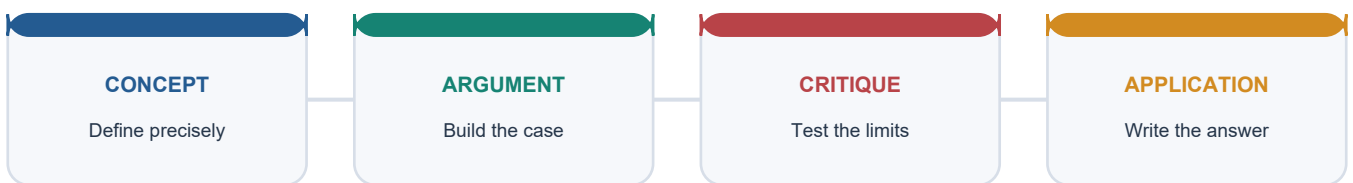


COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Sāṃkhya - Complete Learning Session

UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper I, Section B | 15 teaching sessions, 32 diagnostics, 13 solved PYQs, 6 original Mains models and register notes

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Sāṃkhya - Complete Learning Session

Catalogue identity: Philosophy Optional · Philosophy Paper I - Indian Philosophy · Syllabus item 16. **Official syllabus wording (verbatim, printed spelling retained):** Samkhya; Prakrit; Purusa; Causation; Liberation. **Terminology rule:** the English concept leads; the accurate Sanskrit term in IAST follows immediately in brackets. **Evidence discipline:** doctrine, textual attribution and previous-year wording follow the repository's canonical owners. Model answers are independent learner practice and are never presented as official keys.

Package practice counts

Component	Count
Teaching sessions in the Basic block	15
Core diagnostic multiple-choice questions	24
Remedial diagnostic multiple-choice questions	8
Total diagnostics	32
Solved previous-year questions	13 (10 primary-owned + 3 routed)
Original solved Mains models	6 (2 x 10, 2 x 15, 2 x 20)
Consolidated register parts	14 (A-N)

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

How this Basic block is organised

The fifteen sessions below run in teaching order, not in source order. Each session opens with a definition, gives a gateway idea in plain language, shows the concept before it argues it, then supplies the named evidence, the answer-grabbing line, the must-write keywords, a worked answer-paragraph model, the exam route, the traps and a rapid revision strip.

Everything needed for a complete 10-, 15- or 20-mark answer on any routed question is inside this Basic block. The Optional Advanced block near the end of this document is enrichment; no core answer depends on it.

Session	What it settles	Why it comes here
1	Threefold suffering (duḥkha-traya) and the promise of final cessation	The system is built to answer a practical problem, so the problem comes first
2	System identity: name, texts, enumeration, non-theism	Fixes what "Sāṃkhya" refers to before doctrine is argued
3	Three means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) and the inferential burden	Nothing later can be proved until the instruments of proof are fixed
4	Cognition: the inner instrument (antaḥkaraṇa) and reflection	Explains how an unconscious mind can seem conscious
5	Primordial material nature (prakṛti): what it is and why it is needed	Introduces the first ultimate
6	The five proofs of primordial material nature	Discharges the burden created in Session 3
7	The three qualities (guṇa) and their modification	Supplies the internal mechanism of all evolution
8	Conscious witness (puruṣa): nature and five proofs	Introduces the second ultimate
9	Plurality of witnesses, purposive nature, and empirical self versus witness	Completes the account of selfhood
10	The twenty-five principles (tattva) in exact order	The full cosmological-psychological sequence

Session	What it settles	Why it comes here
11	Subtle body (liṅga-śarīra), transmigration and karma	Explains continuity without making the witness move
12	Pre-existence of the effect (satkāryavāda): the five arguments	The causal thesis
13	Real transformation (pariṇāmavāda) against rival causal theories	Positions Sāṃkhya among competitors
14	Bondage, discriminative knowledge, isolation (kaivalya) and non-theism	The soteriology the system was built for
15	The contact problem, Śaṅkara's critique, inter-school placement and verdict	The evaluative close every high-mark answer needs

SESSION 1 - WHY SĀṂKHYA EXISTS: THREEFOLD SUFFERING AND THE DEMAND FOR FINAL CESSATION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. Sāṃkhya begins from a practical complaint, not from curiosity: living beings are struck by suffering from three directions, ordinary remedies only postpone it, and the system claims that one particular kind of knowledge ends it permanently.

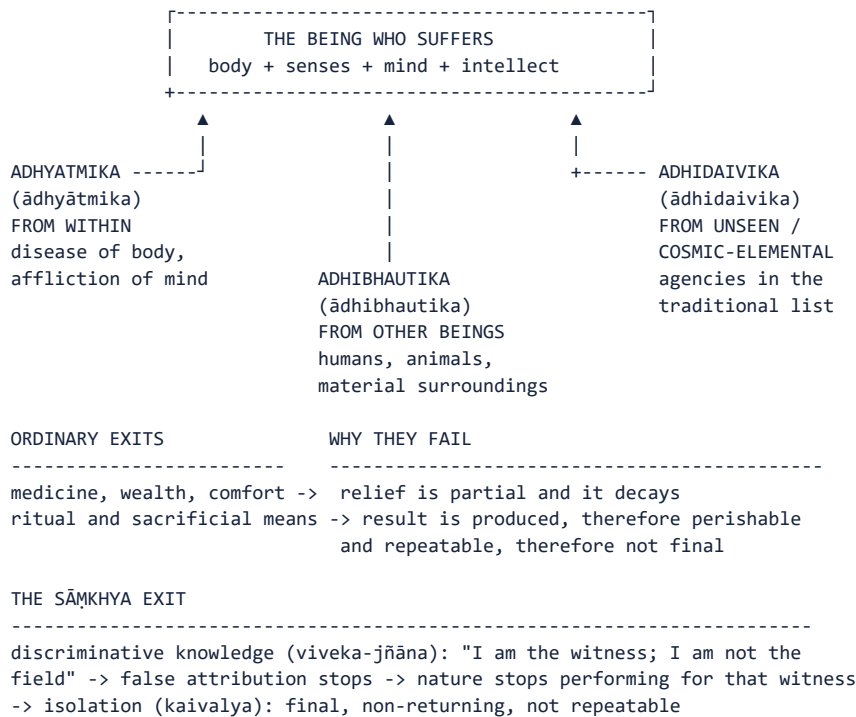
Technical definition. The threefold suffering (**duḥkha-traya**) is the classification of affliction into the internal or psychophysical (**ādhyātmika**), the affliction caused by other beings and the external natural order (**ādhibhautika**), and the affliction attributed to cosmic, elemental or unseen agencies (**ādhidaivika**). Sāṃkhya holds that visible and ritual means give incomplete or temporary relief, and that discriminative knowledge alone yields final, non-returning cessation.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Think of a person with a recurring illness. Painkillers work, but only for a while. A ritual cure may comfort, but the disease returns. Sāṃkhya says the same thing about existence: every remedy that operates *inside* the field of nature is itself made of nature, so it can only rearrange suffering, never abolish it. To end suffering you must step outside the field - and that step is a piece of knowledge, not an action.

That single move explains the whole architecture. If liberation is by knowledge, the system must say exactly *what* is to be known. It answers: know that you are the witness and not the field. Everything else in Sāṃkhya - the two ultimates, the qualities, the twenty-five principles, the theory of causation - exists to make that one discriminative statement true and intelligible.

VISUAL - THE THREE ARROWS OF SUFFERING AND THE ONE EXIT



What the diagram shows: three independent sources of affliction converge on one psychophysical complex; only an exit that is not itself a product of that complex can be final.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

- Suffering is universal and threefold.** The classification is not decorative. It is designed to be exhaustive: whatever afflicts you comes from your own psychophysical constitution, from other beings and the surrounding material order, or from agencies you cannot control or observe. If the list is exhaustive, no remedy that addresses only one arrow can be complete.
- Visible remedies are structurally partial.** Medicine, protection and prosperity operate within the field of nature. They redistribute conditions; they do not remove the possibility of affliction.
- Ritual remedies are structurally impermanent.** Anything *produced* is liable to destruction. A result won by a sacrificial act is a produced result, so it is exhaustible and must be won again. Sāṃkhya therefore treats scripturally promised results as belonging to the same category as visible ones: better, but not final.
- Therefore the required remedy must be non-productive.** It cannot manufacture a new state; it must correct a mistake. A mistake is corrected by knowledge.
- Hence the whole system is enumerative.** "Sāṃkhya" is traditionally connected both with discriminative or right knowledge and with enumeration - fitting a system that promises liberation through the knowledge of twenty-five principles. The list of principles is the content of the liberating knowledge.

Qualification to keep. The threefold diagnosis is a doctrinal framing rather than a separately printed syllabus noun. It earns its place because it explains why liberation, not cosmology, is the organising end of the entire system - and because it is what makes the enumeration of principles a soteriological exercise rather than a taxonomy.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- **Īśvarakṛṣṇa, Sāṃkhyakārikā*** - the earliest extant systematic classical text of the school, and the reference point for the threefold suffering, the proofs, the evolutionary sequence and the account of liberation.
- **The threefold classification itself** - internal (ādhyātmika), from other beings and the environment (ādhībhautika), and from cosmic or unseen agencies (ādhidaivika).
- **The exhaustibility argument against ritual means** - a produced result is perishable, therefore

repeatable, therefore not final.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Sāṃkhya is not primarily a cosmology that happens to end in liberation; it is a soteriology that is forced to become a cosmology, because a system which promises release by knowledge must first specify, exhaustively, what there is to be known.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- threefold suffering (duḥkha-traya)
- internal affliction (ādhyātmika)
- affliction from other beings and surroundings (ādhibhautika)
- affliction from cosmic or unseen agencies (ādhidaivika)
- final and non-returning cessation (ātyantika)
- discriminative knowledge (viveka-jñāna)
- enumeration of twenty-five principles

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Sāṃkhya's metaphysical apparatus is generated by a therapeutic demand, not by speculative interest.

Named evidence. The system opens from the impact of threefold suffering - internal (ādhyātmika), from other beings and the material environment (ādhibhautika), and from cosmic or unseen agencies (ādhidaivika) - and rejects both visible remedies and ritual means as partial or exhaustible.

Analysis. Because a produced result is by definition perishable, no *action* can supply a final cure; only a correction of misidentification can, and a correction of misidentification is knowledge. This is precisely why the school must enumerate principles: the discriminative knowledge that liberates is knowledge that the witness is not any of the twenty-four evolutes.

Qualification. The point is not that Sāṃkhya despises ordinary or ritual remedies; it grades them. They are effective within nature and ineffective against the structural condition that makes affliction recur, which is why the school treats them as preliminary rather than false.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

This session is not itself a printed question, but it supplies the opening move for every liberation-facing routed question - most directly **2018 Q5(e)** on the plurality of witnesses, where "whose bondage and whose release?" is the decisive pressure, and **2023 Q5(b)** on Śaṃkara's criticism, where the practical stake of the dualism must be visible before the relation problem is raised.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** present the threefold suffering as a printed syllabus term; present it as the doctrinal starting point that explains why the syllabus clause ends with "Liberation".
- Do **not** say Sāṃkhya rejects Vedic means as false. It grades them as exhaustible.
- Do **not** import Buddhist "first noble truth" language. The classifications differ, and the Sāṃkhya remedy is discriminative knowledge of two ultimates, not the eightfold discipline.

RAPID REVISION

- Three arrows: internal · from beings and surroundings · from unseen or cosmic agencies.
- Visible remedies are partial; ritual results are produced and therefore exhaustible.
- A final cure must correct a mistake, not manufacture a state -> knowledge, not action.
- Knowledge must have content -> enumeration of twenty-five principles.
- One line: *the system enumerates because it promises release by discrimination.*

SESSION 2 - SYSTEM IDENTITY: NAME, TEXTS, SCOPE AND THE NON-THEISTIC FRAME

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. "Classical Sāṃkhya" means one specific, argued position - the dualism of one unconscious primordial nature and many inactive conscious witnesses, with real evolution and no creator - as set out in the earliest surviving systematic text of the school.

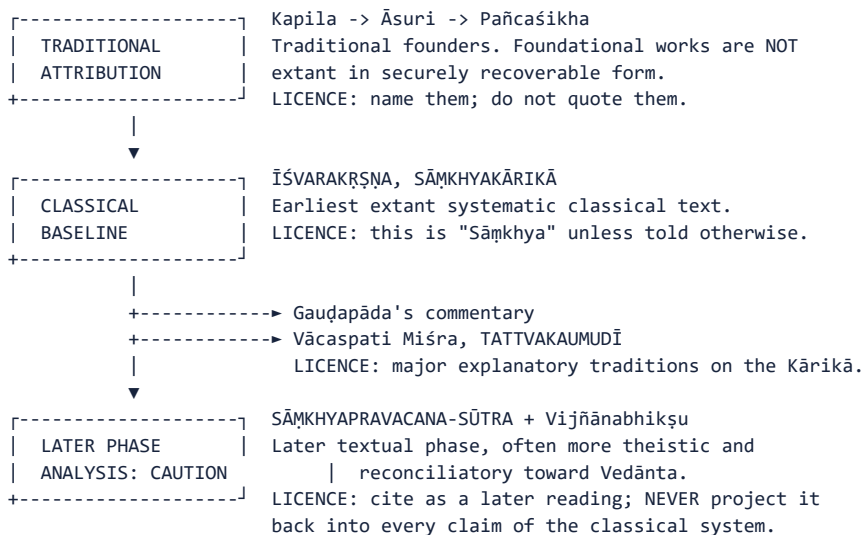
Technical definition. Classical Sāṃkhya is the system of Īśvarakṛṣṇa's *Sāṃkhyakārikā*: a realist dualism of primordial material nature (**prakṛti**) and conscious witness (**puruṣa**), committed to the pre-existence of the effect in its material cause (**satkāryavāda**) in the form of real transformation (**pariṇāmavāda**), to a plurality of witnesses, and to a non-theistic (**nirīśvara**) account of world, bondage and release.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

There is a trap hidden in the word "Sāṃkhya". Sāṃkhya-like ideas appear in medical, epic and Upaniṣadic contexts, and later authors rewrite the school in a theistic direction. If you quote all of these as one thing, your answer becomes indefensible. So fix the reference first: when the examiner writes "Sāṃkhya", the default is the *Sāṃkhyakārikā* system. Anything earlier is a precursor and anything later is a development, and both must be labelled as such.

VISUAL - THE TEXTUAL LADDER AND WHAT EACH RUNG LICENCES

TIME ->



What the diagram shows: four rungs with four different permissions. Most errors in this topic are permission errors - using a later theistic reading to describe the classical non-theistic system.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

- 1. Traditional lineage, honest limits.** Tradition associates the school with Kapila, followed by Āsuri and Pañcaśikha. Their foundational works are not extant in securely recoverable form, so they are names in a lineage rather than quotable authorities.
- 2. The classical baseline.** The earliest extant systematic classical text is Īśvarakṛṣṇa's *Sāṃkhyakārikā*, with major explanatory traditions including Gauḍapāda's commentary and Vācaspati Miśra's *Tattvakaumudī*.
- 3. The later phase must be labelled.** The *Sāṃkhyapravacana-sūtra* and Vijñānabhikṣu's commentary represent a later textual and often more theistic phase. They must not be projected uncritically back into every claim of the classical Kārikā system.
- 4. What the name signals.** "Sāṃkhya" is traditionally connected both with discriminative or right knowledge and with enumeration. Both senses fit a system that seeks liberation through knowledge of twenty-five principles.

5. **Non-theism, stated precisely.** In the classical system no God is required for either bondage or liberation. The safest formulation is that the position is *non-theistic* or *God-unproved* rather than a demonstration that no divine being could exist: primordial material nature and conscious witnesses are held sufficient for the explanatory work.

6. **The boundary with Yoga.** Sāṃkhya supplies the dualist metaphysics of primordial nature and many witnesses that classical Yoga substantially shares. Yoga then develops a distinct practical psychology - mind-field, afflictions, meditative absorption, the eight-limbed discipline, and a special conscious witness identified as God. Therefore Yoga is a *bounded comparison* in a Sāṃkhya answer, never a source of Sāṃkhya doctrine.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

Item	Exact status	Answer use
Kapila, Āsuri, Pañcaśikha	Traditional founders; foundational works not securely recoverable	Name the lineage; do not attribute arguments
Īśvarakṛṣṇa, <i>Sāṃkhyakārikā</i>	Earliest extant systematic classical text	The controlling reference for every claim
Gauḍapāda's commentary	Major explanatory tradition on the Kārikā	Supporting commentarial authority
Vācaspati Miśra, <i>Tattvakaumudī</i>	Major commentary	Supporting commentarial authority
<i>Sāṃkhyapravacana-sūtra</i> ; Vijñānabhikṣu	Later, often more theistic phase	Cite only as a labelled later development

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The first discipline in writing on Sāṃkhya is chronological hygiene: the school's classical identity is fixed by the *Sāṃkhyakārikā*, so a later theistic commentary cannot be used to soften the non-theism that the classical system deliberately argues for.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Īśvarakṛṣṇa's *Sāṃkhyakārikā**
- Vācaspati Miśra's *Tattvakaumudī**
- later theistic phase (Vijñānabhikṣu)
- non-theistic (nirīśvara)
- enumeration and discriminative knowledge
- chief principle (pradhāna)
- bounded comparison with Yoga

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Precision about which Sāṃkhya is being discussed is itself a philosophical commitment, not a bibliographic courtesy.

Named evidence. Classical Sāṃkhya is fixed by Īśvarakṛṣṇa's *Sāṃkhyakārikā* and its commentarial tradition, including Vācaspati Miśra's *Tattvakaumudī*, while the *Sāṃkhyapravacana-sūtra* and Vijñānabhikṣu represent a later and often more theistic phase.

Analysis. The difference is doctrinally decisive: the classical system argues that primordial nature and plural witnesses are jointly sufficient to explain world, bondage and release, so importing a later God-affirming reading does not merely add a thesis - it removes the explanatory economy that the classical arguments were built to establish.

Qualification. The later phase is not thereby worthless; it is a legitimate development that shows the pressure Vedāntic theism exerted on the school. It simply cannot be used as evidence about what Īśvarakṛṣṇa's system held.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

Directly load-bearing for **2025 Q7(a)** on why Śaṃkara treats Sāṃkhya as his chief opponent (**pradhāna malla**): the answer only works if "Sāṃkhya" means the classical non-theistic system with an unconscious first principle. It also protects **2024 Q7(a)**, which explicitly asks for the evolution "as propounded in *Sāṃkhyakārikā*".

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** call classical Sāṃkhya "atheistic" without qualification; write **non-theistic** or **God-unproved**, and then give the arguments.
- Do **not** use Vijñānabhikṣu's theism as evidence about the Kārikā system.
- Do **not** treat "unorthodox" as a synonym for non-theistic; Sāṃkhya is an orthodox (āstika) school that nevertheless does not require a creator.
- Do **not** blur Sāṃkhya and Yoga. Yoga owns the mind-field, afflictions, eight limbs, meditative absorption and God as a special witness.

RAPID REVISION

- Four rungs: traditional founders -> *Sāṃkhyakārikā* □ -> commentaries -> later theistic phase.
- "Sāṃkhya" = enumeration + discriminative knowledge; both senses fit twenty-five principles.
- Classical position: non-theistic, not anti-theistic-by-proof.
- Orthodox school, no creator. Yoga is a bounded comparison, not a source.

SESSION 3 - THREE MEANS OF VALID KNOWLEDGE AND THE INFERENTIAL BURDEN

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. Sāṃkhya allows only three ways of knowing anything. That decision creates a problem it must then solve, because the two things the system most needs - primordial nature and the witness - cannot be seen.

Technical definition. Sāṃkhya admits exactly three means of valid knowledge (**pramāṇa**): perception (**dr̥ṣṭa** / **pratyakṣa**), inference (**anumāna**) and reliable verbal testimony (**āptavacana** / **śabda**). Other candidates - comparison (**upamāna**), postulation (**arthāpatti**), non-apprehension (**anupalabdhi**), inclusion or probability (**sambhava**) and traditional report (**aitihya**) - are not dismissed as useless but reduced to, or included within, these three.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Imagine a court that accepts only three kinds of evidence: what the witness saw, what can be validly inferred, and the testimony of a reliable authority. Now the court must decide a case about something nobody can ever see. It cannot invent a fourth kind of evidence without abandoning its own rule. So it must show that inference alone - of a particular, carefully specified kind - is strong enough to reach the invisible defendant.

That is exactly Sāṃkhya's situation, and it is why the proofs of primordial nature and of the witness are not rhetorical flourishes. They are the discharge of a debt the school incurred when it restricted the instruments of knowledge to three.

VISUAL - THE THREE INSTRUMENTS, THE REDUCTIONS, AND THE BURDEN

ADMITTED (exactly three)	REDUCED (not rejected as useless)
1 PERCEPTION (pratyakṣa) ascertainment with respect to a presented object through the senses in contact with it	upamāna -> inference / testimony arthāpatti -> inference anupalabdhi -> perception's failure-conditions sambhava -> inference aitihya -> testimony when reliable, otherwise rejected
2 INFERENCE (anumāna) - THREE KINDS + pūrvavat cause/antecedent -> effect + śeṣavat effect/residue -> cause + sāmānyato-dṛṣṭa general correlation, connection NOT itself perceived	e.g. clouds -> rain e.g. one drop -> the sea is salty e.g. sun in different positions -> the sun moves
3 RELIABLE TESTIMONY (āptavacana / śabda) word of a non-defective source, pre-eminently Veda/śruti, where the object is not otherwise easily known	

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+-----+
| THE BURDEN THIS CREATES |
| root nature (mūla-prakṛti) and witness (puruṣa) are BEYOND THE SENSES |
| (atīndriya) -> perception cannot reach them |
| testimony alone would beg the question against non-Vedic opponents |
| => THE WHOLE WEIGHT FALLS ON SĀMĀNYATO-DṚṢṬA INFERENCE |
+-----+

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What the diagram shows: the left column is what Sāṃkhya keeps, the right column is what it absorbs, and the box is the debt that the five proofs of nature and the five proofs of the witness are built to repay.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

The three definitions, precisely.

- **Perception** is the ascertainment with respect to a presented object (**pratiṣayādhyavasāya**) of objects through the sense-capacities in contact with them.
- **Inference** is threefold, as tabulated above.
- **Reliable testimony** is the word of a trustworthy source, pre-eminently Veda or **śruti**, where the speaker or text is not defective and the object is not otherwise easily known.

Why the reductions matter. Sāṃkhya is not being economical for its own sake. Each reduction is an argued claim:

Candidate	Reduced to	Reason in one line
comparison (upamāna)	inference / testimony	Similarity works because a prior verbal report is applied inferentially to a present case.
postulation (arthāpatti)	inference	Postulation is inference to the best explanatory condition; no separate instrument is needed.
non-apprehension (anupalabdhi)	perception's failure-conditions	Non-perception means the conditions for perceiving are absent or the object is unavailable.
inclusion / probability (sambhava)	inference	Moving from a larger unit to a smaller or probable implication is inferential dependence.
traditional report (aitihya)	testimony when reliable	Mere tradition has force only when it becomes trustworthy verbal cognition.

Why non-perception does not refute. Sāṃkhya lists the standard causes of non-perception: excessive distance, excessive proximity, defect of the organ, inattention of mind, subtlety (**saukṣmya**), obstruction by an intervening object, being overpowered by something else, and admixture with like things. Root nature's imperceptibility is assigned to **subtlety**; the witness is likewise beyond the senses rather than non-existent. This is the single most important defensive move in the topic: *imperceptibility is a fact about the knower's instruments, not a proof of absence.*

Why general-correlation inference is decisive. Ordinary inference of the first two kinds needs the invariable relation (**vyāpti**) to be established by observing both terms together. That is impossible for a term never observed at all. General-correlation inference (**sāmānyato-dṛṣṭa**) can reach such a term because it does not require the two terms to

be seen together; it works through a general correlation of *kinds*. Since perception cannot reach what is beyond the senses, and testimony alone would beg the question against non-Vedic opponents, the argumentative burden falls here.

Objections and replies.

- **Cārvāka objection.** The invariable relation cannot be secured for a term never perceived; inference to root nature or the witness is therefore speculative. **Reply.** Strict perceptualism cannot explain ordinary causal reasoning either; manifest, dependent, purposive and objectifiable experience demands an unmanifest material ground and a conscious witness.

- **Nyāya objection.** General-correlation inference is legitimate, but Sāṃkhya overuses it. A plurality of atoms plus an intelligent God explains the ordered world more economically than an unobservable material first cause. **Reply.** The continuity between cause and effect, the qualitative character of experience and the determinacy of production are better explained by a single material nature; adding God is unnecessary because it does not explain the material continuity itself.

Presupposition to state openly. Sāṃkhya presupposes that inference from general correlation can legitimately reach an entity of a kind never itself observed as a sense-object. If that presupposition is denied, the five proofs of primordial nature become analogical guesses rather than philosophical inferences.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- **Three-instrument scheme** with the five named reductions.
- **The threefold division of inference**, with the sun's changing positions as the standard example of general-correlation inference.
- **The eight causes of non-perception**, with subtlety assigned to root nature.
- **The named objectors:** Cārvāka on the invariable relation; Nyāya on economy and an intelligent maker.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Sāṃkhya's epistemology is not a preface to its metaphysics but a constraint upon it: by admitting only three instruments of knowledge, the school obliges itself to reach its two ultimates by general-correlation inference alone, and every later proof is the payment of that self-imposed debt.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **perception (pratyakṣa) as prativīṣayādhyavasāya**
- **inference (anumāna): pūrvavat · śeṣavat · sāmānyato-dṛṣṭa**
- **reliable testimony (āptavacana / śabda)**
- **beyond the senses (atīndriya)**
- **subtlety (saukṣmya)**
- **invariable relation (vyāpti)**
- **reduction of upamāna, arthāpatti, anupalabdhi, sambhava, aitiḥya**

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Sāṃkhya's restriction to three instruments of knowledge is what makes its metaphysical proofs necessary rather than ornamental.

Named evidence. The school admits only perception, inference and reliable testimony, reducing comparison, postulation, non-apprehension, inclusion and traditional report to these three; and it classes root nature's imperceptibility under subtlety (**saukṣmya**) in the standard list of eight causes of non-perception.

Analysis. Because both ultimates are beyond the senses and testimony would be question-begging against a non-Vedic opponent, the entire evidential weight falls on general-correlation inference (**sāmānyato-dṛṣṭa**), which alone can reach a term whose invariable relation was never observed directly. The five proofs of nature and the five

proofs of the witness are therefore the exact shape this epistemology forces.

Qualification. The move is powerful but not cost-free: it rests on the presupposition that a general correlation of kinds can license an inference to an entity of a kind never observed, and it is precisely this presupposition that Cārvāka denies and Nyāya accepts while accusing Sāṃkhya of over-extending it.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

Load-bearing for **2019 Q8(c)** - "which proof actually shows that there can be only one nature?" - because the answer must first explain *why* nature has to be proved at all. It also strengthens **2022 Q5(a)** on the proofs for the witness: the examiner's word "evaluate" is best met by showing that the proofs share one inferential form.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** write that Sāṃkhya *rejects* comparison or postulation. It **reduces** them.
- Do **not** say root nature is imperceptible because it does not exist; the school assigns its imperceptibility to **subtlety** within a standard eight-item list.
- Do **not** attribute six instruments (an Advaita count) or four (the classical Nyāya count) to Sāṃkhya.
- Do **not** describe general-correlation inference as "vague inference". It is a technical kind defined by an unperceived connection between the terms.

RAPID REVISION

- Three instruments: perception · inference · reliable testimony.
- Five reductions: comparison, postulation, non-apprehension, inclusion, traditional report.
- Inference is threefold; general-correlation inference carries the metaphysics.
- Eight causes of non-perception; root nature falls under subtlety.
- One line: *three instruments in, two invisible ultimates to prove, therefore inference does all the work.*

SESSION 4 - COGNITION: THE INNER INSTRUMENT, REFLECTION AND APPARENT AGENCY

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. In Sāṃkhya the mind is not conscious and consciousness does not think. Knowing happens when an insentient mental organ takes the shape of an object and the witness's light falls on it - so the event *looks* like a conscious mind knowing, although neither of its two components is that.

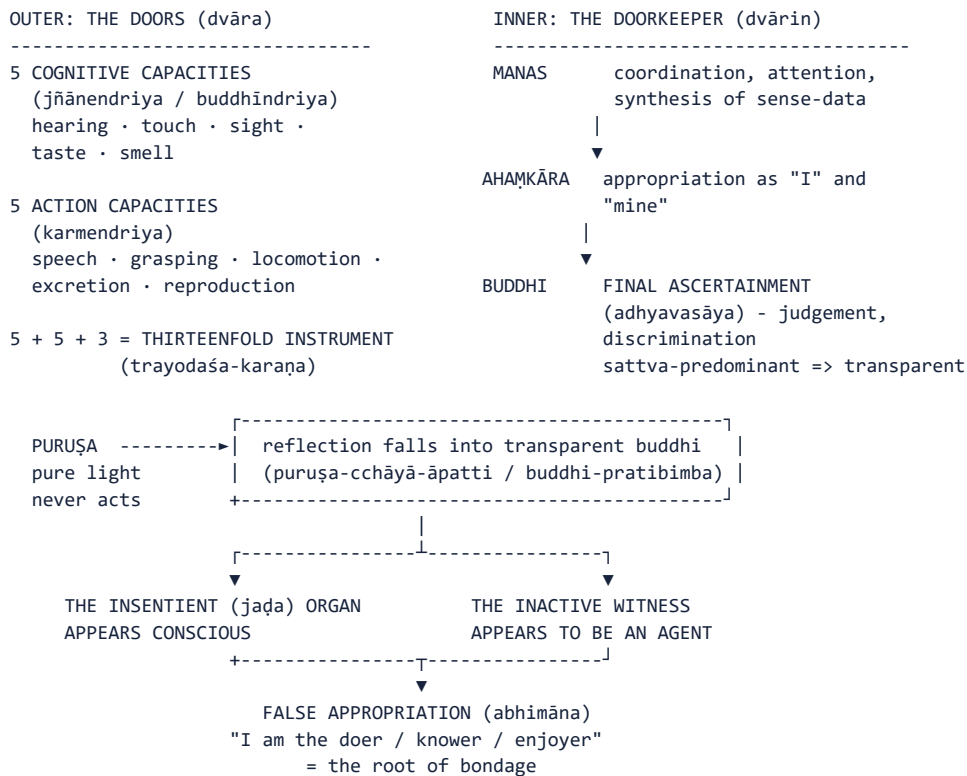
Technical definition. The inner instrument (**antaḥkaraṇa**) has three functions - determinative intellect (**buddhi**), the I-maker (**ahaṃkāra**) and the coordinating mind (**manas**). With the five cognitive capacities and five action capacities it forms the thirteenfold instrument (**trayodaśa-karaṇa**). Intellect alone makes the final ascertainment (**adhyavasāya**). Being predominantly luminous (**sattva**-predominant), intellect receives the reflection of the witness (**puruṣa-cchāyā-āpatti** / **buddhi-pratibimba**), and this reflection generates false appropriation (**abhimāna**) - "I am the doer, knower, enjoyer" - which is the psychological root of bondage.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Think of a clean mirror in a dark room and a lamp outside the doorway. The mirror cannot glow; the lamp cannot take shapes. But put them in the right relation and you get something that looks exactly like a glowing image. Sāṃkhya says empirical knowing is that: the intellect takes the shape of the object, the witness supplies the light, and the resulting cognition seems to be a conscious mind's own act.

Two mistakes then become natural. The insentient organ appears conscious, and the inactive witness appears to be an agent. Both mistakes are one mistake seen from two ends - and undoing it is what liberation means.

VISUAL - THE THIRTEENFOLD INSTRUMENT AND THE TWO-WAY MISTAKE



What the diagram shows: a strict division of labour on top, a single reflection event in the middle, and a symmetrical two-way misattribution at the bottom. The whole of Sāṃkhya soteriology is the reversal of that bottom row.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

- Three inner functions, sharply distinguished.** Intellect determines and ascertains; the I-maker appropriates; the mind coordinates. Writing them as three synonyms for "mind" destroys the argument.
- Doors and doorkeeper.** The external faculties function as doors (**dvāra**); the inner organ functions as doorkeeper (**dvārin**) because it receives, coordinates and determines what enters cognition. Sense-capacities present; only intellect concludes.
- Only intellect ascertains.** Final ascertainment (**adhyavasāya**) belongs to intellect alone. This matters for the exam because the 2024 question asks precisely for the difference between cosmic intellect, determinative intellect and the I-maker.
- Why intellect and not another organ receives the reflection.** Intellect is **sattva**-predominant and therefore transparent. Transparency is what makes reflection possible; a **tamas**-heavy organ would obstruct rather than receive.
- The two-way appearance.** Through conjunction or the semblance of conjunction, the unconscious internal instrument appears conscious, while the inactive witness appears to be an agent. Productive agency belongs to the qualities and evolutes of nature; witnessing belongs to the witness.
- From reflection to bondage.** The reflection generates false appropriation (**abhimāna**) - "I am the doer/knower/enjoyer" - and that appropriation is the psychological root of bondage. Note the exact ordering: reflection is a structural fact, appropriation is the error, bondage is the consequence.

Answer-level formulation. For Sāṃkhya the mind does not know by itself and the witness does not act by itself; empirical knowing is a reflected-consciousness event located in the intellect.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

Term	Precise function
buddhi	final ascertainment (adhyavasāya), judgement, discrimination
ahaṁkāra	appropriation as "I" and "mine"
manas	coordination, attention, synthesis of sense-data
five cognitive capacities	access to sound, touch, form, taste and smell
five action capacities	speech, grasping, locomotion, excretion, reproduction
dvāra / dvārin	doors versus doorkeeper
buddhi-pratibimba	reflection of the witness in transparent intellect
abhimāna	false appropriation; psychological root of bondage
jaḍa	insentient - the standing description of every evolute

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Sāṃkhya's most modern-sounding claim is that cognition and consciousness are different things: the intellect processes without being aware, the witness is aware without processing, and what we call a conscious thought is the borrowed light of the second falling on the first.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- inner instrument (**antaḥkaraṇa**)
- thirteenfold instrument (**trayodaśa-karaṇa**)
- final ascertainment (**adhyavasāya**)
- doors and doorkeeper (**dvāra / dvārin**)
- reflection in intellect (**buddhi-pratibimba**)
- false appropriation (**abhimāna**)
- insentient (**jaḍa**)

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Sāṃkhya explains the appearance of a conscious mind without granting consciousness to any mental organ.

Named evidence. The inner instrument is threefold - intellect, I-maker and mind - and with ten external capacities forms the thirteenfold instrument; the external faculties are doors and the inner organ the doorkeeper; and intellect, being **sattva**-predominant and therefore transparent, receives the reflection of the witness.

Analysis. This yields a symmetrical illusion rather than a single one: the insentient organ appears conscious and the inactive witness appears to be an agent, and the false appropriation "I am the doer" is generated exactly at the junction. The school therefore has a psychological mechanism for bondage, not merely a metaphysical label for it.

Qualification. The mechanism is explanatory only if reflection into an insentient medium is itself intelligible; critics reply that a reflection which changes nothing in either relatum cannot generate a genuine cognitive event, and Sāṃkhya's answer at this point is analogical rather than demonstrative.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

Essential to **2019 Q5(d)** on the metaphysical status of the empirical self and the witness, since the empirical self just is the witness as conditioned through intellect. Essential again to **2024 Q7(a)**, whose second half asks explicitly for the difference between cosmic intellect, determinative intellect and the I-maker.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** say the mind (**manas**) determines or judges. It coordinates; intellect determines.
- Do **not** say the witness knows objects directly. The witness illuminates the intellect's operations.

- Do **not** describe the reflection as a real modification of the witness; that would make bondage real and liberation impossible.
- Do **not** count the thirteenfold instrument as thirteen *tattvas* separate from the twenty-five; the instrument is a functional grouping drawn from within the list.

RAPID REVISION

- Inner instrument: intellect determines · I-maker appropriates · mind coordinates.
- Thirteenfold instrument = 3 inner + 5 cognitive + 5 action capacities.
- Doors present; the doorkeeper decides.
- Transparent intellect receives the witness's reflection -> false appropriation -> bondage.
- One line: *knowing is processing plus borrowed light, and mistaking the two for one is bondage.*

SESSION 5 - PRIMORDIAL MATERIAL NATURE: WHAT IT IS AND WHY THE SYSTEM NEEDS IT

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. Primordial material nature is the one unconscious stuff out of which everything objective evolves - not only bodies and elements, but also intellect, ego, mind and the senses. It is never created and never perceived; it is inferred as the root of everything that changes.

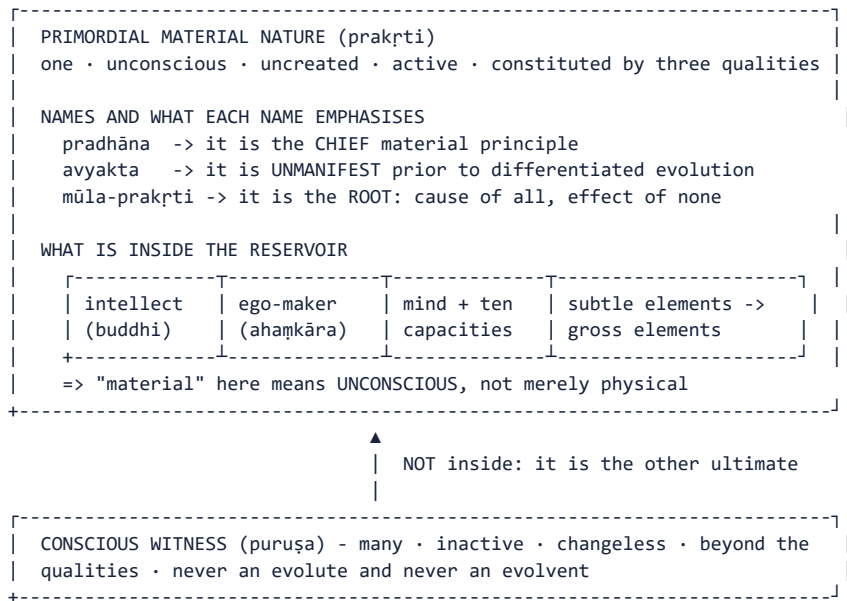
Technical definition. Primordial material nature (**prakṛti**) is the unmanifest, unconscious, primordial material principle from which the entire objective and psychophysical world evolves. It is called the chief principle (**pradhāna**) because it is the primary material basis of all empirical manifestation, and the unmanifest (**avyakta**) because in its primordial condition it is not yet differentiated into manifest principles. It is the ultimate material cause of the world within Sāṃkhya's dualist ontology.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Two words will keep you out of trouble here. First, *material* in Sāṃkhya does not mean "physical". Intellect, ego, mind and the senses are all products of nature; they are unconscious machinery, however subtle. Second, *root* does not mean "first event". Nature is not a beginning in time; it is the standing condition from which manifestation issues whenever equilibrium is disturbed.

So when you write "nature", picture a single reservoir of unconscious potency that includes the mind, not a heap of matter opposed to the mind. Getting this right prevents the commonest error in the topic: reading Sāṃkhya as a mind-body dualism instead of a consciousness-nature dualism.

VISUAL - WHAT "NATURE" COVERS AND WHAT IT EXCLUDES



What the diagram shows: the dividing line in Sāṃkhya does not run between mind and body - it runs between everything unconscious, however subtle, and pure consciousness.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

Why a second principle is required at all.

1. The world is marked by plurality, transformation, dependence, purposiveness and structured manifestation.
2. A school that accepts real effects, real bondage and real liberation needs a real material source from which empirical diversity emerges. Sāṃkhya is a realist; it cannot dissolve the world into appearance.
3. The witness is changeless and inactive, so it cannot itself become the world. A changeless principle that turned into the world would not be changeless.
4. Therefore a second principle is required: active but unconscious nature.

The three names, and what each licenses in an answer.

Name	What it emphasises	Answer use
prakṛti	the productive nature of the principle	the general term
pradhāna	it is the <i>chief</i> material principle	Śaṅkara's target term in pradhāna māla
avyakta	it is <i>unmanifest</i> before differentiation	contrasts with the manifest (vyakta) evolutes
mūla-prakṛti	it is <i>root</i> : cause of all, effect of none	fixes its place in the fourfold classification

Exam-safe definition. Nature is the unmanifest chief principle (**avyakta pradhāna**), constituted by the three qualities.

The precise scope of "material". Nature is not "matter" in the modern physicalist sense. It includes the roots of intellect, ego, mind, the senses, the subtle elements and the gross elements. This is why Sāṃkhya can be a dualism and still hold that all mental functioning is unconscious machinery.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- **The four names** - nature, chief principle, unmanifest, root nature - with their distinct emphases.
- **The uncreatedness claim** - nature is not itself produced; it is the ultimate material cause within the dualist ontology.
- **The scope claim** - intellect, ego, mind, capacities, subtle and gross elements are all

evolutes of nature.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Sāṃkhya's dualism is often misdescribed as mind against matter; in fact it places intellect, ego and mind firmly on the side of unconscious nature, so the real fault-line runs between everything that changes and the one thing that merely watches.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- primordial material nature (*prakṛti*)
- chief principle (*pradhāna*)
- unmanifest (*avyakta*) versus manifest (*vyakta*)
- root nature (*mūla-prakṛti*)
- ultimate material cause
- unconscious, not merely physical

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. The postulation of primordial material nature is forced by Sāṃkhya's realism, not chosen for elegance.

Named evidence. Nature is defined as the unmanifest chief principle (*avyakta pradhāna*), uncreated, constituted by the three qualities, and comprehending the roots of intellect, ego, mind, the capacities, and the subtle and gross elements.

Analysis. Because the witness is changeless and inactive, it cannot become the world; and because Sāṃkhya refuses to treat the world as mere appearance, the transformation has to be located somewhere real. A single unconscious productive principle is the minimum that satisfies both constraints, which is why nature is inferred rather than merely assumed.

Qualification. The economy is genuine but purchased at a price: once intellect and ego are placed inside nature, Sāṃkhya must explain how anything unconscious can present an ordered experience at all - the question that Sessions 4, 9 and 15 return to.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

The definitional spine for **2019 Q8(c)** and **2021 Q6(b)**, and the indispensable opening for **2024 Q7(a)** on the evolution of nature. It also supplies the term Śaṅkara actually attacks in **2025 Q7(a)**: the chief principle (*pradhāna*).

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** equate nature with matter as opposed to mind. Mind is *inside* nature.
- Do **not** call nature "created" or "produced". It is the root: cause of all, effect of none.
- Do **not** treat "unmanifest" as a synonym for "non-existent". It means undifferentiated.
- Do **not** substitute Advaita's *māyā* for nature. Nature really transforms; *māyā* produces appearance.

RAPID REVISION

- One, unconscious, uncreated, active, constituted by three qualities.
- Four names: nature · chief principle · unmanifest · root nature.
- Contains intellect, ego, mind, capacities, subtle and gross elements.
- Needed because a changeless witness cannot become a changing world.
- One line: *the unmanifest chief principle constituted by the three qualities.*

SESSION 6 - THE FIVE PROOFS OF PRIMORDIAL NATURE AND THE ONE-NATURE VERDICT

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. Since nature cannot be seen, Sāṃkhya gives five inferences that together argue there must be one unmanifest material root. One of these five does a job the others cannot: it shows the root must be *single*.

Technical definition. The five standard arguments are: from the finitude and determinateness of things (**bhedānām parimāṇāt**); from the uniformity running through effects (**samanvayāt**); from operation due to causal power (**śaktiṭaḥ pravṛtteś ca**); from the distinction between cause and effect (**kāraṇa-kārya-vibhāgāt**); and from the undivided source of the diversified universe (**avibhāgāt vaiśvarūpyasya**). The fifth is the proof that establishes there can be only one nature.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Do not learn these as five interchangeable slogans. Learn them as five different *jobs*:

- one argues from **limits** (things are finite, so something subtler underlies them);
- one argues from **pattern** (effects hang together, so they share a matrix);
- one argues from **power** (only a potent cause operates, so a competent source exists);
- one argues from **stages** (manifest effect implies unmanifest cause);
- one argues from **unity in diversity** - and only that one delivers *singularity*.

The 2019 examiner asked exactly this: *which* proof shows nature is one? If you have learned five slogans you will guess. If you have learned five jobs you will answer instantly.

VISUAL - FIVE PROOFS, FIVE JOBS, ONE VERDICT

PROOF	WHAT IT ARGUES FROM	WHAT IT DELIVERS
1 bhedānām parimāṇāt "from the finitude of things"	finitude, delimitation, measurability	a SUBTLER GROUND beneath limitation
2 samanvayāt "from uniformity in effects"	order and common pattern across diverse products	a COMMON MATERIAL BASIS
3 śaktiṭaḥ pravṛtteś ca "from operation due to power"	effects arise only through a cause with the relevant power (śakti)	a PRODUCTIVE POWER adequate to all manifest effects
4 kāraṇa-kārya-vibhāgāt "from the cause-effect distinction"	cause and effect are distinguishable stages	an UNMANIFEST CAUSAL MATRIX distinct from the manifest order
5 avibhāgāt vaiśvarūpyasya "from the undivided source of the diversified universe"	the diversified world is ONE INTERCONNECTED COSMOS	=> THE ROOT MUST BE => **ONE** => 2019 Q8(c) ANSWER

THE BRIDGE THE EXAMINER WANTS AFTER NAMING PROOF 5:

plurality at the root would defeat the very inference that took us there -
if the source were many disconnected ultimates, the cosmos would not be
the ONE interconnected whole from whose undividedness we reasoned back.

What the diagram shows: four proofs establish that there is an unmanifest material root; only the fifth constrains how many such roots there can be.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

(1) From the finitude and determinateness of things - bhedānām parimāṇāt. Empirical things are many, finite, delimited and measurable. What is finite and determinate points beyond itself to a more fundamental source from which such determinate forms arise; the manifold world therefore requires a common antecedent material ground. The force of the argument is not merely "every effect has a cause", but that *the limited and differentiated presuppose a subtler ground from which limitation and differentiation emerge*.

(2) From the uniformity running through effects - samanvayāt. Effects display an underlying order and common pattern; diverse products nevertheless reveal continuity of constitution and dependence. Such systematic coherence

suggests a common material basis. This is an argument from *coordinated* diversity: if effects hang together, they are likely rooted in one underlying matrix.

(3) From operation due to causal power - śaktiḥ pravṛtteś ca. Effects arise through the operation of a cause possessing the relevant power (śakti). Evolution is manifestation of what the potent cause can produce; an impotent or unrelated source cannot generate a determinate effect. Therefore the world-process presupposes an underlying productive power capable of the full range of manifest effects.

Textual control - write this if you can. The standard reading of *Sāṃkhyakārikā* 15 is śaktiḥ pravṛtteś ca, not kāryataḥ pravṛtteḥ. The argument is from causal power and operation, **not** from conscious purposive planning. Getting this right is what stops the proof collapsing into a design argument - which would be fatal for a non-theistic system.

(4) From the distinction between cause and effect - kāraṇa-kārya-vibhāgāt. Cause and effect are distinguishable stages: the unmanifest source and the manifest product are not identical in appearance. If effects are manifest, multiple and differentiated, their cause must be a more basic, prior and subtler condition. The point is not total disconnection; cause and effect are distinguishable without being unrelated.

(5) From the undivided source of the diversified universe - avibhāgāt vaiśvarūpyasya. The world is astonishingly diverse, yet this diversity forms **one interconnected cosmos**. A diversified whole points back to an undivided source in which later differentiations are not yet separated. Therefore there must be an original unmanifest, undivided root of the whole world-process. **This is the proof that shows nature must be ONE**, and it is the strongest anti-pluralist argument at the level of material causation in the system.

The 2019 answer, stated exactly. The proof is **avibhāgāt vaiśvarūpyasya**. Reason: if the entire articulated universe emerges from an undivided source, that source must itself be singular, not many independent primal materials. In a ten-marker, do not merely name the proof - add the logical bridge: *plurality at the root would undermine the very inference to an undivided source of total cosmic diversity*.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- All five Sanskrit proof-names, each with its English gloss.
- *Sāṃkhyakārikā* 15 and the correct reading śaktiḥ pravṛtteś ca.
- The explicit verdict that the fifth proof, and only the fifth, delivers singularity.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Four of Sāṃkhya's proofs establish *that* there is an unmanifest material root; only the argument from the undivided source of a diversified universe establishes *how many* there can be, which is why it alone answers the question of nature's unity.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **bhedānām parimāṇāt**
- **samanvayāt**
- **śaktiḥ pravṛtteś ca** (*Sāṃkhyakārikā* 15)
- **kāraṇa-kārya-vibhāgāt**
- **avibhāgāt vaiśvarūpyasya** - the one-nature proof
- **causal power (śakti)**
- **undivided source of a diversified cosmos**

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Among the five inferences for primordial nature, only the argument from the undivided source of the diversified universe (**avibhāgāt vaiśvarūpyasya**) proves that nature is one.

Named evidence. The first four proofs reason from finitude, from uniformity across effects, from operation due to causal power as read in *Sāṃkhyakārikā* 15, and from the distinction between manifest effect and unmanifest cause; the fifth reasons from the fact that cosmic diversity forms a single interconnected whole.

Analysis. The first four are all compatible with a plurality of material roots - several reservoirs could each be subtler than their products, exhibit pattern, possess power and differ from their effects. Only the fifth makes unity itself the premise, so that admitting many roots would destroy the very undividedness from which the inference proceeds.

Qualification. The argument is decisive only within Sāṃkhya's own inferential licence: it assumes that the interconnectedness we observe is genuine and traces back to a single origin rather than to a coordination among several, which is exactly the assumption a Nyāya atomist declines to grant.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

2019 Q8(c) asks this question verbatim - "Which Sāṃkhya proof for the existence of Prakṛti actually shows that there can be only one Prakṛti? Justify your answer." Proof 3 also matters for **2025 Q7(a)**, because Śaṃkara's charge that unconscious nature cannot act purposively is answered by showing the proof is from *power*, not from planning.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** name proof 1 or proof 2 as the one-nature proof. They establish a root, not its unity.
- Do **not** render proof 3 as "from purposive activity". Write ****from operation due to causal power****; the misreading turns a non-theistic system into a design argument.
- Do **not** answer 2019 with only the proof-name. The marks are in the bridge sentence.
- Do **not** confuse "one nature" with "one witness". Nature is one; witnesses are many.

RAPID REVISION

- Five names in order: finitude · uniformity · power · cause-effect distinction · undivided source.
- Proof 5 □ = the only one that proves **oneness**.
- *Sāṃkhyakārikā* 15 reads **śaktiḥ pravṛtteś ca** - power, not planning.
- Bridge line: many roots would destroy the undividedness we reasoned from.

SESSION 7 - THE THREE QUALITIES, EQUILIBRIUM AND MODIFICATION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. Nature is not a smooth blank; it is woven from three strands that are always present together in different proportions. Change the proportion and you change the object, the mood and the moral tone at once. Balance the three exactly and nothing manifests at all.

Technical definition. The three qualities (**guṇa**) are luminosity (**sattva**), activity (**rajas**) and inertia (**tamas**). They are not three separable substances but three inseparable constitutive tendencies within one nature. Their exact balance is the state of equilibrium (**sāmyāvasthā**), in which nature remains unmanifest. Transformation within each quality's own nature is homogeneous modification (**sarūpa-pariṇāma**); asymmetrical transformation producing differentiated evolutes is heterogeneous modification (**virūpa-pariṇāma**).

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

A useful way in: the three qualities are simultaneously *ontological*, *psychological* and *ethical*. The same luminosity that makes an object visible makes a mind clear and a temperament serene. The same inertia that makes a stone heavy makes a mind dull and a temperament confused. Sāṃkhya is claiming that one set of three factors explains physical properties, mental states and moral tone together - an extremely economical claim, and a genuinely distinctive one.

The second thing to fix is the word "quality". These are not properties possessed by nature; they are what nature is *made of*. Nature is not a thing that has three qualities; nature is the equilibrium of the three.

VISUAL - THE THREE STRANDS: CHARACTER, TONE, FUNCTION AND STATE

QUALITY	CORE CHARACTER	AFFECTIVE TONE	FUNCTION IN EVOLUTION
SATTVA	lightness, illumination, buoyancy	pleasure	revelation, clarity, manifestation, knowledge
RAJAS	activity, restlessness, propulsion	pain	energy, stimulation, movement, mediation
TAMAS	heaviness, obstruction, inertia	delusion	concealment, resistance, fixation, material density

TWO STATES OF THE SAME THREE STRANDS

EQUILIBRIUM (sāmyāvasthā)
the three in exact balance
nature = UNMANIFEST (avyakta)



SARŪPA-PARIṆĀMA
homogeneous modification:
each quality transforms WITHIN
its own nature
=> nature is dynamic even when
unmanifest; nothing differentiated
is yet produced

DISTURBANCE
asymmetrical relations begin
nature = MANIFEST evolution



VIRŪPA-PARIṆĀMA
heterogeneous modification:
the qualities transform ACROSS
one another
=> actual cosmological evolution
belongs here

ANALYSIS: WHAT DISTURBS THE BALANCE: the mere PRESENCE of the witness (sannidhi) - functional activation in proximity, NOT a mechanical collision.

What the diagram shows: one triad, two states, two kinds of modification. The 2021 question asks for exactly the top table plus the bottom pair.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

- The three characters.** Luminosity is clear and upward-moving; it makes cognition and manifestation possible. Activity is dynamic, agitating and projective; it supplies motion, effort and transition. Inertia is heavy, obscuring and resistant; it produces inertia, concealment and confusion.
- The affective mapping.** Pleasure is associated with luminosity, pain with activity and delusion with inertia. Write this explicitly - it is what makes the qualities psychological and not merely physical.
- Inseparability.** The qualities are not three separable substances but three inseparable constitutive tendencies within one nature, occurring together in every evolute in varying proportions. This is what lets a single triad explain unlimited qualitative variety.
- Equilibrium.** Before manifestation the three exist in equilibrium (sāmyāvasthā); in this state nature is unmanifest.
- Disturbance.** Manifest evolution begins when this equilibrium is disturbed in the presence of the witness. Disturbance should not be imagined as mechanical collision; Sāṃkhya speaks of functional activation in proximity.
- Homogeneous modification.** In equilibrium, each quality transforms within its own nature. This preserves the idea that nature is dynamic even in the unmanifest state without yet producing differentiated effects.
- Heterogeneous modification.** When equilibrium is disturbed, the qualities enter asymmetrical relations and produce differentiated evolutes. Actual cosmological evolution belongs here.

Why this matters beyond the 2021 question. The mechanism of *all* Sāṃkhya causation is quality modification. When Session 13 says the effect is a real transformation of the cause, the transformation being spoken of is exactly this: the three qualities transforming and recombining to produce the differentiated principles.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- The three names with characters, affective tones and functions.
- **Equilibrium (sāmyāvasthā)** as the definition of the unmanifest state.
- **Homogeneous (sarūpa)** versus **heterogeneous (virūpa)** modification.
- The inseparability claim: three tendencies within one nature, not three substances.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The theory of the three qualities is Sāṃkhya's most economical achievement: a single triad is made to explain physical constitution, affective tone and moral temperament together, so that cosmology and psychology are not two subjects in this system but one.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **luminosity (sattva) - pleasure - manifestation**
- **activity (rajas) - pain - motion**
- **inertia (tamas) - delusion - concealment**
- **equilibrium (sāmyāvasthā)**
- **homogeneous modification (sarūpa-pariṇāma)**
- **heterogeneous modification (virūpa-pariṇāma)**
- **modification of the qualities (guṇa-pariṇāma)**

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. The three qualities are not properties of nature but its constituents, and their two states of modification explain both why anything is manifest and why anything is unmanifest.

Named evidence. Luminosity, activity and inertia carry pleasure, pain and delusion respectively, and function as manifestation, motion and concealment; their exact balance is equilibrium (**sāmyāvasthā**), within which each quality still undergoes homogeneous modification, while disturbance yields the heterogeneous modification that generates the manifest principles.

Analysis. The distinction between the two kinds of modification does real work: it lets Sāṃkhya say that nature is never inert and never static, yet is genuinely unmanifest before evolution - so dissolution is not annihilation and creation is not a beginning from nothing.

Qualification. What triggers the shift from one modification to the other remains the system's most exposed point, since the witness is inactive and can only be present; Sāṃkhya therefore describes the disturbance as functional activation in proximity rather than as an event with an efficient cause.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

2021 Q6(b) asks for the three qualities *and their modifications* - the second half is the homogeneous/heterogeneous pair, which is where most answers lose marks. The triad also feeds **2018 Q5(e)**, since differential distribution of the qualities is one of the arguments for a plurality of witnesses.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** call the qualities three substances. They are inseparable constituent tendencies.
- Do **not** treat them as moral labels applied after the fact; they are constitutive.
- Do **not** stop at the table in a 2021-type question. The modifications carry half the marks.
- Do **not** say equilibrium means nature is inactive. It means nature is undifferentiated while still undergoing homogeneous modification.
- Do **not** describe the disturbance as a physical push from the witness.

RAPID REVISION

- Luminosity/pleasure/manifestation · activity/pain/motion · inertia/delusion/concealment.
- Together always, in varying proportion, in every evolute.

- Balance = unmanifest; disturbance = manifest.
- Homogeneous modification within a quality; heterogeneous modification across qualities.
- One line: *change the proportion and you change the world, the mind and the mood at once.*

SESSION 8 - CONSCIOUS WITNESS: NATURE AND THE FIVE PROOFS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. The witness is pure awareness. It does not think, act, change or produce. It is not a soul that owns experiences the way a person owns property; it is the bare fact that experience is *for* someone.

Technical definition. The conscious witness (**puruṣa**) is pure consciousness, self-luminous, inactive, changeless and beyond the qualities. Consciousness is not a quality *in* the witness; it is the witness's very essence. The witness is seer, witness and experiencer (**bhoktr**), but not agent in the productive sense.

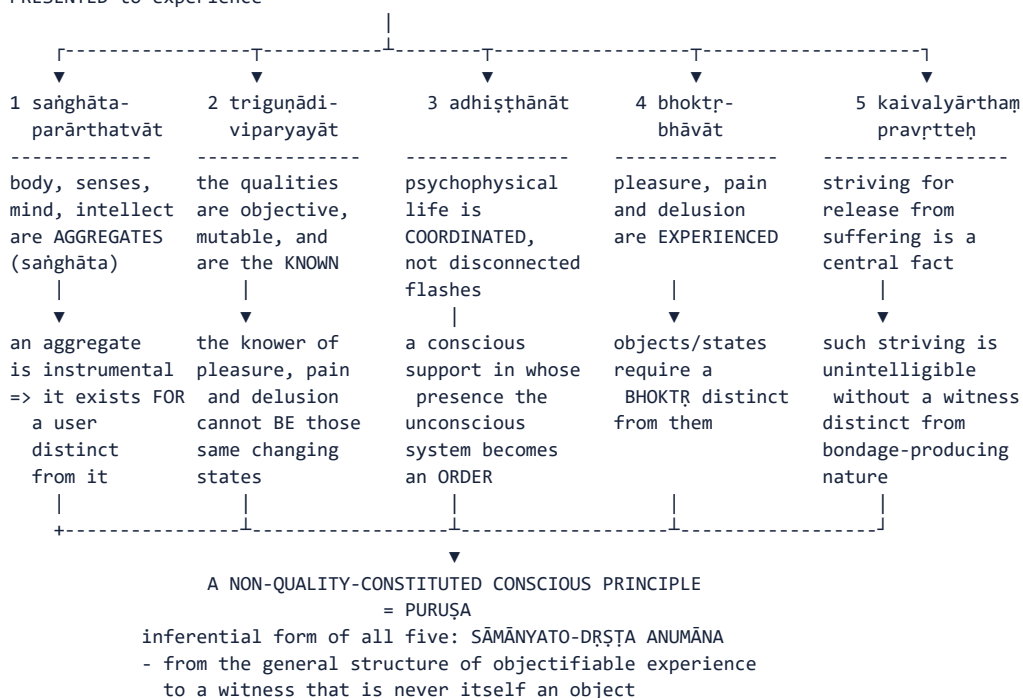
SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

The easiest way to hold this is by subtraction. Take a human being and remove everything that changes: the body, the senses, the coordinating mind, the ego that says "mine", the intellect that decides. In most systems you have now removed the self as well. In Sāṃkhya you have removed everything *except* the self, because all of those were nature.

What remains is not a thinner person. It is the condition under which any of that machinery could appear to anyone at all. That is why the witness cannot be an object of perception: it is that for which objects are.

VISUAL - THE FIVE PROOFS AS ONE CUMULATIVE INFERENCE

THE SHARED PREMISE OF ALL FIVE
everything in the objective complex is unconscious (jaḍa), instrumental, and
PRESENTED to experience



ANALYSIS: PROOF 3 IS NOT A GOD-PROOF. It infers a presiding WITNESS of lived order,
not an intelligent maker of the world.

What the diagram shows: five arguments with one premise and one conclusion. Presenting them as five independent proofs weakens the answer; presenting them as a cumulative case is what "evaluate" rewards.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

(1) Aggregates exist for another - saṅghāta-parārthatvāt. Body, senses, mind and intellect are aggregates or complexes (**saṅghāta**). Aggregates function instrumentally, and an instrument is for a user or beneficiary distinct from it. Hence there must be a conscious witness for whose experience and release the aggregate functions.

(2) The witness must be other than the qualities - triṣuṇādi-viparyayāt. The qualities are objective, mutable and characterised by pleasure, pain and delusion. The knower of pleasure, pain and delusion cannot be reducible to the same changing states that are known. Therefore a non-quality-constituted conscious principle must be admitted.

(3) Organised experience requires a presiding locus - adhiṣṭhānāt. Psychophysical life displays coordinated functioning rather than disconnected flashes. Sāṃkhya infers a conscious support in whose presence the unconscious system becomes an experienced order. **This is not a God-proof;** it is an inference to the witness as the presiding witness of lived order. Marking this explicitly is worth marks, because it is the point at which a careless answer accidentally imports theism into a non-theistic system.

(4) Experience requires an enjoyer - bhoktr-bhāvāt. Pleasure, pain and delusion are experienced. Since these are presented as objects or states, there must be an experiencer (**bhoktr**) distinct from them. Unconscious nature can *present* experience, but it cannot be the subject *for whom* experience appears.

(5) Striving for liberation presupposes a liberable witness - kaivalyārthaṃ pravṛtteḥ. Human striving for release from suffering is a central fact for Sāṃkhya. Such striving would be unintelligible if there were no conscious principle distinct from bondage-producing nature. The orientation toward isolation (**kaivalya**) therefore presupposes the witness.

Evaluation - what "examine and evaluate" wants.

- The proofs are **cumulative, not isolated**. Any one alone is answerable; together they argue that aggregates are instrumental, qualities are objectifiable, experience requires a witness, and liberation presupposes a self.
- Their epistemic form is uniform: general-correlation inference (**sāmānyato-dṛṣṭa anumāna**), from the general structure of objectifiable experience to a witness that is never itself an object.
- Their honest limit: they establish that experience has a *subject-pole*; they do not by themselves establish that the subject-pole is eternal, plural or inactive. Those come from further argument (Session 9) and from the system's soteriological requirements.

The nature of the witness, tabulated.

Feature	Sāṃkhya position
Consciousness	essence, not quality
Activity	inactive, non-productive
Change	changeless, immutable
Relation to the qualities	entirely beyond them
Status	witness, seer, experiencer

Two consequences follow immediately and must be written: the witness does not become bound in its own nature - bondage belongs to misidentification; and the witness does not produce the world - all production belongs to nature.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- All five Sanskrit proof-names with English glosses.
- **Aggregate (saṅghāta), experiencer (bhoktr), insentient (jaḍa).**
- The explicit disclaimer that the third proof is not a God-proof.
- The uniform inferential form: general-correlation inference.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Sāṃkhya's proofs for the witness are best read as one argument in five movements: everything we can point to in the person is an instrument, and an instrument that is genuinely for no one is not an instrument at all.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **saṅghāta-parārthatvāt** - aggregates exist for another

- **triguṇādi-viparyayāt** - other than the qualities
- **adhiṣṭhānāt** - presiding locus (not a God-proof)
- **bhoktr-bhāvāt** - experience requires an enjoyer
- **kaivalyārthaṃ pravṛtteḥ** - striving presupposes a liberable witness
- **self-luminous, inactive, changeless**
- **cumulative inference of the general-correlation kind**

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. The five Sāṃkhya proofs for the conscious witness succeed as a cumulative case and fail as five independent demonstrations.

Named evidence. They argue from the instrumentality of aggregates (**saṅghāta-parārthatvāt**), from the objectivity and mutability of the qualities (**triguṇādi-viparyayāt**), from the coordination of psychophysical life (**adhiṣṭhānāt**), from the presented character of pleasure, pain and delusion (**bhoktr-bhāvāt**), and from the intelligibility of striving for release (**kaivalyārthaṃ pravṛtteḥ**).

Analysis. Each proof taken alone invites a deflationary reply - a Buddhist can explain coordination by causal series and ownership by convention - but the five together converge on a single structural point: every candidate item inside the person is something *presented*, and a domain of presentation without a subject-pole is not a domain of presentation at all.

Qualification. What the convergence yields is a witness, not yet an eternal, plural and wholly inactive witness; those further properties are secured by the system's account of individuation and liberation rather than by these inferences, and honest evaluation should say so.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

2022 Q5(a) - "Examine and evaluate the proofs given by Sāṃkhya philosophy to prove the existence of Puruṣa" - is answered exactly by the five proofs plus the cumulative-force evaluation and the honest limit. The nature-table also underwrites **2019 Q5(d)** on the empirical self and the witness.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** present the third proof as a proof of God. It infers a presiding *witness*.
- Do **not** say consciousness is a *property* of the witness; it is its essence.
- Do **not** call the witness an agent or a knower in the productive sense; it is the experiencer for whom cognition occurs.
- Do **not** stop at listing when the directive says "evaluate". Add cumulative force and limits.

RAPID REVISION

- Five proofs: aggregates-for-another · other-than-qualities · presiding locus · enjoyer · striving.
- One premise (everything objective is unconscious and presented) and one form (general-correlation inference).
- Nature of the witness: essence-consciousness, inactive, changeless, beyond the qualities.
- Never bound in itself; never productive.

SESSION 9 - PLURALITY OF WITNESSES, PURPOSIVE NATURE, AND EMPIRICAL SELF VERSUS WITNESS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. Sāṃkhya holds that there are many witnesses, not one - even though every witness is exactly alike. It also holds that unconscious nature behaves *for* those witnesses without intending anything. And it holds that the everyday "I" is not a further entity but the witness seen through the intellect.

Technical definition. Plurality of witnesses (**puruṣa-bahutva**) is numerical, not qualitative. Nature acts for the sake of the witness (**puruṣārtha**) by supplying experience and finally the possibility of discriminative release. The empirical

self (**jīva**) is not a separate principle (**tattva**) but the witness as empirically appearing through identification with intellect, I-maker, mind, body and the karmic stream.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Three separate claims are packed together here, and separating them is most of the work.

- *How many witnesses?* Many - because your blindness is not mine and your release would not be mine.
- *Why does nature bother?* Because purposiveness, in this system, does not require intention; milk flows for the calf without deliberating.
- *What then is the everyday self?* Not a third thing between nature and witness, but the witness wearing the intellect.

If you write these as three separate answers, each with its own evidence, you will not blur them - and blurring them is precisely what loses marks in the 2018 and 2019 questions.

VISUAL - THE PLURALITY ARGUMENT, ITS SOURCE CONTROL, AND ITS PRESSURE POINT

ARGUMENTS FOR MANY WITNESSES

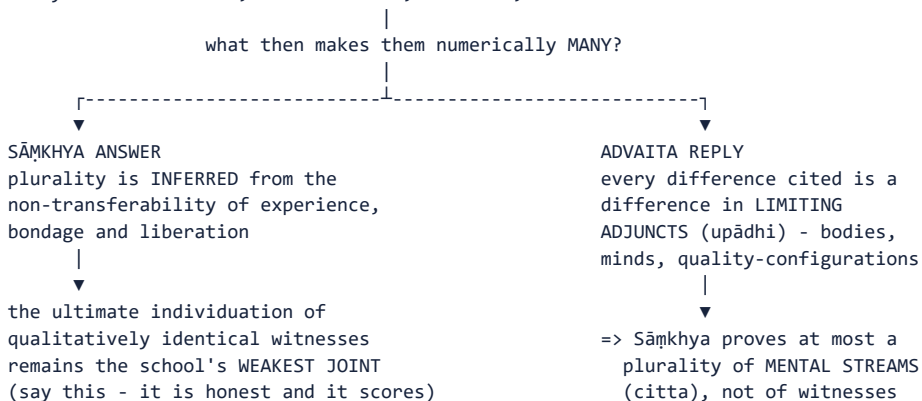
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|-- FROM Sāṃkhyakārikā 18 (write these THREE first) -----
| 1 FIXED DISTRIBUTION of birth, death and sense-faculties
|   if there were ONE witness, one birth would be all births, one death all
|   deaths, and all would be blind when one is blind
| 2 NON-SIMULTANEITY OF ACTIVITY
|   beings act at different times and in different ways; one self would make
|   all embodied streams act together
| 3 DIFFERENTIAL DISTRIBUTION OF THE THREE QUALITIES
|   beings differ as luminous, active or inert in temperament => distinct
|   centres of experience
+-----+
|-- SUPPLEMENTARY (add as REINFORCEMENT, not as a fourth Kārikā phrase) -----
| 4 DIFFERENTIAL LIBERATION - if the self were one, release of one would be
|   release of all; some remain bound while another may be released
+-----+

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THE PRESSURE POINT (state it; do not hide it)

every witness is PURE, ATTRIBUTELESS, PARTLESS, ACTIONLESS consciousness



What the diagram shows: three canonical arguments, one supplementary argument, and one admitted weakness. Marking the fourth argument as supplementary is a source-control point the examiner can check.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

A. Why witnesses are many.

The first three arguments map directly onto *Sāṃkhyakārikā* 18: fixed distribution of birth, death and faculties; non-simultaneous activity; and differential constitution by the qualities. Differential liberation is a standard supplementary inference, **not** a fourth phrase in that verse. In the exam, present the three canonical arguments first and add non-simultaneous liberation only as reinforcement.

Plurality does not mean qualitative difference among witnesses; each witness is pure, inactive consciousness, but they are numerically many.

B. The presuppositions behind the plurality argument. These are worth naming because "critically discuss" directives reward them.

Presupposition	Why it matters
Empirical individuation transfers upward	Differences in bodies and mental streams are taken to license an inference to distinct witnesses.
The witness is genuinely an experienter (bhoktr)	If experience has no owner, the question "whose pleasure or pain?" loses its force.
Liberation is particular	Liberation is attributed to a particular witness's psychophysical stream, not to the collapse of a universal illusion.
Numerical plurality of attributeless consciousness is intelligible	The school accepts numerical difference without qualitative difference.

C. Objections and replies - the four that matter.

- **Advaita / Śaṅkara.** Every difference cited is a difference in limiting adjuncts (**upādhi**) - bodies, minds, quality-configurations - not in consciousness itself. Pure consciousness, being without attribute, part, action or spatial location, admits no principle of individuation; therefore Śāṅkhya proves at most a plurality of mental streams (**citta**), not of witnesses. **Śāṅkhya's reply.** If there were one witness, the bondage of one would be the bondage of all and the release of one the release of all; the reflection model also requires distinct reflected loci in distinct intellects. **Residual force.** Advaita answers that bondage itself is adventitious and the many empirical selves are apparent, so the exchange terminates in a clash of first principles: Śāṅkhya trusts the plurality given in experience, while Advaita subordinates plurality to the unity given in scripture.
- **Nyāya.** Nyāya agrees that selves are many but objects to a purely inactive self; an agentless self cannot be the locus of moral desert, so Nyāya makes the self a substance with adventitious cognition, volition and effort. **Reply.** Agency belongs to nature's evolutes; ascribing agency to the witness is precisely the false appropriation (**abhimāna**) that bondage consists in.
- **Buddhist.** A permanent, changeless and actionless entity is causally idle and therefore, by the criterion of efficacy (**arthakriyā**), unreal. **Reply.** The witness's efficacy is not productive causation but mere presence (**sannidhi / sānnidhya**) that renders nature's activity experienced; without the witness the purposiveness of nature (**puruṣārtha**) is unintelligible.
- **Internal objection.** If witnesses are all identical in nature - pure, attributeless consciousness - what makes them numerically many? **Honest reply.** Plurality is inferred from the non-transferability of experience, bondage and liberation; but the ultimate individuation of qualitatively identical witnesses remains the school's weakest joint. Saying this is not a concession that costs marks; it is the mark of a candidate who has understood the problem.

D. Purposive nature without intention.

Nature acts for the sake of the witness (**puruṣārtha**) by providing experience and finally the possibility of discriminative release. Four canonical images carry this:

Image	What it explains
Milk flowing for the calf	unconscious functioning can still serve a purposive end
The lame man and the blind man	complementarity: the witness sees but cannot act; nature acts but cannot see
The dancer who retires once she has been seen	after discriminative knowledge nature no longer performs binding activity for that witness
The modest woman who withdraws on being seen	once her distinction from the witness is disclosed, concealment ends

Objection. Unconscious teleology appears incoherent, because purposiveness seems to require intelligence. **Reply.** Purposive functioning need not be conscious planning; the quality-structure naturally unfolds in the presence of the

witness, just as milk nourishes the calf without deliberation.

E. The empirical self is not a further principle.

- The witness is the metaphysical reality: pure, inactive, changeless consciousness.
- The empirical self (jīva) is **not a separate principle**. It is the witness as empirically appearing through identification with intellect, I-maker, mind, body and the karmic stream.
- Therefore the empirical self is the conditioned everyday self, while the witness is the unconditioned conscious reality behind it.
- **Best formulation for the exam:** the empirical self is the witness as empirically conditioned through intellect; the witness is the metaphysical reality behind that appearance.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- **Sāṃkhyakārikā 18** for the three canonical plurality arguments, with differential liberation marked as supplementary.
- The four analogies: milk and calf, lame and blind, the dancer, the modest woman.
- Named objectors: Advaita on limiting adjuncts; Nyāya on moral desert; Buddhism on efficacy.
- **Limiting adjunct (upādhi), mental stream (citta), efficacy (arthakriyā)**, **mere presence (sannidhi)**.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Sāṃkhya defends a plurality of witnesses by an argument from non-transferability - my blindness is not yours and my release would not be yours - and the school's deepest embarrassment is that this excellent moral argument must individuate entities which, by its own account, have no features by which to differ.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **Sāṃkhyakārikā 18**
- **numerical, not qualitative, plurality**
- **limiting adjunct (upādhi)** - the Advaita counter
- **efficacy (arthakriyā)** - the Buddhist counter
- **for the sake of the witness (puruṣārtha)**
- **milk-and-calf · lame-and-blind · the dancer · the modest woman**
- **the empirical self (jīva) is not a separate principle**

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Sāṃkhya's plurality of witnesses is argued from moral and experiential non-transferability, and the empirical self is a mode of appearance rather than an additional entity.

Named evidence. *Sāṃkhyakārikā* 18 supplies fixed distribution of birth, death and faculties, non-simultaneous activity and differential constitution by the qualities, with differential liberation added as a supplementary inference; and the school explicitly denies that the empirical self is a separate principle, treating it as the witness conditioned through intellect.

Analysis. These two theses are mutually supporting: because the empirical self is only the witness seen through an intellect, differences among empirical selves can be read as evidence of differences among witnesses, which is exactly the inference Advaita blocks by assigning every such difference to limiting adjuncts.

Qualification. The Sāṃkhya position therefore stands or falls on whether numerically distinct but qualitatively identical consciousnesses are intelligible; the school infers plurality from non-transferable bondage and release, but concedes in effect that it cannot state the principle of individuation itself.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

2018 Q5(e) - "Is Puruṣa one or many?" - is answered by section A plus the Advaita objection and reply. **2019 Q5(d)** - the metaphysical status of the empirical self and the witness - is answered by section E plus the reflection mechanism from Session 4. Section D is the load-bearing reply to Śaṅkara's teleology charge in **2025 Q7(a)**.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** cite differential liberation as a fourth phrase of *Sāṃkhyakārikā* 18. It is supplementary.
- Do **not** say the witnesses differ in quality. The plurality is numerical only.
- Do **not** treat the empirical self as a twenty-sixth principle.
- Do **not** answer the Advaita objection by repeating the plurality arguments; answer it by the non-transferability of bondage and release and the requirement of distinct reflected loci.
- Do **not** claim nature "intends" anything. Purposiveness here is structural, not intentional.

RAPID REVISION

- Three Kārikā-18 arguments + one supplementary; plurality is numerical only.
- Advaita: differences are in limiting adjuncts -> at most many mental streams.
- Nyāya: an inactive self cannot own moral desert. Buddhist: no efficacy, so unreal.
- Nature works for the witness: milk-calf, lame-blind, dancer, modest woman.
- Empirical self = witness through intellect; not a separate principle.

SESSION 10 - THE TWENTY-FIVE PRINCIPLES: THE COMPLETE EVOLUTIONARY SEQUENCE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. From one unmanifest nature the world unfolds in a fixed order: intellect first, then the ego, then two branches - one producing the mind and the ten capacities, the other producing the five subtle elements and from them the five gross elements. Counting nature and the witness, the total is twenty-five.

Technical definition. The twenty-five principles (**tattva**) are: primordial material nature; the great one or determinative intellect (**mahat / buddhi**); the I-maker (**ahaṃkāra**); the coordinating mind (**manas**); five cognitive capacities (**jñānendriya**); five action capacities (**karmendriya**); five subtle elements (**tanmātra**); five gross elements (**mahābhūta**); and the conscious witness (**puruṣa**) as the twenty-fifth, which is not an evolute of nature.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Three sentences will protect you through this entire session.

1. The great one and the determinative intellect are **the same principle** under two names - cosmic and individual.
2. The ego produces **two lines**, not three, because activity (**rajas**) supplies energy rather than a separate product-set.
3. The witness is number twenty-five but is **not an evolute**; it stands outside the productive series entirely.

Every recurring error in this topic is a violation of one of those three sentences.

VISUAL - THE EVOLUTION TREE IN EXACT ORDER



What the diagram shows: one root, one first evolute, one individuator, then a two-line branching with a third quality acting as energiser rather than producer.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

The ordered list.

No.	Principle	Note
1	primordial nature (prakṛti)	root material cause
2	the great one / determinative intellect (mahat / buddhi)	first evolute
3	I-maker (ahaṅkāra)	principle of individuation
4	coordinating mind (manas)	internal coordinator
5-9	five cognitive capacities (jñānendriya)	cognitive senses
10-14	five action capacities (karmendriya)	action faculties
15-19	five subtle elements (tanmātra)	subtle elements
20-24	five gross elements (mahābhūta)	gross elements
25	conscious witness (puruṣa)	pure consciousness, non-evolute

The complete instrument and element taxonomy.

Family	English-first members	Function / evolution
Five cognitive capacities	hearing (śrotra), touch (tvak), sight (cakṣus), taste (rasanā), smell (ghrāṇa)	disclose sound, touch, form or colour, taste and smell
Five action capacities	speech (vāk), grasping (pāṇi), locomotion (pāda), excretion (pāyu), reproduction (upastha)	perform the five principal outward functions

Family	English-first members	Function / evolution
Five subtle elements	sound-potential (śabda), touch-potential (sparsā), form-potential (rūpa), taste-potential (rasa), smell-potential (gandha)	arise from the inert side of the I-maker with active-quality energy
Five gross elements	ether (ākāśa), air (vāyu), fire or light (tejas), water (ap), earth (prthivī)	arise from the subtle-element series and compose the gross world

The standard correspondence runs sound -> ether, touch -> air, form -> fire, taste -> water and smell -> earth. Do **not** import Advaita's later fivefold grossification (**pañcīkaraṇa**) into a basic classical Sāṃkhya evolution answer.

The fourfold cause-effect classification - the fastest control on the whole list.

Status	Principles	Count
Cause but not effect (evolvent only)	primordial nature alone	1
Both cause and effect	intellect, I-maker and the five subtle elements	7
Effect only	mind, five cognitive capacities, five action capacities, five gross elements	16
Neither cause nor effect	the conscious witness	1

This classification is the quickest way to control the full sequence and to prevent miscounting the cosmic and determinative intellect as two separate principles.

Cosmic intellect, determinative intellect and the I-maker - the 2024 second half.

- The great one (**mahat**) and the determinative intellect (**buddhi**) are the **same principle**.

The great one is the cosmic aspect or name; the determinative intellect is the individual or psychological aspect or name.

- The I-maker (**ahamkāra**) emerges **from** that principle as the principle of individuation or I-sense.
- Therefore the sequence is nature -> the great one / determinative intellect -> the I-maker.
- **This is a classic trap.** Never write the great one and the determinative intellect as two separate stages.

What each of the three does.

- The determinative intellect determines, judges, ascertains and discriminates; it is the locus where reflected consciousness is most conspicuous in empirical life.
- The I-maker appropriates functions into the form "I know", "I act", "I experience"; false selfhood crystallises here, which is why it is central to bondage.
- The mind coordinates. In one line: *mind coordinates, I-maker appropriates, intellect determines.*

The three lines.

- From the luminous aspect of the I-maker arise the mind, the five cognitive capacities and the five action capacities. This line accounts for the cognitive and conative equipment of empirical life.
- From the inert aspect of the I-maker arise the five subtle elements, and from those the five gross elements. This line accounts for subtle-to-gross material manifestation.
- The active quality supplies activity, energy and operative force to **both** lines. The active-aspect I-maker does **not** produce a separate set of principles. Write this explicitly; it is repeatedly confused.

Why the sequence matters philosophically. The sequence shows that cosmology and psychology are internally linked in Sāṃkhya: the same nature that yields matter also yields the faculties through which matter is experienced. That is the philosophical point a 20-mark answer must reach after narrating the list.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- The ordered twenty-five with their numbering.
- The fourfold classification with the counts 1 / 7 / 16 / 1.
- The named members of all four five-fold families.
- The subtle-to-gross correspondence, and the explicit exclusion of fivefold grossification.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The list of twenty-five principles is not an inventory but an argument: by deriving intellect, ego, mind and the senses from the same root as the elements, Sāṃkhya makes the knower's equipment as much a part of nature as the known world, and therefore makes liberation a matter of discrimination rather than of escape.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **twenty-five principles (tattva); twenty-four evolutes plus the witness**
- **the great one / determinative intellect (mahat / buddhi) - one principle, two names**
- **I-maker (ahaṃkāra) as the principle of individuation**
- **luminous line · inert line · active quality as energiser only**
- **subtle elements (tanmātra) -> gross elements (mahābhūta)**
- **fourfold cause-effect classification: 1 / 7 / 16 / 1**

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. The Sāṃkhya evolutionary sequence is ordered by a single principle - subtler and more internal before grosser and more external - and that ordering is what carries its philosophical point.

Named evidence. Nature yields the great one or determinative intellect, which yields the I-maker, from whose luminous aspect arise the mind and the ten capacities and from whose inert aspect arise the five subtle elements and then the five gross elements, with the active quality supplying energy to both lines and producing no separate set; the fourfold classification fixes this as one evolvent, seven both, sixteen effects only, and one neither.

Analysis. Because determination precedes individuation and individuation precedes both the sensory apparatus and the elements, Sāṃkhya locates the "I" inside nature rather than at its origin - which is exactly what allows bondage to be described as a misplacement within the series and liberation as its correction.

Qualification. The order is a doctrinal derivation, not an observational chronology; the school does not claim that intellect existed before elements in datable time, but that the manifest world is intelligible only if the more determinate is derived from the less determinate.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

2024 Q7(a) (20 marks, 10+10) asks for the evolution of nature as propounded in the *Sāṃkhyakārikā* and, in that context, the difference between the determinative intellect, the great one and the I-maker. The first ten marks are the tree; the second ten are the one-principle-two-names point plus the three functional roles.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** write the great one and the determinative intellect as two separate stages.
- Do **not** give the active-quality aspect its own product-set. It energises both lines.
- Do **not** derive the mind from the inert line, or the subtle elements from the luminous line.
- Do **not** count the witness among the evolutes; it is the twenty-fifth principle but a non-evolute.
- Do **not** insert Advaita's fivefold grossification into the classical sequence.
- Do **not** reverse the elemental correspondence: smell goes with earth, sound with ether.

RAPID REVISION

- Nature -> intellect -> ego -> (luminous: mind + 5 + 5) and (inert: 5 subtle -> 5 gross); activity energises both.

- 24 evolutes + witness = 25.
- 1 evolver-only · 7 both · 16 effects-only · 1 neither.
- Cosmic name and individual name of one principle; the ego individuates.
- One line: *the equipment of knowing is itself a product of the known.*

SESSION 11 - SUBTLE BODY, TRANSMIGRATION AND KARMA

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. Something has to travel between lives, or rebirth is unintelligible. It cannot be the witness, because the witness never moves. So Sāṃkhya gives the job to a subtle psychophysical vehicle that carries dispositions from one gross body to the next.

Technical definition. The subtle body (*liṅga-śarīra* / *sūkṣma-śarīra*) is the continuing psychophysical vehicle between gross embodiments. It is commonly counted as eighteen constituents: the determinative intellect, the I-maker, the eleven sense and action capacities including the mind, and the five subtle elements. It is conditioned by dispositions (*bhāva*) and by the eight broad tendencies of the intellect: merit and demerit, knowledge and ignorance, detachment and non-detachment, power and powerlessness.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Picture a seal and a series of wax blocks. The seal is not the wax; it does not become the wax; but it stamps its pattern on each new block in turn. Sāṃkhya's subtle body is like the seal: a stable carrier of dispositions that receives a new gross body at each embodiment.

Now note what is *not* in the picture. The witness is not the seal and not the wax. It does not migrate at all. This is the point most answers get wrong, and it is exactly what the school's strictest formulations insist on.

VISUAL - WHAT MIGRATES, WHAT DOES NOT, AND WHAT CARRIES THE PATTERN

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+-----+
| DOES NOT MIGRATE
| PURUṢA - never acts, never moves, is never really bound or liberated
| => transmigration is NOT the journey of a soul in this system
+-----+

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+-----+
| MIGRATES: THE SUBTLE BODY (liṅga-śarīra / sūkṣma-śarīra)
| commonly counted as EIGHTEEN constituents
|
| +-----+
| | intellect 1 | I-maker 1 | mind + 10 | five subtle
| | | | | capacities 11 | elements 5 |
| +-----+
|
| 1 + 1 + 11 + 5 = 18
|
| CONDITIONED BY the EIGHT BROAD TENDENCIES OF INTELLECT (bhāva)
| merit demerit · knowledge ignorance
| detachment non-detachment · power powerlessness
+-----+

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+-----+
| IS DISCARDED: THE GROSS BODY
| produced from parental material; falls away at death
+-----+

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THE PRESSURE POINT
moral ownership must be explained through the STABLE ASSOCIATION of one subtle stream with ONE numerically distinct witness - an association the system asserts but does not further ground.

What the diagram shows: a three-tier separation - what never moves, what carries the pattern, and what is discarded - plus the ethical problem the separation creates.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

1. **The vehicle.** The subtle body is the continuing psychophysical vehicle between gross embodiments. It is not a ghost or a soul; it is a functional aggregate drawn from the evolutes already enumerated in Session 10.

2. **The count.** Eighteen constituents: determinative intellect, I-maker, eleven capacities including the mind, and five subtle elements. Note that the eleven includes the mind - this is why the count is eighteen and not seventeen.
3. **The dispositions.** The subtle body is described as primordially arisen within the evolutionary cycle and conditioned by dispositions and the eight broad tendencies of the intellect: merit and demerit, knowledge and ignorance, detachment and non-detachment, power and powerlessness. These eight are the moral-cognitive profile that the vehicle carries.
4. **Death.** At death the gross body produced from parental material falls away, while the subtle body carries dispositions and karmic tendencies into another embodiment.
5. **The strict formulation about the witness.** The pure conscious witness neither acts nor literally migrates. Transmigration belongs to the subtle body and the empirical self-complex operating *for* a particular witness.
6. **The pressure point - state it.** This preserves the inactivity of the witness, but it creates a difficulty: moral ownership must be explained through the stable association of a subtle stream with one numerically distinct witness. Sāṃkhya asserts that association; it does not further ground it. This is the same weak joint identified in Session 9, now seen from the ethical side.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- **Subtle body (liṅga-śarīra / sūkṣma-śarīra)** with its eighteen-constituent count.
- The **eight tendencies of the intellect** as four contrasted pairs.
- The strict claim that the witness neither acts nor literally migrates.
- The contrast with the gross body produced from parental material.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Sāṃkhya buys the inactivity of consciousness at the price of relocating rebirth: what travels between lives is not a self but a disposition-bearing subtle body, so the school must then explain how a purely passive witness comes to own a moral career it never conducted.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **subtle body (liṅga-śarīra / sūkṣma-śarīra)**
- **eighteen constituents (1 + 1 + 11 + 5)**
- **dispositions (bhāva)**
- ****eight tendencies: merit/demerit, knowledge/ignorance, detachment/non-detachment, power/powerlessness****
- **the gross body from parental material**
- **the witness neither acts nor migrates**

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Sāṃkhya explains rebirth without a transmigrating self by assigning continuity to a subtle body rather than to the witness.

Named evidence. The subtle body is counted as eighteen constituents - determinative intellect, I-maker, the eleven capacities including the mind, and the five subtle elements - and is conditioned by dispositions and the intellect's eight tendencies of merit and demerit, knowledge and ignorance, detachment and non-detachment, power and powerlessness; at death the gross body from parental material falls away while this vehicle continues.

Analysis. The manoeuvre is internally consistent, because everything that changes has already been placed inside nature, so the carrier of karmic tendency can be constructed entirely from evolutes without compromising the changelessness of the witness.

Qualification. Its cost is ethical rather than cosmological: since the witness never acts, moral desert has to be secured by the stable association of one subtle stream with one witness, and that association is asserted by the

system rather than derived from anything more basic.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

Supports **2019 Q5(d)** on the empirical self and the witness, because the empirical self is exactly the witness plus this subtle-body complex. It is also the correct reply to any Buddhist or Nyāya challenge in **2018 Q5(e)** that plural inactive witnesses cannot ground moral responsibility.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** say the witness transmigrates. Say the subtle body does.
- Do **not** confuse the subtle body with the five subtle elements; the elements are five of its eighteen constituents.
- Do **not** omit the mind when counting the eleven capacities; the total is eighteen.
- Do **not** treat the eight tendencies as ethical maxims. They are dispositional states of the intellect.

RAPID REVISION

- Subtle body = 1 intellect + 1 ego + 11 capacities + 5 subtle elements = 18.
- Eight tendencies in four contrasted pairs.
- Gross body from parental material is discarded; subtle body carries dispositions.
- The witness never acts and never moves.
- One line: *the pattern travels; the light does not.*

SESSION 12 - PRE-EXISTENCE OF THE EFFECT: THE FIVE ARGUMENTS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. Sāṃkhya says the effect is already in its material cause before it is produced - not visibly, but as a determinate capacity. Production does not create being; it makes latent being patent.

Technical definition. The doctrine of the pre-existence of the effect in the cause (**satkāryavāda**) holds that the effect pre-exists in its material cause, so that production is manifestation (**abhivyakti**), not creation out of sheer non-being. Sāṃkhya's specific form is the doctrine of real transformation (**pariṇāmavāda**).

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Read the thesis carefully, because the careless version is indefensible. Sāṃkhya does **not** say a miniature gross tree is hidden inside the mango seed. It says that this seed, and not sand, has the determinate capacity for this tree - and that having such a determinate capacity is what "the effect pre-exists" means.

If you write the careless version, the examiner's rival positions demolish it in one line. If you write the careful version - *latent effect, material continuity, real transformation* - the doctrine becomes formidable.

VISUAL - FIVE ARGUMENTS, EACH WITH ITS COUNTER AND REPLY

1	asadakaraṇāt - a NON-ENTITY CANNOT BE PRODUCED no operation yields a hare's horn or oil from sand ◀ Nyāya: you equivocate - we deny only that the POT exists AS A POT before production, not that anything exists ▶ reply: the "not-yet" effect must still be SOMETHING in the material cause, else the operation has no determinate terminus
2	upādāna-grahaṇāt - a DETERMINATE MATERIAL CAUSE IS TAKEN UP for curd take milk, not water; for cloth take threads, not clay ◀ counter: the restriction is explained by causal CAPACITY, not by the effect's pre-existence ▶ reply: capacity in the required DETERMINATE sense just IS the latent presence of that effect in that material continuum
3	sarvasambhavābhāvāt - EVERYTHING CANNOT ARISE FROM EVERYTHING non-existence as such is INDISTINGUISHABLE, so it cannot explain why curd comes from milk and not from water ◀ counter: restrictions come from the constitution of causes ▶ reply: a constitution capable of producing only X IS the latent presence of X as a determinate effect-potential
4	śaktasya śakya-karaṇāt - THE POTENT PRODUCES ONLY THE PRODUCIBLE milk has potency for curd, not for cloth; threads for cloth, not curd ◀ Nyāya: potency is a RELATIONAL PROPERTY of the cause, not the effect in latent form ▶ reply: a merely relational potency cannot explain DETERMINATE production unless the producible form is already grounded in the material cause
5	kāraṇa-bhāvāt - THE EFFECT HAS THE BEING OF THE CAUSE cloth is threads in an arrangement: same material basis, weight and quality-continuity; ornament and gold differ in form and name only ◀ Nyāya: the WHOLE (avayavin) is a NEW substance with new properties - a cloth covers, separate threads do not ▶ reply: the new properties are new ARRANGEMENTS (saṁsthāna), not new substances created out of non-being

What the diagram shows: this is not a list of five assertions but five miniature debates. Reproducing the counter and the reply is what converts a description into an argument.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

(1) Because what does not exist cannot be brought into being - asadakaraṇāt. A sheer non-entity cannot be produced. No amount of causal operation can produce a hare's horn or oil from sand; production presupposes something determinate to be produced. A potter's effort can manifest a pot from clay, but it cannot manifest a square circle from nothing. *Nyāya objection:* Sāṃkhya equivocates between the absolutely non-existent and the merely not-yet-existent; Nyāya denies only that the pot exists as a *pot* before production. *Reply:* the not-yet-existent effect must still be something in the material cause, otherwise the operation would have no determinate terminus.

(2) Because a determinate material cause is taken up - upādāna-grahaṇāt. Specific effects require specific material causes. One who wants curd takes milk, not water; one who wants cloth takes threads, not clay. The selection of mango seed rather than sand for a mango tree shows a determinate causal base. *Objection:* the restriction may be explained by causal capacity rather than by the pre-existence of the effect. *Reply:* causal capacity in the required determinate sense just is the latent presence of that effect in that material continuum.

(3) Because everything cannot arise from everything - sarvasambhavābhāvāt. If effects were wholly non-existent before production, any cause could produce any effect. Non-existence as such is indistinguishable; therefore it cannot explain why curd arises from milk and not from water. Cloth comes from threads, not from milk; curd comes from milk, not from threads. *Objection:* restrictions come from the constitution of causes, not from effects already existing in causes. *Reply:* a constitution capable of producing only one effect is precisely the latent presence of that effect as a determinate effect-potential.

(4) Because the efficient can produce only what it is capable of producing - śaktasya śakya-karaṇāt. A cause has a determinate potency (śakti) directed toward a determinate effect. A potency for something is unintelligible unless that something is in some manner already there as the object of the potency. Milk has the potency for curd, not for cloth; threads have the potency for cloth, not for curd. *Nyāya objection:* potency is a relational property of the

cause, not the effect in latent form. *Reply*: a merely relational potency cannot explain determinate production unless the producible form is already grounded in the material cause.

(5) Because the effect has the nature or being of the cause - kāraṇa-bhāvāt. The effect is non-different from the cause in substance. Cloth is nothing over and above threads in a certain arrangement; it has the same material basis, weight and quality-continuity. Ornament and gold differ in form and name, but the material substance remains gold. *Nyāya objection*: the whole (**avayavin**) is a new substance with new properties - a cloth covers, but separate threads do not. *Reply*: the new properties are new arrangements or configurations (**saṁsthāna**), not new substances created out of non-being.

The formulation to memorise for the mango-seed question. Write it as *latent effect + material continuity + real transformation*. Do **not** write it as a miniature gross mango tree hidden inside the seed.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- All five Sanskrit argument-names with English glosses.
- The standard examples: hare's horn, oil from sand, milk and curd, threads and cloth, gold and ornament, mango seed and mango tree.
- **Whole (avayavin)** and **arrangement (saṁsthāna)** - the Nyāya objection and the Sāṃkhya reply.
- The prohibition on the "miniature tree in the seed" reading.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The doctrine of the pre-existent effect is best defended as an argument about determinacy: since sheer non-being is featureless and therefore cannot explain why *this* cause yields *that* effect, the restriction we actually observe in production must already be written into the material cause.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **satkāryavāda**; production as manifestation (**abhivṛyakti**)
- **asadakaraṇāt · upādāna-grahaṇāt · sarvasambhavābhāvāt · śaktasya śakya-karaṇāt · kāraṇa-bhāvāt**
- **determinate potency (śakti)**
- **whole (avayavin)** versus **arrangement (saṁsthāna)**
- **latent effect + material continuity + real transformation**

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Sāṃkhya's case for the pre-existent effect rests on the observed determinacy of production rather than on any claim that effects are visible inside their causes.

Named evidence. The five arguments run from the impossibility of producing a non-entity, from the taking up of a determinate material cause, from the fact that everything does not arise from everything, from potency being directed at a determinate producible, and from the effect's sharing the being of the cause - with milk and curd, threads and cloth, and gold and ornament as the standing examples.

Analysis. The third argument carries the greatest weight, because non-existence is featureless and a featureless antecedent cannot discriminate outcomes; hence any theory that begins from sheer prior absence must smuggle the required determinacy back in through the constitution of the cause, which is what Sāṃkhya means by latent presence.

Qualification. The Nyāya rejoinder is not thereby refuted: an opponent may locate determinacy in a relational potency rather than in a latent effect, and the debate then turns on whether a relation without a determinate relatum can do explanatory work - a question the two schools answer by different first principles.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

The core of **2020 Q7(a) (20 marks)** on the mango tree and the mango seed, where the demand is explicitly to explain the process "by rejecting their rival perspectives". It is also the Sāṃkhya-side content required by the routed **2021 Q5(a)** ("Does the seed contain the tree?") and **2023 Q8(b)** on prior non-existence.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** say the gross effect is already manifest, or that a small tree sits inside the seed.
- Do **not** conflate the doctrine of the pre-existent effect with Sāṃkhya's specific form of it;

Advaita is also a pre-existence theorist.

- Do **not** omit the Nyāya counters. "Rejecting rival perspectives" is part of the printed demand.
- Do **not** treat argument 5 as a claim of identity; the effect differs from the cause in state and arrangement.

RAPID REVISION

- Five names: non-entity · determinate material · not-everything-from-everything · potency · being-of-the-cause.
- Examples: hare's horn, sand and oil, milk and curd, threads and cloth, gold and ornament.
- Nyāya counters: equivocation, capacity, constitution, relational potency, the new whole.
- Reply pattern: determinacy must be grounded in the material cause.
- One line: *featureless non-being cannot explain a selective world.*

SESSION 13 - REAL TRANSFORMATION AGAINST THE RIVAL CAUSAL THEORIES

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. Sāṃkhya's version of the pre-existent effect is that the cause really turns into the effect. Advaita's version is that the cause only appears to. Nyāya denies the pre-existence altogether. Buddhism denies the enduring cause. Four positions, one question.

Technical definition. The doctrine of real transformation (**pariṇāmavāda**) holds that the effect is a genuine modification of its material cause, effected through the modification of the qualities (**guṇa-pariṇāma**). It is contrasted with the doctrine of apparent transformation (**vivartavāda**), with the doctrine of the non-pre-existent effect (**asatkāryavāda**), and with dependent origination (**pratītyasamutpāda**).

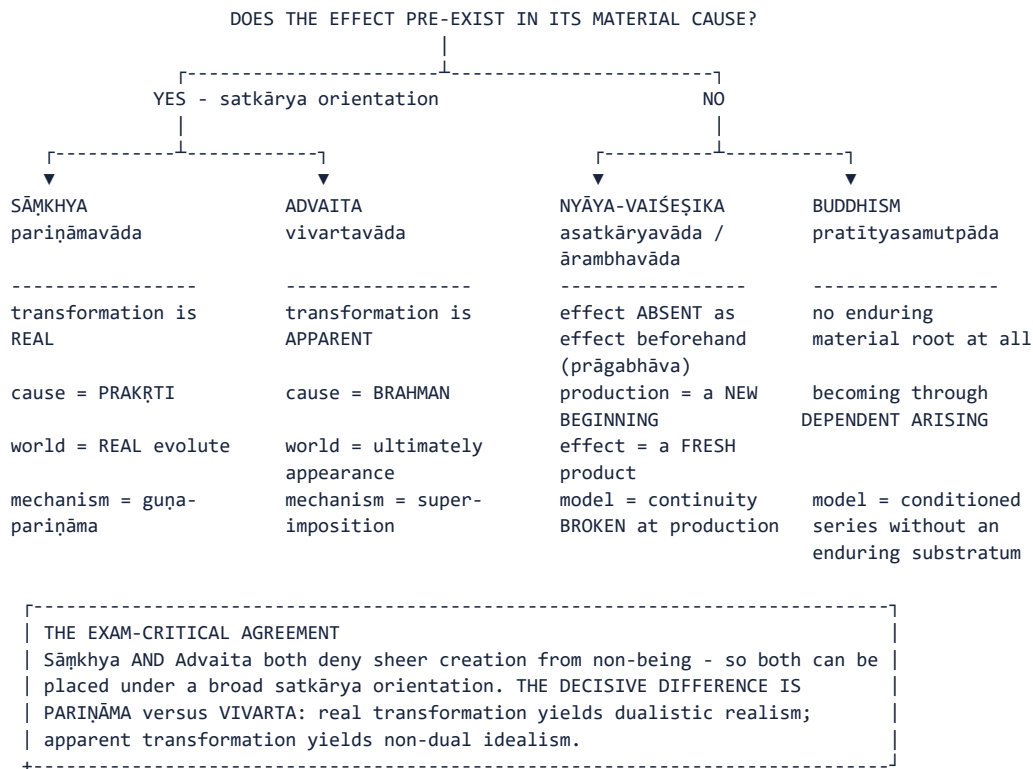
SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Hold four sentences apart:

- **Sāṃkhya:** the clay really becomes the pot.
- **Advaita:** the rope only appears to be a snake; nothing really becomes anything.
- **Nyāya:** the pot did not exist before, and production is a genuinely new beginning.
- **Buddhism:** there is no enduring clay at all; there is only conditioned arising.

The examiner's favourite trap is the first pair, because Sāṃkhya and Advaita agree that being does not come from non-being - and then disagree about everything else. Name the agreement, then make the disagreement decisive.

VISUAL - THE FOUR-WAY CAUSAL MAP



What the diagram shows: one question, one binary split, and then a second split inside the "yes" branch which is where most of the marks lie.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

What real transformation asserts. Sāṃkhya's pre-existence doctrine is specifically the doctrine of real transformation: the effect is a real transformation of the cause. It is **not** apparent transformation, because the world is not a mere appearance superimposed on an unchanged cause; it is the real evolution of nature. The mechanism is the modification of the qualities: the three qualities transform and recombine to produce the differentiated principles. In equilibrium each quality transforms homogeneously within its own nature; when equilibrium is disturbed the qualities transform heterogeneously and generate the manifest evolutes.

Three standing objections and their replies.

Objection	Sāṃkhya reply
If the effect already exists, causal effort becomes pointless.	Production is manifestation (abhivyakti) of what is latent; effort removes obstruction and supplies conditions - it does not create being out of non-being.
The doctrine abolishes the distinction between cause and effect.	Cause and effect differ by state (avasthā) : the cause is latent or unmanifest, the effect patent or manifest.
The doctrine implies the world was always exactly as it is now.	The gross effect is <i>not</i> already manifest; only the determinate capacity or effect-form exists latently in the cause.

Contrast with apparent transformation (Advaita).

Issue	Sāṃkhya	Advaita Vedānta
Type of transformation	real	apparent
Technical term	pariṇāma	vivarta
Cause	primordial nature	Brahman
Status of the world	real evolute	ultimately appearance

Both may be placed under a broad pre-existence orientation, but their accounts of transformation differ radically. This is the exact point on which the 2018 fifteen-marker turns.

How the Advaitins react to Sāṃkhya's real transformation of nature, and how Sāṃkhya defends itself. The Advaita reaction has three parts: an unconscious first principle cannot be the scripturally described conscious cause; a real transformation of the ultimate would make the ultimate mutable and hence dependent; and the world's dependence is better explained by superimposition than by evolution. Sāṃkhya's defence also has three parts: the continuity we observe between determinate causes and determinate effects is real and requires a real material continuity; treating the world as appearance leaves the *selectivity* of production unexplained, since appearances too would then be arbitrary; and Sāṃkhya's ultimate is not made mutable by evolution, because nature is *by definition* the principle whose being is modification, unlike a changeless Brahman.

Contrast with the non-pre-existent effect (Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika).

Issue	Sāṃkhya	Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika
Effect before production	pre-existent in the cause	absent as effect - prior non-existence (prāgabhāva)
Production	manifestation	new beginning
Causal model	continuity through transformation	the effect as a fresh product

This contrast is directly relevant to the routed 2023 question on prior non-existence and Sāṃkhya causation, and to the routed 2021 question "Does the seed contain the tree?".

Contrast with dependent origination (Buddhism). Buddhism explains becoming through dependent origination rather than an enduring unmanifest material root; Sāṃkhya explains becoming through the transformation of enduring nature. A crisp contrast line is usually enough unless the question explicitly asks for a Buddhist comparison.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- **pariṇāma** versus **vivarta** versus **prāgabhāva** / **ārambhavāda** versus **pratītyasamutpāda**.
- **Manifestation (abhivyakti)** and **difference of state (avasthā)** as the two standard replies.
- Quality-modification as the mechanism, with the homogeneous/heterogeneous pair from Session 7.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The dispute between Sāṃkhya and Advaita is not about whether being can come from non-being - both deny that - but about whether an ultimate principle can change without ceasing to be ultimate, and Sāṃkhya's answer is that it can, because its ultimate is defined as that whose very being is modification.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **real transformation (pariṇāmavāda)** versus **apparent transformation (vivartavāda)**
- **non-pre-existence (asatkāryavāda)** / **new beginning (ārambhavāda)**
- **prior non-existence (prāgabhāva)**
- **manifestation (abhivyakti); difference of state (avasthā)**
- **modification of the qualities (guṇa-pariṇāma)**
- **dependent origination (pratītyasamutpāda)** as the Buddhist contrast

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Sāṃkhya's distinctive causal thesis is not the pre-existence of the effect, which it shares with Advaita, but the reality of the transformation by which the effect is manifested.

Named evidence. Its mechanism is the modification of the qualities, homogeneous within each quality during equilibrium and heterogeneous when equilibrium is disturbed; against the charge of redundant effort it answers that production is manifestation (**abhivyakti**), and against the charge that cause and effect collapse it answers that they differ by state (**avasthā**).

Analysis. This lets Sāṃkhya occupy a position no rival holds: unlike Nyāya it keeps material continuity unbroken through production, and unlike Advaita it keeps the resulting world fully real, so that bondage and liberation are events in a real order rather than corrections of an illusion.

Qualification. The position is exposed on exactly one flank: an ultimate that genuinely changes invites the Vedāntic question of what sustains its changes, and Sāṃkhya's answer - that nature is by nature modification - is a definition rather than a further explanation.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

2018 Q7(b) (15 marks) asks precisely how the Advaita Vedāntins react to Sāṃkhya's real transformation of nature and how the Sāṃkhyas defend their position. **2020 Q7(a)** requires the rival-rejection half of this session. The routed **2022 Q5(e)** on whether apparent transformation is the logical development of real transformation is answered from the same map.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** claim the pre-existence doctrine is unique to Sāṃkhya. Advaita holds it too.
- Do **not** describe Advaita as denying causation. It denies *real* transformation.
- Do **not** say Nyāya denies that the material cause is determinate; it denies that the effect pre-exists as the effect.
- Do **not** answer the 2018 question with the five pre-existence arguments alone; the demand is the Advaita reaction *and* the Sāṃkhya defence.

RAPID REVISION

- Four positions: real transformation · apparent transformation · new beginning · dependent arising.
- Shared premise with Advaita: no being from non-being. Decisive difference: real versus apparent.
- Three replies: manifestation · difference of state · only the capacity is latent.
- Nyāya contrast term: prior non-existence.
- One line: *the effect is old in substance and new in state*.

SESSION 14 - BONDAGE, DISCRIMINATIVE KNOWLEDGE, ISOLATION AND NON-THEISM

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. Bondage is a mistake, not a chain. Liberation is the correction of the mistake, not an escape or a reward. And no God is required at either end.

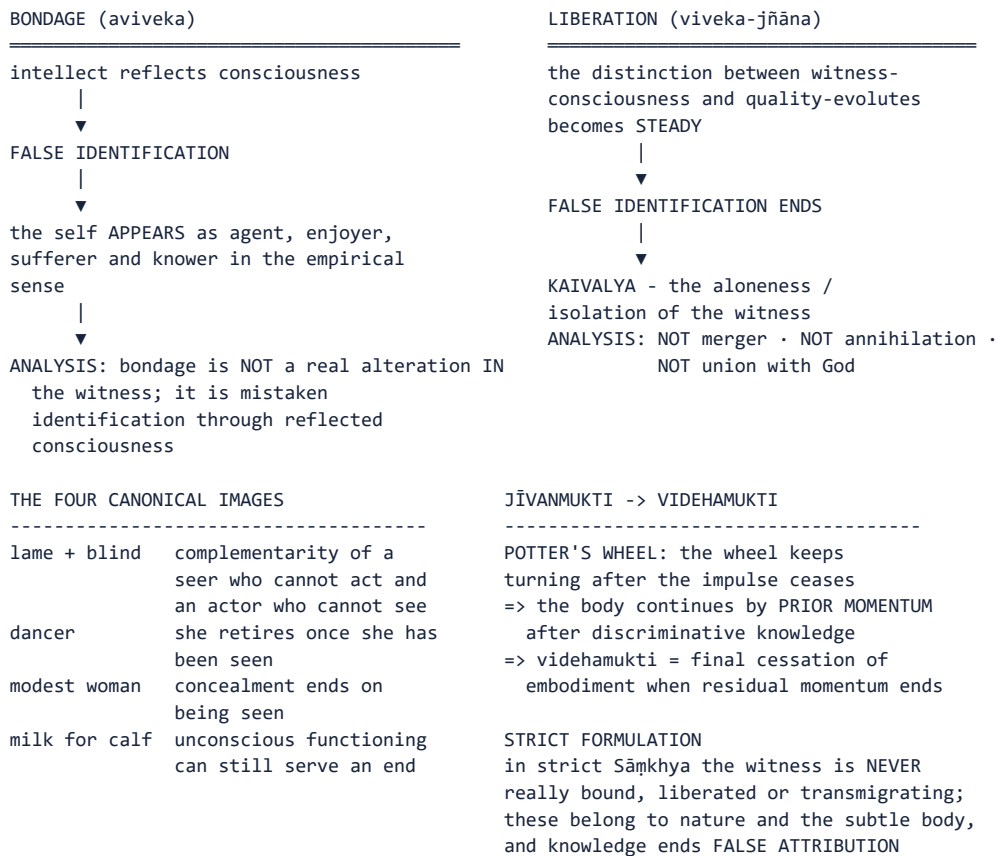
Technical definition. Bondage is non-discrimination (**aviveka**) between the witness and nature. Liberation is discriminative knowledge (**viveka-jñāna**) that "I am not nature", and the resulting state is isolation (**kaivalya**) - the aloneness of the witness. Liberation while the body persists is **jīvanmukti**; final cessation of embodiment is **videhamukti**. The classical account is non-theistic (**nirīśvara**).

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Two words to keep separate: *isolation* and *union*. Almost every other Indian soteriology moves the self toward something - identity with Brahman, service to God, cessation of a series. Sāṃkhya moves the self away from something. Isolation is disentanglement, not merger and not annihilation.

The second thing to fix: nothing actually changes in the witness at liberation. What changes is that nature stops performing for it. That is why the dancer image is the most precise picture the school has.

VISUAL - THE BONDAGE-TO-ISOLATION CIRCUIT



WHY NO GOD IS NEEDED (nirīśvara) - five standard arguments

- 1 a God acting from desire or motive is neither perfect nor free
- 2 an eternally fulfilled God has NO MOTIVE to create a painful world
- 3 if God distributes results under karma, divine independence is limited; if distribution is arbitrary, justice fails
- 4 an immutable conscious God cannot be the MATERIAL source of a changing unconscious world under Sāṃkhya's cause-effect continuity
- 5 eternal witnesses and primordial nature ALREADY explain consciousness and material evolution without a creator hypothesis

What the diagram shows: a two-column circuit with the same components running in opposite directions, plus the images, the two stages of release, and the five non-theistic arguments.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

1. Bondage. Bondage is non-discrimination between the witness and nature. The intellect reflects consciousness, and this reflection creates false identification; the self then appears as agent, enjoyer, sufferer and knower in the empirical sense. Bondage is **not** a real alteration in the witness but mistaken identification through reflected consciousness.

2. Liberation. Liberation is discriminative knowledge - the knowledge that "I am not nature". When the distinction between witness-consciousness and quality-evolutes becomes steady, false identification ends. This state is isolation, the aloneness of the witness. Isolation is not merger; it is disentanglement.

3. The lame-and-blind image. The witness is like the lame man: conscious but inactive. Nature is like the blind man: active but unconscious. Together they explain empirical process. The image conveys complementarity without collapsing the two principles into one.

4. The dancer image. Nature is like a dancer who stops after being seen by the witness. Once discriminative knowledge arises, nature no longer continues its binding display for that witness. This is the neatest canonical image for liberation through fulfilled disclosure.

5. Two stages of release. Liberation while the body still continues, due to prior momentum, is **jīvanmukti**; the standard analogy is the potter's wheel that keeps turning even after the impulse ceases. Final cessation of embodiment, when the body falls and residual momentum ends, is **videhamukti**.

6. The strict textual nuance. This is stronger than "the witness becomes free": in strict Sāṃkhya the conscious witness is never really bound, liberated or transmigrating. These processes belong to nature and the subtle body,

while discriminative knowledge ends false attribution. In Sāṃkhya this remains isolation of consciousness, not union with God.

7. Non-theism, argued. No God is required for either bondage or liberation in classical Sāṃkhya. Nature's purposive evolution for the witness's experience and release is treated as sufficient. The classical position is better described as non-theistic or God-unproved than as a proof that no divine being can exist: primordial nature and conscious witnesses are held sufficient for the explanatory work. The five standard supporting arguments are set out in the visual above and should be reproduced as numbered points.

8. Two boundary cautions. Later Sāṃkhya writers such as Vijñānabhikṣu develop more theistic interpretations; do not project them back into Īśvarakṛṣṇa's classical non-theistic system. And this is precisely why classical Sāṃkhya must be clearly separated from Yoga, which adds a special conscious witness identified as God and owns the practical discipline.

9. Isolation is not the same as the rival goals. Isolation is the aloneness of the witness; release in Advaita is identity with Brahman; release in Nyāya is the cessation of suffering. Three different goals with three different technical names.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- **Non-discrimination (aviveka), discriminative knowledge (viveka-jñāna), **isolation (kaivalya)**.**
- The four images: lame and blind; the dancer; the modest woman; milk for the calf.
- **Jīvanmukti / videhamukti** with the potter's-wheel analogy.
- The five non-theistic arguments.
- The strict formulation that the witness is never really bound or liberated.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

In Sāṃkhya nothing whatever happens to the witness at liberation; what happens is that nature stops performing for it - which is why the school's decisive image is not a prisoner released but a dancer who leaves the stage once she has been seen.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **non-discrimination (aviveka) -> discriminative knowledge (viveka-jñāna) -> **isolation (kaivalya)****
- **false appropriation (abhimāna)** as the psychological root
- **jīvanmukti** and **videhamukti**; the **potter's wheel**
- **non-theistic (nirīśvara), not anti-theistic-by-proof**
- **isolation ≠ identity with Brahman ≠ cessation of suffering**

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Sāṃkhya's soteriology is cognitive and subtractive: liberation removes a misidentification rather than producing a new state of the self.

Named evidence. Bondage is non-discrimination generated by the reflection of consciousness in the intellect; liberation is discriminative knowledge that stabilises the distinction between witness and quality-evolutes; and the canonical image is the dancer who retires once she has been seen, with the potter's wheel explaining why the body persists after knowledge arises.

Analysis. Because the witness is changeless, liberation cannot be an alteration in it; the strict formulation is therefore that the witness is never really bound or released at all, and that knowledge ends a false attribution located in nature's own evolutes.

Qualification. This is internally consistent, but it displaces rather than dissolves the difficulty: if the witness was never bound, the school must explain in what sense there was ever a problem for *it*, and Sāṃkhya's answer - that the problem was always one of attribution - is a clarification of the question rather than a demonstration.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

Supplies the closing paragraph for **2018 Q5(e)** (differential liberation as a plurality argument), for **2019 Q5(d)** (the empirical self dissolves, the witness does not), and for **2022 Q5(a)** (the fifth proof is precisely the striving for isolation). The non-theistic block is the Sāṃkhya-side material for **2025 Q7(a)**.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** equate isolation with identity with Brahman or with the cessation of suffering.
- Do **not** say the witness *attains* isolation as a new state; it is disentanglement.
- Do **not** call classical Sāṃkhya theistic on the strength of later commentators.
- Do **not** describe liberation as the destruction of nature. Nature ceases to act *for* that witness*.
- Do **not** merge liberation-while-living with final release; the potter's wheel marks the gap.

RAPID REVISION

- Bondage = non-discrimination; liberation = discriminative knowledge; state = isolation.
- Four images: lame-blind · dancer · modest woman · milk for calf.
- Two stages: liberation-while-living -> final release; potter's wheel explains the gap.
- Five non-theistic arguments; classical position is God-unproved, not disproved.
- One line: *the witness does not go anywhere; the performance simply ends.*

SESSION 15 - THE CONTACT PROBLEM, ŚAṂKARA'S CRITIQUE, INTER-SCHOOL PLACEMENT AND VERDICT

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. If the witness never acts and nature is never conscious, how do they ever get together? Sāṃkhya answers "by mere presence". Śaṃkara answers that mere presence is not an answer - and because Sāṃkhya is his most serious rival, he attacks it hardest.

Technical definition. The contact problem is the objection that two radically heterogeneous ultimates - an inactive conscious witness and an unconscious active nature - cannot stand in any intelligible real relation. Sāṃkhya replies that the relation is mere proximity or presence (**sānnidhya**), not gross physical contact. Śaṃkara treats Sāṃkhya as the chief opponent (**pradhāna malla**) and argues that an unconscious chief principle cannot be the scripturally described cause, that the relation remains unintelligible, and that purposiveness requires intelligence.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

The wrestling metaphor is worth remembering because it tells you the shape of the answer. A **pradhāna malla** is the chief wrestler - the opponent you must beat first, because beating anyone else proves nothing. Śaṃkara does not treat Sāṃkhya as chief because it is closest to the truth in content, but because it is the most systematically formidable rival: it explains world, self, bondage, liberation and causation from a single ultimate principle, exactly as Advaita does.

So a good 2025 answer has two halves: *why chief* (proximity of ambition and method) and *why rejected* (four specific objections). Candidates who write only the second half lose the question.

VISUAL - THE RELATION PROBLEM AND THE FOUR-POINT CRITIQUE

THE PROBLEM

PURUṢA is INACTIVE
PRAKṚTI is UNCONSCIOUS
↓
how can they RELATE at all?
yet the whole system depends on
SOME relation to explain evolution,
bondage and liberation

TWO ANALOGIES, TWO DIFFERENT JOBS

MAGNET AND IRON	CLEAR CRYSTAL AND NEARBY FLOWER
explains ACTIVATION BY PRESENCE	explains APPARENT CONTAMINATION WITHOUT REAL CHANGE

THE SĀMḲHYA ANSWER

the relation is SĀNNIDHYA -
mere PROXIMITY or PRESENCE,
not gross physical contact
↓
the witness does not push or alter
nature by action; nature becomes
ACTIVE IN THE MERE PRESENCE of the
witness

ŚAMKARA'S FOUR OBJECTIONS

- 1 UNCONSCIOUS NATURE CANNOT BE THE UPANIṢADIC CAUSE - the scriptural source is described as conscious, knowing, being-and-consciousness
- 2 THE CONTACT PROBLEM IS UNRESOLVED - inactive witness + unconscious nature cannot intelligibly relate
- 3 TELEOLOGY WITHOUT CONSCIOUSNESS - if nature evolves "for the sake of" the witness, purposiveness seems to require intelligence
- 4 "KNOWING-CAUSE" TEXTS (tājñā-type) EXCLUDE an insentient nature

WHY SĀMḲHYA IS THE CHIEF RIVAL

- A closest systematic rival: it explains world, self, bondage, liberation and causation in one coherent system
- B real transformation is the NEAREST RIVAL to apparent transformation
- C both appeal to a SINGLE ULTIMATE EXPLANATORY GROUND - unconscious nature versus conscious Brahman
=> the contest is direct, so the refutation must be detailed

ANALYSIS: WHY THE MAGNET ANALOGY IS ATTACKED: even a magnet EXERTS FORCE; if the witness were like that, it would not be wholly inactive.

ANALYSIS: WHY THE CRYSTAL ANALOGY IS ATTACKED: it may explain APPEARANCE, but not the INITIATION of the world-process.

=> VERDICT PREPARED BY ŚAMKARA: the dualism is unstable - it either collapses toward monism or requires a third mediating principle.

What the diagram shows: the problem, the reply, the two analogies with their distinct jobs, the four objections, and the three reasons the rivalry is chief rather than marginal.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

A. The contact problem. If the witness is inactive and nature is unconscious, how can they relate at all? Yet the entire system depends on some relation between them to explain evolution, bondage and liberation.

B. The Sāṃkhya response. The relation is mere proximity or presence (sānnidhya), not gross physical contact. The witness does not push or alter nature by action; nature becomes active in the mere presence of the witness.

C. The two analogies. The magnet and iron explains activation by presence: as a magnet moves iron without deliberative willing, the witness's presence occasions nature's activity. The clear crystal and the nearby flower explains apparent contamination without real change: as a crystal appears coloured by a nearby flower without itself changing, the witness appears affected by nature without real transformation. The first explains initiation; the second explains appearance. Keep them distinct.

D. Śamkara's attack on the analogies. The magnet analogy fails because even a magnet exerts force; if the witness were like that, it would not be wholly inactive. The crystal analogy may explain appearance, but not the initiation of the world-process. Therefore Sāṃkhya dualism appears unstable: either it collapses toward monism or it requires a third mediating principle.

E. Why Sāṃkhya is the chief opponent. Three reasons, all of which must be written.

1. It is the most sophisticated non-Vedāntic rival at the level of ultimate explanation, explaining world, self, bondage, liberation and causation through a coherent metaphysical system. It is therefore not marginal but philosophically near enough to require detailed refutation.
2. Real transformation is the nearest rival to apparent transformation. Both aim to explain the world

from an ultimate principle; Sāṃkhya takes transformation as real while Advaita takes it as apparent. This causal proximity is one reason Śaṃkara treats Sāṃkhya as chief opponent.

3. Both appeal to a single ultimate explanatory ground - Sāṃkhya through one primal material principle, Advaita through conscious Brahman. Because both are large-scale metaphysical explanations, the contest is direct.

F. Śaṃkara's four objections. Unconscious nature cannot be the Upaniṣadic cause, because the scriptural source is described as conscious, knowing and of the character of being-and-consciousness. The contact problem remains unresolved. Teleology cannot be explained without consciousness. And texts describing the cause as knowing exclude an insentient nature.

G. Exam conclusion. Śaṃkara calls Sāṃkhya his chief opponent because it is the strongest rival causal-metaphysical system; he rejects it because the ultimate cause must be conscious, teleology cannot rest on unconscious nature, and the witness-nature relation remains unstable.

H. Inter-school placement - the debate axes.

Debate axis	Sāṃkhya	Rival	High-yield contrast
Self	many witnesses	Advaita	one self/Brahman versus many witnesses
Causation	pre-existent effect + real transformation	Nyāya	pre-existent effect versus prior non-existence and new beginning
World-process	rooted in nature	Buddhism	enduring material root versus dependent origination
God	non-theistic	Yoga / Nyāya / Vedānta	no God needed versus explicit God or Brahman
Liberation	isolation	Advaita / Nyāya	isolation versus identity versus cessation of suffering

In cross-school answers Sāṃkhya is often the benchmark for real causation and for strict consciousness-matter dualism.

I. Sāṃkhya against Cārvāka. The contrast is worth one line in any epistemology-facing answer. Cārvāka admits perception alone and therefore rejects the inference to imperceptible entities; Sāṃkhya admits three instruments and rests its two ultimates on general-correlation inference. The Sāṃkhya reply to the Cārvāka is that strict perceptualism cannot explain ordinary causal reasoning either.

J. Sāṃkhya against Yoga, stated as a friendly amendment. Yoga retains the broad metaphysics of nature, the qualities and many witnesses, but adds God, a stronger practical discipline, devotion to God and the yogi's perception. Hence Sāṃkhya is non-theistic and more theoretical, while Yoga is theistic and more practical.

K. The four standing criticisms and Sāṃkhya's replies.

Criticism	Sāṃkhya reply	Residual force
Teleology without intelligence: how can unconscious nature evolve purposively?	Purposive functioning need not involve conscious planning; the quality-structure itself yields ordered manifestation in the presence of the witness.	Preserves system-internal sufficiency but remains vulnerable to Vedāntic criticism.
Relation between two absolutes: if the two are radically different, how can misidentification occur?	Through proximity, reflection and false attribution rather than real fusion.	Partly explanatory and partly analogical; critics see it as the school's weakest point.
Multiplicity of witnesses is unnecessary: could not one consciousness appear as many?	Non-simultaneous liberation, individual experience and differentiated embodiment support plurality.	Advaita's limiting-adjunct reply is not thereby answered.
The pre-existence doctrine removes novelty: if the effect exists, production is redundant.	Production is manifestation from latent to patent, not pointless repetition.	Nyāya can still press that new properties mark a genuinely new substance.

L. The graded verdict.

What is strong. Sāṃkhya is a rigorously argued non-theistic realism rather than a loose mythology of evolution. Its theory of the qualities is one of the most economical Indian accounts of qualitative variety. The pre-existence doctrine is a genuinely powerful causal thesis because it explains determinate production and material continuity. Its separation of consciousness from mental function anticipates the modern distinction between phenomenal consciousness and cognitive processing.

What is weak. The witness-nature relation is under-explained. Unconscious teleology remains difficult. The individuation of attributeless witnesses is the weakest point in the plurality doctrine. The beginning of bondage is obscure, because the witness is never really modified and nature is beginningless.

What is genuinely contested. Whether early Sāṃkhya was originally theistic or consistently non-theistic remains debated. Whether isolation is purely negative or has a positive phenomenological character is disputed. The relation between the Kārikā tradition and the later Sūtra tradition is historically and doctrinally contested.

Ready verdicts by length. At ten marks: Sāṃkhya is strongest as a concise dualist realism - one nature explains the world, many witnesses explain experience, discrimination explains liberation. At fifteen: its power lies in the mutual fit of instruments of knowledge, the pre-existent effect, the theory of the qualities and isolation, though the contact problem invites Vedāntic criticism. At twenty: it is a philosophically serious non-theistic system whose causal realism and psychology of reflection are impressive, but whose unconscious teleology and plurality of attributeless witnesses remain unresolved pressure points.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- **Mere proximity (sānnidhya)**; the magnet-and-iron and crystal-and-flower analogies with their distinct jobs.
- **Chief wrestler (pradhāna malla)** and the three reasons for the designation.
- Śaṅkara's four objections, including the knowing-cause texts.
- The five-axis debate table and the four criticisms with replies.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Śaṅkara honours Sāṃkhya by attacking it: he calls it the chief wrestler precisely because it attempts, from an unconscious first principle, the very thing Advaita attempts from a conscious one - a total explanation of world, self, bondage and release from a single ultimate ground.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **mere proximity (sānnidhya)**; magnet and iron; crystal and flower
- **chief wrestler (pradhāna malla)**
- **the knowing-cause objection (tājñā-type texts)**
- **teleology without intelligence**
- **unstable dualism: monism or a third mediating principle**
- **isolation versus identity versus cessation of suffering**

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Śaṅkara's designation of Sāṃkhya as chief opponent is a judgement about systematic strength, and his refutation targets the exact point at which that strength becomes instability.

Named evidence. Sāṃkhya answers the relation question by mere proximity (**sānnidhya**), supported by the magnet moving iron and the crystal coloured by a nearby flower; Śaṅkara replies that a magnet exerts force and so cannot model an inactive witness, that a crystal explains appearance but not initiation, and that the scripturally described cause is conscious and knowing.

Analysis. The critique is well aimed because Sāṃkhya's two analogies do different jobs and neither does both: activation by presence and appearance without change are separate explananda, so the school has two partial models where it needs one complete account of how the world-process begins.

Qualification. Śaṃkara's own alternative is not thereby established by this argument alone; what follows is that Sāṃkhya's dualism is unstable - tending either toward monism or toward a third mediating principle - which is a demand for further explanation rather than a demonstration that the Advaita account is correct.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

2025 Q7(a) (20 marks) asks directly why Śaṃkara considers Sāṃkhya his chief opponent and to examine his arguments. **2023 Q5(b) (10 marks)** gives the relation problem as a quoted statement and asks for a brief presentation of Śaṃkara's criticism. Section K supplies the evaluative close for **2022 Q5(a)**, and Section L supplies graded verdicts for every twenty-marker in the topic.

UPSC TRAPS

- Do **not** translate the chief-wrestler title as "chief error" or "chief enemy of scripture". It marks systematic strength.
- Do **not** answer 2025 with objections alone; the first half of the question is *why chief*.
- Do **not** merge the two analogies. One explains initiation, the other explains appearance.
- Do **not** claim Śaṃkara refutes Sāṃkhya's realism by asserting Advaita; the argument is that the dualism is unstable.
- Do **not** present the criticisms without the Sāṃkhya replies; "critically examine" requires both.

RAPID REVISION

- Problem: inactive witness + unconscious nature => what relation?
- Answer: mere proximity; magnet = activation, crystal = appearance.
- Chief wrestler for three reasons: systematic completeness · real versus apparent transformation · single ultimate ground.
- Four objections: unconscious cause · unresolved relation · teleology · knowing-cause texts.
- Verdict: strong causal realism, weak at relation, teleology and individuation.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Practice protocol

Attempt every item before reading its key. The correct position was fixed **independently for each question** from a randomised draw, so there is no rotation, cycle or seed-derived sequence to exploit; the four positions occur eight times each and twice in every consecutive block of eight, and no position repeats on consecutive questions. Option length, specificity, grammar and formatting are balanced so that the correct answer is not visually identifiable. Every option carries a question-specific explanation and every question carries a unique examiner trap.

Composition: 24 core diagnostics (items 1-24) covering all fifteen teaching sessions, then 8 remedial drills (items 25-32) targeting the errors this topic reliably produces.

CORE DIAGNOSTICS

MCQ 1. Why the system begins from suffering

Consider the following statements about the starting point of Sāṃkhya inquiry.

1. Affliction is classified as internal, as caused by other beings and the material surroundings, and as attributed to cosmic or unseen agencies.
2. Scripturally promised results are rejected as false rather than as exhaustible.
3. The remedy the system seeks must correct a misidentification rather than manufacture a state.

Which of the statements is or are correct?

A. Statements 1 and 3 only, because ritual results are graded as perishable rather than false B. Statements 2 and 3 only, since Sāṃkhya treats every Vedic promise as an outright fabrication C. Statement 1 only, because the required remedy is an action performed with detached intention D. All three statements, as the school denies any efficacy whatever to visible or ritual means

Answer: A. Statements 1 and 3 only, because ritual results are graded as perishable rather than false

- **A:** Correct - the threefold classification is stated exactly as in statement 1, and the demand for a non-productive remedy is what makes liberation cognitive rather than active.
- **B:** Wrong on statement 2: Sāṃkhya grades ritual means as incomplete and exhaustible because a produced result is perishable; it does not call them fabrications.
- **C:** Wrong twice: it drops the correct statement 3, and it replaces discriminative knowledge with detached action, which is a Bhagavad-gītā formula and not the Sāṃkhya remedy.
- **D:** Wrong because it endorses statement 2; the school allows visible and ritual means real but partial efficacy within the field of nature.

Examiner trap 1: Candidates upgrade "incomplete and exhaustible" into "false", which converts a graded critique of ritual means into a blanket rejection the school never makes.

MCQ 2. Which text controls the classical position

Which statement about the textual identity of classical Sāṃkhya is accurate?

A. Kapila's own foundational work is extant and supplies the school's controlling formulations B. The *Sāṃkhyapravacana-sūtra* is the earliest systematic text and fixes the classical doctrine C. Vācaspati Miśra's *Tattvakaumudī* is the earliest extant systematic statement of the system D. Īśvarakṛṣṇa's *Sāṃkhyakārikā* is the earliest extant systematic classical text of the school

Answer: D. Īśvarakṛṣṇa's Sāṃkhyakārikā is the earliest extant systematic classical text of the school

- **A:** Kapila is the traditional founder, but the foundational works of the Kapila-Āsuri-Pañcaśikha lineage are not extant in securely recoverable form and cannot be quoted.
- **B:** The *Sāṃkhyapravacana-sūtra* belongs to a later textual phase, associated with more theistic readings, and must never be projected back into the classical system.
- **C:** The *Tattvakaumudī* is a major commentary on the Kārikā and therefore presupposes it; a commentary cannot be the earliest systematic statement.
- **D:** Correct - the Kārikā is the classical baseline, with Gauḍapāda's commentary and Vācaspati Miśra's *Tattvakaumudī* as its major explanatory traditions.

Examiner trap 2: A later theistic commentary is cited as evidence about the classical position, which quietly deletes the non-theism that the Kārikā system deliberately argues for.

MCQ 3. The exhaustive set of instruments of knowledge

Which set exhausts the means of valid knowledge (**pramāṇa**) admitted by classical Sāṃkhya?

A. Perception (pratyakṣa), inference (anumāna) and reliable testimony (āptavacana or śabda) B. Perception, inference, comparison (upamāna) and reliable testimony, as in classical Nyāya C. Perception and inference alone, as in the Buddhist epistemological tradition of two instruments D. Six instruments including postulation (arthāpatti) and non-apprehension (anupalabdhi)

Answer: A. Perception (pratyakṣa), inference (anumāna) and reliable testimony (āptavacana or śabda)

- **A:** Correct - exactly three instruments are admitted, and all other candidates are reduced to or included within them rather than rejected outright.
- **B:** Four instruments including comparison is the classical Nyāya count; Sāṃkhya reduces comparison to inference or testimony instead of admitting it separately.
- **C:** Two instruments is the Buddhist epistemological count; Sāṃkhya retains reliable testimony because scriptural authority is available to an orthodox school.
- **D:** Six instruments including postulation and non-apprehension is the standard Advaita count; Sāṃkhya absorbs both rather than listing them.

Examiner trap 3: The Advaita six-instrument list and the Nyāya four-instrument list are transferred to Sāṃkhya, destroying the inferential burden that the three-instrument restriction creates.

MCQ 4. How the surplus instruments are absorbed

Match each candidate instrument with the Sāṃkhya reduction assigned to it.

Candidate	Reduction
1. comparison (upamāna)	P. included under perception's failure-conditions
2. non-apprehension (anupalabdhi)	Q. included in testimony when it becomes reliable
3. traditional report (aitihya)	R. included in inference or in testimony

A. 1-P, 2-Q, 3-R B. 1-R, 2-P, 3-Q C. 1-Q, 2-R, 3-P D. 1-P, 2-R, 3-Q

Answer: B. 1-R, 2-P, 3-Q

- **A:** Misassigns comparison to the failure-conditions of perception, which is the treatment reserved for non-apprehension, and leaves traditional report in the wrong column.
- **B:** Correct - similarity works through a prior verbal report applied inferentially; non-perception means the conditions for perceiving are absent; and mere tradition counts only once it is trustworthy.
- **C:** Reverses the entire mapping, treating comparison as testimony-dependent only and non-apprehension as inferential, neither of which is the stated reduction.
- **D:** Places traditional report rightly but assigns comparison to perception's failure-conditions and non-apprehension to inference, reversing both of those.

Examiner trap 4: Non-apprehension is treated as an inference from absence, whereas Sāṃkhya locates it in the failure-conditions of perception and therefore needs no new instrument at all.

MCQ 5. Why the imperceptibility of the root does not refute it

An opponent argues that primordial material nature cannot exist because nobody perceives it. What is the precise Sāṃkhya reply?

A. Perception is not a means of valid knowledge at all, so its silence carries no evidential weight
B. Scriptural testimony settles the matter independently, so no inferential defence is required
C. Nature is perceived by the conscious witness directly, though not by the external capacities
D. Non-perception can follow from subtlety, which is one of the standard causes of non-perception

Answer: D. Non-perception can follow from subtlety, which is one of the standard causes of non-perception

- **A:** Perception is the first admitted instrument in Sāṃkhya; denying its validity would collapse the school's own three-instrument scheme.
- **B:** Testimony alone would beg the question against a non-Vedic opponent, which is exactly why the argumentative burden is shifted to inference.
- **C:** The witness never perceives objects; it illuminates the intellect's operations, and nature remains beyond the senses for it as well.
- **D:** Correct - subtlety (**saukṣmya**) sits in the standard list of causes of non-perception alongside distance, organ-defect, obstruction and admixture.

Examiner trap 5: The reply is compressed into "it is inferred", omitting the causes-of-non-perception list that alone converts imperceptibility from a refutation into a datum requiring inference.

MCQ 6. Division of labour inside the inner instrument

Which statement correctly describes the functions of the inner instrument?

A. The coordinating mind determines and judges, while the intellect merely gathers sense-data
B. The I-maker performs the final ascertainment and the intellect appropriates its results
C. The intellect makes the final ascertainment, the I-maker appropriates and the mind coordinates
D. All three functions are interchangeable names for a single undivided act of the mind

Answer: C. The intellect makes the final ascertainment, the I-maker appropriates and the mind coordinates

- **A:** Inverts the two decisive roles: the mind coordinates and synthesises sense-data, while ascertainment belongs to the intellect alone.
- **B:** Assigns ascertainment to the I-maker, whose sole function is appropriation as "I" and "mine", and reduces the intellect to a recipient.
- **C:** Correct - ascertainment (**adhyavasāya**) belongs to the intellect, appropriation to the I-maker and coordination to the mind.
- **D:** Collapses a threefold functional analysis into one act, which would make the derivation of the I-maker from the intellect unintelligible.

Examiner trap 6: The three inner functions are written as loose synonyms for "mind", which destroys the precise distinction the 2024 question explicitly demands.

MCQ 7. The two-way appearance

Consider the following statements about reflection in Sāṃkhya.

1. The insentient internal instrument appears conscious.
2. The inactive conscious witness appears to be an agent.
3. The witness undergoes a real modification when the reflection occurs.

Which of the statements is or are correct?

A. Statements 2 and 3 only, since apparent agency requires an actual change in the witness B. Statements 1 and 2 only, and the reflection leaves the witness entirely unmodified C. Statement 1 only, because the witness never appears to be an agent in any sense D. All three statements, as reflection is a real relation and therefore alters both relata

Answer: B. Statements 1 and 2 only, and the reflection leaves the witness entirely unmodified

- **A:** Statement 3 is false: a real modification of the witness would make bondage real, and a really bound changeless principle could never be released.
- **B:** Correct - the appearance is symmetrical and both terms are misdescribed, yet productive agency stays with nature and witnessing stays with the witness.
- **C:** Statement 2 is precisely what generates false appropriation, so excluding it removes the psychological root of bondage from the account.
- **D:** Endorsing statement 3 contradicts the changelessness that every proof of the witness presupposes.

Examiner trap 7: Reflection is described as an event that happens *to* the witness, whereas Sāṃkhya needs it to be an event that happens only in the transparent intellect.

MCQ 8. What "material" covers in this system

Which of the following is **not** an evolute of primordial material nature?

A. The determinative intellect, which is the first evolute and is predominantly luminous B. The coordinating mind, which arises from the luminous aspect of the principle of individuation C. The conscious witness, which is the twenty-fifth principle and neither cause nor effect D. The five subtle elements, which arise from the inert aspect of the principle of individuation

Answer: C. The conscious witness, which is the twenty-fifth principle and neither cause nor effect

- **A:** The intellect is the first evolute of nature and is placed in the "both cause and effect" class of the fourfold scheme.
- **B:** The mind belongs to the luminous line issuing from the I-maker and falls in the sixteen effects-only principles.
- **C:** Correct - the witness is counted twenty-fifth but is neither an evolvent nor an evolute; it stands outside the productive series.
- **D:** The subtle elements arise from the inert side of the I-maker and are themselves productive of the gross elements.

Examiner trap 8: "Material" is read as "physical", so intellect, ego and mind are moved out of nature and Sāṃkhya is misdescribed as a mind-body dualism.

MCQ 9. Which proof establishes that nature is one

Which argument for primordial material nature is the one that shows there can be only one such nature?

A. From the finitude and determinateness of things (bhedānām parimāṇāt) B. From the uniformity running through diverse effects (samanvayāt) C. From the distinction between cause and effect (kāraṇa-kārya-vibhāgāt) D. From the undivided source of the diversified universe (avibhāgāt vaiśvarūpyasya)

Answer: D. From the undivided source of the diversified universe (avibhāgāt vaiśvarūpyasya)

- **A:** Reasoning from limitation establishes that a subtler ground exists, but several such grounds would satisfy the inference equally well.
- **B:** Coordinated diversity suggests a common material basis, yet a coordinated plurality of bases is not excluded by the argument itself.
- **C:** Distinguishing manifest effect from unmanifest cause fixes the stage-relation, not the number of unmanifest causes.
- **D:** Correct - since cosmic diversity forms one interconnected whole, positing many disconnected roots would destroy the undividedness from which the inference proceeds.

Examiner trap 9: The proof is named without the bridge sentence, so the answer states a conclusion the examiner asked to have *justified* and forfeits the reasoning marks.

MCQ 10. The textual reading of the third proof

The third argument for primordial nature is best rendered as an argument from which of the following?

A. Purposive planning, which shows that an intelligent designer arranges the world-process B. Operation due to causal power, since only a cause with the relevant potency can produce an effect C. The testimony of scripture, which alone can establish an entity beyond the reach of the senses D. The observed regularity of natural laws, which presupposes a legislating cosmic intelligence

Answer: B. Operation due to causal power, since only a cause with the relevant potency can produce an effect

- **A:** Reading the proof as planning imports a design argument, which would be fatal to a system that denies a creator.
- **B:** Correct - the standard reading of *Sāṃkhyakārikā* 15 is **śaktiḥ pravṛtteś ca**, an argument from potency and operation rather than from intention.
- **C:** Testimony is admitted by Sāṃkhya but cannot carry this proof, since the point at issue is precisely what inference can establish against a non-Vedic opponent.
- **D:** Regularity requiring a legislator is a theistic formulation that the non-theistic argument from causal power is constructed to avoid.

Examiner trap 10: The variant reading *kāryataḥ pravṛtteḥ* is repeated, which turns an argument from power into an argument from purpose and converts non-theism into design.

MCQ 11. The three constituent qualities

Which pairing of quality, affective tone and evolutionary function is correct throughout?

- A. Luminosity-pain-concealment; activity-pleasure-manifestation; inertia-delusion-movement B. Luminosity-delusion-movement; activity-pleasure-concealment; inertia-pain-manifestation C. Luminosity-pleasure-manifestation; activity-pain-movement; inertia-delusion-concealment D. Luminosity-pleasure-movement; activity-delusion-manifestation; inertia-pain-concealment

Answer: C. Luminosity-pleasure-manifestation; activity-pain-movement; inertia-delusion-concealment

- **A:** Swaps the tones of the first two qualities and gives movement to inertia, whose function is precisely resistance and fixation.
- **B:** Assigns delusion to luminosity, although delusion is the standing affective correlate of inertia in every canonical listing.
- **C:** Correct - the triad maps character, affective tone and evolutionary function together, which is what makes it simultaneously physical, psychological and ethical.
- **D:** Right about the first affective tone but wrong about all three functions, since manifestation belongs to luminosity and movement to activity.

Examiner trap 11: The affective column is memorised without the functional column, so the answer cannot explain why the same triad governs cosmology and psychology at once.

MCQ 12. Two kinds of modification

Which statement correctly distinguishes homogeneous from heterogeneous modification of the qualities?

- A. Homogeneous modification occurs in equilibrium within each quality; heterogeneous modification generates the manifest evolutes B. Homogeneous modification generates the manifest evolutes; heterogeneous modification occurs only during cosmic dissolution C. Both kinds occur only after equilibrium is disturbed, since nature is entirely static while unmanifest D. Homogeneous modification belongs to the witness and heterogeneous modification belongs to nature

Answer: A. Homogeneous modification occurs in equilibrium within each quality; heterogeneous modification generates the manifest evolutes

- **A:** Correct - same-form transformation keeps nature dynamic while still undifferentiated, and cross-form transformation produces the differentiated principles.
- **B:** Exactly reverses the two, which would make the manifest world a feature of equilibrium and dissolution a period of active production.
- **C:** Denies that nature transforms while unmanifest, removing the reason Sāṃkhya can say dissolution is not annihilation.
- **D:** Assigns a modification to the witness, contradicting its changelessness and its exclusion from the quality-structure altogether.

Examiner trap 12: Only the table of the three qualities is reproduced for a question that asks for the qualities *and their modifications*, discarding half the printed demand.

MCQ 13. The status of the third proof for the witness

The argument from a presiding locus (**adhiṣṭhānāt**) infers which of the following?

A. An intelligent creator who arranges the psychophysical order from outside nature B. A cosmic mind that is itself an evolute of primordial nature and coordinates all beings C. A conscious witness in whose presence the unconscious system becomes an experienced order D. A permanent substance possessing cognition, volition and effort as adventitious qualities

Answer: C. A conscious witness in whose presence the unconscious system becomes an experienced order

- **A:** Reading the proof as a God-proof imports theism into a system that argues at length that no creator is required.
- **B:** A cosmic evolute would still be insentient, so it could not supply the conscious presence the argument is reaching for.
- **C:** Correct - the inference is to a presiding witness of lived order, and Sāṃkhya marks explicitly that this is not a proof of God.
- **D:** A substance with adventitious cognition and effort is the Nyāya self, which Sāṃkhya rejects because agency belongs to nature's evolutes.

Examiner trap 13: The third proof is presented as a design argument, so a non-theistic system is made to prove God in the middle of its own case for the witness.

MCQ 14. The nature of the conscious witness

Which description of the conscious witness is accurate in every element?

A. Consciousness is one of its qualities, and it acts, changes and produces the world for itself B. It is self-luminous, inactive, changeless, beyond the qualities, and a witness rather than a producer C. It is a conscious substance that really becomes bound and later really attains a new liberated state D. It is the material as well as the efficient cause of the world, though it remains unaffected by it

Answer: B. It is self-luminous, inactive, changeless, beyond the qualities, and a witness rather than a producer

- **A:** Treating consciousness as a quality would make it separable from the witness, and productive activity belongs entirely to nature.
- **B:** Correct - consciousness is the essence rather than a property, and every productive function is located on the side of nature.
- **C:** Real bondage and a really new state would both require modification, which the changelessness of the witness excludes.
- **D:** Nature is the material cause; making the witness a cause of any kind would destroy the division of labour the whole system rests on.

Examiner trap 14: Consciousness is described as an attribute the witness possesses, which quietly converts the Sāṃkhya witness into the Nyāya self with adventitious cognition.

MCQ 15. Source control on the plurality arguments

Which argument for a plurality of witnesses is **supplementary** rather than one of the three arguments of *Sāṃkhyakārikā* 18?

A. The fixed distribution of birth, death and the sense-faculties across different beings B. The non-simultaneity of activity, since beings act at different times and in different ways C. The differential constitution of beings by the three qualities in their temperaments D. The differential attainment of liberation, since some remain bound while another is released

Answer: D. The differential attainment of liberation, since some remain bound while another is released

- **A:** Fixed distribution of birth, death and faculties is the first of the three arguments that map directly onto the verse.
- **B:** Non-simultaneous activity is the second of the three verse-arguments and is regularly listed with the first.
- **C:** Differential constitution by the qualities is the third verse-argument and grounds the appeal to temperament.
- **D:** Correct - differential liberation is a standard supplementary inference and is not a fourth phrase in that verse; present it as reinforcement.

Examiner trap 15: A fourth argument is attributed to the verse itself, which is a checkable source error even when the philosophical content of the argument is sound.

MCQ 16. The Advaita objection to plurality

How does the Advaita objection to the plurality of witnesses proceed?

A. Every cited difference is a difference in limiting adjuncts, so at most many mental streams are proved B. Plurality is impossible because consciousness is inherently divisible into numerically distinct parts C. Plurality is unnecessary because Sāṃkhya could locate individuation in the subtle elements instead D. Plurality contradicts scripture, and Sāṃkhya therefore abandons the doctrine in its later phase

Answer: A. Every cited difference is a difference in limiting adjuncts, so at most many mental streams are proved

- **A:** Correct - bodies, minds and quality-configurations are adjuncts, and attributeless consciousness admits no principle of individuation of its own.
- **B:** Advaita holds consciousness to be partless and indivisible; divisibility is the opposite of its premise.
- **C:** Subtle elements are evolutes of nature, so relocating individuation there would still leave the witnesses undifferentiated.
- **D:** The plurality doctrine is retained throughout the classical school; no later phase abandons it on scriptural grounds.

Examiner trap 16: The objection is answered by simply repeating the plurality arguments, when the required reply is non-transferable bondage and release plus distinct reflected loci.

MCQ 17. The status of the empirical self

What is the metaphysical status of the empirical self (**jīva**) in Sāṃkhya?

A. A twenty-sixth principle standing between primordial nature and the conscious witness B. An evolute of the I-maker that possesses consciousness of its own in a derived degree C. The conscious witness as empirically conditioned through the intellect and the karmic stream D. A composite substance in which consciousness and materiality are really fused into one entity

Answer: C. The conscious witness as empirically conditioned through the intellect and the karmic stream

- **A:** Adding a further principle would break the enumeration of twenty-five, which is the content of the liberating knowledge itself.
- **B:** No evolute possesses consciousness in any degree; every evolute is insentient and only appears conscious by reflection.
- **C:** Correct - the empirical self is not a separate principle but the witness appearing through identification with intellect, ego, mind, body and karma.
- **D:** A real fusion would make bondage a genuine modification of the witness and would leave nothing for discriminative knowledge to correct.

Examiner trap 17: The empirical self is treated as a distinct entity to be enumerated, so the answer to the 2019 question loses the very identity claim it was asked to state.

MCQ 18. The order of evolution

Which sequence correctly states the opening of the evolutionary series?

A. Primordial nature, then the great one or determinative intellect, then the I-maker B. Primordial nature, then the great one, then the determinative intellect, then the I-maker C. Primordial nature, then the I-maker, then the determinative intellect, then the mind D. The conscious witness, then primordial nature, then the intellect, then the I-maker

Answer: A. Primordial nature, then the great one or determinative intellect, then the I-maker

- **A:** Correct - the great one and the determinative intellect are one principle under a cosmic and an individual name, and the I-maker emerges from it.
- **B:** Splitting the great one and the determinative intellect into two stages is the single most penalised error in this topic.
- **C:** Reverses intellect and ego; individuation presupposes the determinative function rather than preceding it.
- **D:** Places the witness inside the productive series, although it is expressly neither cause nor effect.

Examiner trap 18: The cosmic and individual names of one principle are counted as two successive evolutes, which also corrupts the total count of twenty-five.

MCQ 19. The fourfold cause-effect classification

In the fourfold classification of the twenty-five principles, how many are effects only?

A. Seven, comprising the determinative intellect, the I-maker and the five subtle elements B. Sixteen, comprising the mind, the ten capacities and the five gross elements C. Eleven, comprising the mind together with the five cognitive and five action capacities D. Twenty-four, comprising every principle other than the conscious witness itself

Answer: B. Sixteen, comprising the mind, the ten capacities and the five gross elements

- **A:** Seven is the count of principles that are *both* cause and effect, not of those that are effects only.
- **B:** Correct - one is evolvent only, seven are both, sixteen are effects only and one is neither, giving the standard 1 / 7 / 16 / 1 grid.
- **C:** Eleven counts only the capacities including the mind and omits the five gross elements from the effects-only class.
- **D:** Twenty-four is the total number of evolutes, which includes the seven that are also productive.

Examiner trap 19: The count of evolutes is confused with the count of effects-only principles, so the classification loses the discriminating work it was designed to do.

MCQ 20. What the active quality contributes

Which statement about the active aspect of the I-maker is correct?

A. It supplies energy to both lines of evolution and produces no separate set of principles B. It produces a distinct third series of principles alongside the luminous and inert lines C. It produces the five subtle elements, while the inert aspect produces the gross elements D. It ceases to operate once the two lines of evolution have been completely generated

Answer: A. It supplies energy to both lines of evolution and produces no separate set of principles

- **A:** Correct - activity contributes operative force to the luminous and inert lines alike, which is why the total remains twenty-five.
- **B:** A third product-series would inflate the enumeration and would leave the standard totals of the fourfold classification unexplained.
- **C:** The subtle elements belong to the inert line; assigning them to activity misplaces the origin of the elemental series.
- **D:** Activity is a permanent constituent of nature, present in every evolute in some proportion, and does not switch off.

Examiner trap 20: A third evolutionary line is invented for the active quality, which is the commonest way of arriving at a wrong tally of principles.

MCQ 21. Counting the subtle body

The subtle body is commonly counted as how many constituents, and which are they?

A. Seventeen: the determinative intellect, the I-maker, the ten capacities and the five subtle elements B. Thirteen: the three inner functions together with the five cognitive and five action capacities C. Twenty-three: every evolute of primordial nature apart from the five gross elements themselves D. Eighteen: the determinative intellect, the I-maker, the eleven capacities and the five subtle elements

Answer: D. Eighteen: the determinative intellect, the I-maker, the eleven capacities and the five subtle elements

- **A:** Seventeen results from dropping the mind out of the eleven capacities, which is the standard arithmetic slip here.
- **B:** Thirteen is the count of the thirteenfold instrument, a different functional grouping that excludes the subtle elements.
- **C:** Twenty-three would include the gross elements' predecessors indiscriminately and does not match the transmigratory vehicle.
- **D:** Correct - one plus one plus eleven plus five gives eighteen, with the eleven comprising the mind and the ten capacities.

Examiner trap 21: The mind is omitted from the eleven capacities, producing seventeen and quietly removing the coordinating function from the transmigrating vehicle.

MCQ 22. The strongest argument for the pre-existent effect

Which argument turns on the claim that sheer non-existence is featureless and therefore cannot discriminate between outcomes?

A. Because what does not exist cannot be brought into being (asadakaraṇāt) B. Because everything cannot arise from everything (sarvasambhavābhāvāt) C. Because the effect has the being of its material cause (kāraṇa-bhāvāt) D. Because a determinate material cause is actually taken up (upādāna-grahaṇāt)

Answer: B. Because everything cannot arise from everything (sarvasambhavābhāvāt)

- **A:** This argument denies that a non-entity can be produced at all; it does not turn on the indiscriminability of non-existence across cases.
- **B:** Correct - if effects were wholly non-existent beforehand, non-existence being uniform could not explain why curd arises from milk and not from water.
- **C:** This argument establishes substantial non-difference between cause and effect, exemplified by threads and cloth or gold and ornament.
- **D:** This argument observes that agents select determinate materials, which is evidence of restriction rather than an analysis of non-existence.

Examiner trap 22: The five arguments are treated as five paraphrases of one point, so the answer cannot identify which of them carries the weight in a given question.

MCQ 23. Real transformation against apparent transformation

What is the decisive difference between Sāṃkhya and Advaita on causation?

A. Sāṃkhya denies that being can arise from non-being, while Advaita accepts production from nothing B. Sāṃkhya treats the material cause as conscious, while Advaita treats it as unconscious C. Sāṃkhya holds transformation to be real, while Advaita holds it to be apparent only D. Sāṃkhya denies any relation between cause and effect, while Advaita affirms strict identity

Answer: C. Sāṃkhya holds transformation to be real, while Advaita holds it to be apparent only

- **A:** Both schools deny production from sheer non-being, which is exactly why both can be placed under a broad pre-existence orientation.
- **B:** The positions are reversed: Sāṃkhya's material cause is unconscious nature and Advaita's ultimate is conscious Brahman.
- **C:** Correct - real transformation yields dualistic realism and apparent transformation yields non-dual idealism, and this is where the 2018 question turns.
- **D:** Sāṃkhya affirms substantial continuity between cause and effect; denying the relation altogether belongs to neither school.

Examiner trap 23: The pre-existence doctrine is claimed as uniquely Sāṃkhya, which loses the shared premise that makes the real-versus-apparent contrast philosophically interesting.

MCQ 24. What isolation is and is not

Which statement about liberation in Sāṃkhya is accurate?

A. It is the merger of the conscious witness into primordial nature at the end of the cosmic cycle B. It is identity with Brahman attained when the limiting adjuncts of the empirical self dissolve C. It is the destruction of primordial nature, which ceases to exist once knowledge has arisen D. It is isolation, the disentanglement of the witness once discriminative knowledge is steady

Answer: D. It is isolation, the disentanglement of the witness once discriminative knowledge is steady

- **A:** Merger into nature would place consciousness inside the very field the entire system separates it from.
- **B:** Identity with Brahman is the Advaita goal; importing it erases the distinctive Sāṃkhya result of aloneness.
- **C:** Nature is not destroyed; it merely ceases its binding performance for the witness that has seen through it.
- **D:** Correct - isolation is disentanglement rather than merger, and in the strict formulation the witness was never really bound at all.

Examiner trap 24: Isolation, release in Advaita and release in Nyāya are used interchangeably, although the three name three different goals with three different mechanisms.

REMEDIAL DRILLS

These eight items target the errors this topic reliably produces. Each is written against a specific mistake rather than against a specific session.

MCQ 25. Correcting a half-remembered position on the first evolute

A candidate writes: "Nature first evolves the great one; the great one then evolves the determinative intellect; the intellect then evolves the I-maker." What is the correct diagnosis?

A. The sequence is correct, but the I-maker should have been placed before the determinative intellect B. The sequence is correct in order, but the mind should have been inserted between the two evolutes C. The great one and the determinative intellect are one principle, so the sequence has one stage too many D. The sequence is correct, since the cosmic and individual principles are genuinely distinct evolutes

Answer: C. The great one and the determinative intellect are one principle, so the sequence has one stage too many

- **A:** Placing the I-maker before the determinative function reverses the derivation, since individuation presupposes determination.
- **B:** The mind arises much later, from the luminous aspect of the I-maker, and cannot be inserted before the I-maker exists.
- **C:** Correct - the great one is the cosmic name and the determinative intellect the individual name of a single first evolute.
- **D:** Treating them as distinct evolutes inflates the enumeration and contradicts the standard fourfold classification of principles.

Examiner trap 25: The two names are read as two ontological stages, so an answer to a question that explicitly asks for their difference asserts the very confusion being tested.

MCQ 26. Correcting an over-claim about the pre-existent effect

A candidate writes: "The doctrine that the effect pre-exists in its cause is unique to Sāṃkhya." What is wrong with this?

A. Advaita Vedānta also denies production from non-being, so the doctrine is shared rather than unique B. Nothing is wrong, since every other Indian school holds that the effect is newly produced C. The doctrine is in fact unique to Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, which Sāṃkhya later borrowed it from D. The doctrine belongs to Buddhism, where dependent origination presupposes latent effects

Answer: A. Advaita Vedānta also denies production from non-being, so the doctrine is shared rather than unique

- **A:** Correct - what is distinctive is Sāṃkhya's *form* of the doctrine, namely real transformation as against apparent transformation.
- **B:** Nyāya does hold that the effect is newly produced, but Advaita does not, so the generalisation fails immediately.
- **C:** Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika holds the opposite doctrine, prior non-existence followed by a new beginning of the effect.
- **D:** Dependent origination dispenses with an enduring material root altogether and therefore cannot house a latent effect.

Examiner trap 26: Distinctiveness is claimed at the level of the general doctrine instead of at the level of the mechanism, which weakens exactly the comparison the examiner wants.

MCQ 27. Correcting a confusion of soteriological goals

Which pairing of school and technical goal is correct?

- A. Sāṃkhya-identity with Brahman; Advaita-isolation; Nyāya-cessation of suffering B. Sāṃkhya-isolation; Advaita-identity with Brahman; Nyāya-cessation of suffering C. Sāṃkhya-cessation of suffering; Advaita-isolation; Nyāya-identity with Brahman D. Sāṃkhya-isolation; Advaita-cessation of suffering; Nyāya-identity with Brahman

Answer: B. Sāṃkhya-isolation; Advaita-identity with Brahman; Nyāya-cessation of suffering

- **A:** Exchanges the Sāṃkhya and Advaita goals, which are the two most frequently conflated terms in this part of the syllabus.
- **B:** Correct - the three names mark three different results: aloneness of the witness, non-dual identity, and the ending of pain.
- **C:** Assigns the Advaita goal to Nyāya, whose realist pluralism excludes identity with a single ultimate consciousness.
- **D:** Right about Sāṃkhya but wrong about the other two, since cessation of suffering is the Nyāya formulation and identity the Advaita one.

Examiner trap 27: The three goals are treated as stylistic variants of "liberation", so cross-school comparison questions receive an answer with no discriminating content.

MCQ 28. Correcting the mango-seed misstatement

A candidate writes: "Sāṃkhya holds that a fully formed miniature mango tree is spatially hidden inside the seed." What is the correct formulation?

- A. The tree exists in the seed as an actual but invisible object of a subtler perceptual kind B. The tree does not exist in the seed at all; the seed merely has an external causal relation to it C. The seed contains no determinate capacity, and any material would serve given suitable conditions D. The seed holds the effect as a latent determinate capacity, and production is real transformation

Answer: D. The seed holds the effect as a latent determinate capacity, and production is real transformation

- **A:** An invisible actual tree is the caricature the school explicitly rejects; only the capacity, not the gross effect, is present.
- **B:** A merely external relation is the rival position of prior non-existence, which Sāṃkhya's argument from determinacy is directed against.
- **C:** Denying determinate capacity concedes that anything could arise from anything, which is the very consequence the third argument rules out.
- **D:** Correct - the formula to write is latent effect plus material continuity plus real transformation.

Examiner trap 28: The doctrine is defended in its caricatured form, which lets an opponent refute it in a single sentence and costs the whole rival-rejection half of the 2020 question.

MCQ 29. Correcting the boundary with Yoga

Which statement correctly marks the boundary between classical Sāṃkhya and Yoga?

A. Yoga rejects the plurality of witnesses that Sāṃkhya defends and posits a single universal self B. Sāṃkhya is non-theistic and theoretical, while Yoga adds God as a special witness and a discipline C. Sāṃkhya owns the eight-limbed discipline, while Yoga borrows the theory of the three qualities D. Both are non-theistic, and the only difference lies in their respective counts of the principles

Answer: B. Sāṃkhya is non-theistic and theoretical, while Yoga adds God as a special witness and a discipline

- **A:** Yoga retains the plurality of witnesses; what it adds is a special witness, not a single universal self.
- **B:** Correct - Yoga is a friendly amendment that keeps nature, the qualities and many witnesses while adding God, discipline and the yogi's perception.
- **C:** The eight-limbed discipline is owned by Yoga, not by Sāṃkhya, and the qualities are shared metaphysics rather than a borrowing.
- **D:** Yoga is theistic, so the schools differ on precisely the question this option declares them to agree about.

Examiner trap 29: Yoga's mind-field, afflictions and eight limbs are imported into a Sāṃkhya answer, which both wastes words and violates the syllabus division of ownership.

MCQ 30. Correcting the elemental correspondence

Which correspondence between subtle element and gross element is correct?

A. Sound-potential to ether, touch-potential to air, form-potential to fire, taste to water, smell to earth B. Sound-potential to earth, touch-potential to water, form-potential to air, taste to fire, smell to ether C. Sound-potential to air, touch-potential to ether, form-potential to water, taste to earth, smell to fire D. Sound-potential to fire, touch-potential to earth, form-potential to ether, taste to air, smell to water

Answer: A. Sound-potential to ether, touch-potential to air, form-potential to fire, taste to water, smell to earth

- **A:** Correct - this is the standard series, running from the subtlest potential and element to the grossest in strict parallel.
- **B:** Exactly inverts the series, pairing the subtlest potential with the grossest element and vice versa throughout.
- **C:** Shifts every pairing by one position, which breaks the parallel between increasing grossness of potential and of element.
- **D:** Scrambles the series without any ordering principle, and in particular separates sound from ether, the pairing that anchors the list.

Examiner trap 30: The list is memorised as five items without its ordering principle, so any disturbance of the sequence goes undetected in the exam hall.

MCQ 31. Correcting the meaning of the chief-opponent title

Why does Śaṅkara treat Sāṃkhya as his chief opponent?

A. Because Sāṃkhya is a materialist school that denies scripture, the self and moral consequence B. Because Sāṃkhya alone among Indian schools denies that the effect pre-exists in its cause C. Because it is the strongest rival system, closest in ambition and nearest in its causal doctrine D. Because Sāṃkhya's practical discipline attracted more followers than Advaita in Śaṅkara's period

Answer: C. Because it is the strongest rival system, closest in ambition and nearest in its causal doctrine

- **A:** Sāṃkhya is an orthodox school that affirms the self and moral consequence; materialism describes Cārvāka instead.
- **B:** Sāṃkhya affirms the pre-existent effect; the denial belongs to Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika under the doctrine of prior non-existence.
- **C:** Correct - systematic completeness, the proximity of real to apparent transformation, and the shared appeal to a single ultimate ground make the contest direct.
- **D:** The designation records philosophical rivalry rather than popularity, and the practical discipline in question belongs to Yoga.

Examiner trap 31: The chief-wrestler title is read as an insult, so the answer supplies only Śaṅkara's objections and omits the first half of the question, which asks *why chief*.

MCQ 32. Correcting the account of transmigration

In classical Sāṃkhya, what transmigrates between gross embodiments?

A. The conscious witness, which carries its accumulated merit and demerit into each new body B. Nothing at all, since rebirth is a conventional description with no continuing vehicle behind it C. The five gross elements, which recombine to form the next body under karmic determination D. The subtle body, which carries dispositions and karmic tendencies into another embodiment

Answer: D. The subtle body, which carries dispositions and karmic tendencies into another embodiment

- **A:** The witness neither acts nor literally migrates; attributing a moral career to it would make bondage a real modification.
- **B:** Denying a continuing vehicle is closer to a Buddhist analysis and would leave Sāṃkhya unable to explain karmic continuity at all.
- **C:** The gross body produced from parental material falls away at death and is not the transmigrating vehicle.
- **D:** Correct - the subtle body, eighteen constituents conditioned by the intellect's eight tendencies, is what continues between embodiments.

Examiner trap 32: The witness is described as the transmigrating soul, which contradicts the inactivity thesis on which every proof of the witness and the whole account of isolation depends.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Wording discipline. Every previous-year question below reproduces the printed wording exactly, including the paper's own transliteration. Model answers are independent learner practice written to the stated word band and directive; they are never official keys.

VERIFIED PREVIOUS-YEAR QUESTIONS - 13 COMPLETE SOLUTIONS

Ten questions are primary-owned by this syllabus item across 2018-2025; three further questions are routed here because Sāṃkhya's causal doctrine is the actual subject under examination even though another owner holds the question.

2018 · Q5(e) · 10 marks

Printed question. Is Puruṣa one or many? Explain the Sāṃkhya position in this regard and give arguments in support of your answer.

Demand decoded. "Is ... one or many" requires a verdict in the first line. "Explain ... and give arguments in support" requires the canonical arguments with their source status, plus a defence against the obvious rival.

Model answer (183 words).

Sāṃkhya holds that conscious witnesses (**puruṣa**) are many, and that their plurality is numerical rather than qualitative: each is equally pure, inactive, changeless consciousness.

Three arguments map directly onto *Sāṃkhyakārikā* 18. First, the fixed distribution of birth, death and sense-faculties: were there one witness, one birth would be every birth and all would be blind when one is blind. Second, the non-simultaneity of activity: beings act at different times and in different ways, whereas a single self would make all embodied streams act together. Third, differential constitution by the three qualities, since beings differ as luminous, active or inert in temperament. A fourth consideration - that some are released while others remain bound - is a standard supplementary inference rather than a phrase of that verse.

Śaṃkara objects that every difference cited belongs to limiting adjuncts (**upādhi**), so at most many mental streams are proved. Sāṃkhya replies that bondage and release are non-transferable, and that reflection requires distinct loci in distinct intellects.

The argument is therefore strong morally and weak metaphysically: Sāṃkhya establishes that experience is non-transferable, but cannot state what individuates attributeless witnesses.

2018 · Q7(b) · 15 marks

Printed question. How do the Advaita Vedāntins react to the Prakṛtipariṇāmavāda of the Sāṃkhya philosophy? How do the Sāṃkhyas defend their own position in this regard? Discuss.

Demand decoded. Two directed halves - the Advaita reaction, then the Sāṃkhya defence - held together by "Discuss", which asks for ordered exposition ending in a judgement.

Model answer (281 words).

Sāṃkhya's doctrine of the real transformation of primordial nature holds that the effect pre-exists in its material cause and is genuinely manifested through the modification of the three qualities: in equilibrium each quality transforms homogeneously, and on disturbance the qualities transform heterogeneously to yield the manifest principles.

Advaita reacts on three fronts. First, an unconscious first principle cannot be the cause described in the Upaniṣads, where the source is spoken of as conscious and knowing. Second, an ultimate that really transforms becomes mutable, and a mutable principle is dependent rather than ultimate; the world's dependence is therefore better explained by superimposition. Third, Advaita substitutes apparent transformation (**vivarta**) for real transformation, so that Brahman is the cause without undergoing change, as a rope is the "cause" of the snake seen in it.

Sāṃkhya defends itself equally on three fronts. First, the selectivity of production is real: curd comes from milk and not from water, and only a real material continuity explains that restriction, whereas an appearance-theory leaves selectivity unexplained. Second, mutability does not disqualify nature from being ultimate, because nature is by definition the principle whose being is modification; the objection would tell only against a changeless ultimate. Third, treating the world as appearance purchases the immutability of the cause at the cost of the reality of bondage and release, which Sāṃkhya's realism refuses to surrender.

Both schools deny production from sheer non-being, so the dispute is not about the pre-existent effect but about the reality of the transformation.

The exchange therefore terminates in a clash of first principles: Sāṃkhya preserves the reality of the world and pays with a mutable ultimate, while Advaita preserves an immutable ultimate and pays with the ultimate unreality of the world.

2019 · Q5(d) · 10 marks

Printed question. Critically discuss the metaphysical status of a Jīva and a Puruṣa according to Sāṃkhya philosophy.

Demand decoded. "Critically discuss" requires the distinction, its mechanism, and a stated difficulty - not two definitions placed side by side.

Model answer (186 words).

For Sāṃkhya the conscious witness (**puruṣa**) is the metaphysical reality: pure, self-luminous, inactive and changeless consciousness, wholly beyond the three qualities. The empirical self (**jīva**) is **not a further principle** in the enumeration of twenty-five; it is the witness as empirically conditioned through identification with intellect, I-maker, mind, body and the karmic stream.

The mechanism is reflection. The determinative intellect, being predominantly luminous and therefore transparent, receives the reflection of the witness; the resulting cognition generates false appropriation (**abhimāna**) - "I am the doer, knower, enjoyer". The insentient organ thus appears conscious while the inactive witness appears to be an agent. The empirical self is precisely that two-way appearance stabilised into an apparent person.

Two consequences follow. Bondage is misidentification rather than a real modification of the witness, and liberation is the correction of attribution rather than the destruction of an entity.

Critically, the account is elegant but exposed: if the witness is never really conditioned, it becomes unclear in what sense there was ever a problem for it, and Sāṃkhya's reply - that the problem was always one of attribution - clarifies the question rather than demonstrating an answer.

2019 · Q8(c) · 15 marks

Printed question. Which Sāṃkhya proof for the existence of Prakṛti actually shows that there can be only one Prakṛti? Justify your answer.

Demand decoded. A single named proof, then a justification. Marks are lost by listing all five without discriminating, and by naming the proof without the bridging argument.

Model answer (272 words).

The proof is **avibhāgāt vaiśvarūpyasya** - the argument from the undivided source of the diversified universe.

Sāṃkhya offers five inferences for primordial material nature. From the finitude and determinateness of things (**bhedānām parimāṇāt**) it argues that the limited presupposes a subtler ground. From the uniformity running through effects (**samanvayāt**) it argues from coordinated diversity to a common material basis. From operation due to causal power (**śaktiḥ pravṛtteś ca**, the standard reading of *Sāṃkhyakārikā* 15) it argues that determinate production requires a potent source. From the distinction between cause and effect (**kāraṇa-kārya-vibhāgāt**) it argues that manifest effects imply a subtler unmanifest cause.

Each of these four is compatible with a plurality of material roots. Several reservoirs could each be subtler than their products, each display internal pattern, each possess productive power, and each differ in stage from its effects. None of the four takes unity as its premise, so none can deliver unity as its conclusion.

The fifth argument alone does. It begins from the observation that cosmic diversity is not a heap but one interconnected whole, and reasons that a diversified yet undivided cosmos points back to an original source in which later differentiations are not yet separated. Admitting many disconnected primal materials would therefore destroy the very undividedness from which the inference proceeds.

Justification, stated as a bridge: the premise of proof five is the world's undivided interconnectedness, so plurality at the root would falsify the premise and not merely complicate the conclusion.

The verdict holds within Sāṃkhya's own inferential licence; a Nyāya atomist declines it by tracing interconnectedness to coordination among many causes rather than to a single origin.

2020 · Q7(a) · 20 marks

Printed question. "A mango tree is grown out of a mango seed." How will Sāṃkhya system explain this process through their theory of causation by rejecting their rival perspectives?

Demand decoded. Two obligations. Explain the example through the doctrine of the pre-existent effect *and* reject the rivals by name. An answer without the rival-rejection half cannot score.

Model answer (357 words).

Sāṃkhya explains the example by the doctrine that the effect pre-exists in its material cause (**satkāryavāda**), in its specific form as real transformation (**pariṇāmavāda**). The mango tree pre-exists in the mango seed not as a miniature gross tree spatially concealed within it, but as a latent determinate capacity in a material continuum; production is manifestation (**abhivyakti**) of what is latent, and the effect differs from the cause by state (**avasthā**), not by substance.

Five arguments support this. Because a non-entity cannot be produced (**asadakaraṇāt**), no operation yields oil from sand. Because a determinate material cause is taken up (**upādāna-grahaṇāt**), the cultivator selects a mango seed and not sand. Because everything cannot arise from everything (**sarvasambhavābhāvāt**), and non-existence is featureless and therefore indiscriminable, sheer prior absence cannot explain why this seed yields this tree. Because the potent produces only the producible (**śaktasya śakya-karaṇāt**), a potency directed at a determinate effect presupposes that effect as its object. Because the effect has the being of the cause (**kāraṇa-bhāvāt**), the tree continues the seed's material substance as cloth continues threads.

The rivals must now be rejected. Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika holds that the effect is absent beforehand as prior non-existence (**prāgabhāva**) and that production is a new beginning; it objects that Sāṃkhya equivocates between the absolutely non-existent and the merely not-yet-existent, and that the whole (**avayavin**) is a new substance with new properties. Sāṃkhya replies that a not-yet-existent effect must still be something determinate in the cause, else the operation has no terminus, and that new properties are new arrangements (**saṃsthāna**), not new substances from non-being. Advaita agrees that being does not arise from non-being but makes the transformation apparent (**vivartavāda**); Sāṃkhya replies that an appearance-theory cannot explain why production is selective. Buddhism explains becoming by dependent origination without an enduring material root; Sāṃkhya replies that momentary series cannot ground the observed material continuity of seed and tree.

The objection that production becomes pointless is answered by manifestation: effort removes obstruction and supplies conditions rather than creating being.

The doctrine is therefore strongest as an argument about determinacy, and remains contestable only where an opponent grounds determinacy in relational potency instead of latent effect.

2021 · Q6(b) · 15 marks

Printed question. Explain the Sāṃkhya view on three guṇas (guṇa-traya) and their modifications.

Demand decoded. Two halves of equal weight. The triad is the first half; the two kinds of modification are the second, and omitting them forfeits roughly half the marks.

Model answer (250 words).

The three qualities (**guṇa**) are luminosity (**sattva**), activity (**rajas**) and inertia (**tamas**). They are not three separable substances but three inseparable constitutive tendencies of one primordial nature, present together in every evolute in varying proportion.

Luminosity is light, clear and buoyant; its affective tone is pleasure and its function is revelation, clarity and manifestation. Activity is dynamic, restless and projective; its tone is pain and its function is energy, stimulation and movement. Inertia is heavy, obstructive and resistant; its tone is delusion and its function is concealment, resistance and material density. Because character, affective tone and evolutionary function are mapped together, a single triad explains physical constitution, mental state and moral temperament at once - Sāṃkhya's most economical

achievement.

Their modification (**guṇa-pariṇāma**) takes two forms. In equilibrium (**sāmyāvasthā**) the three stand in exact balance and nature is unmanifest (**avyakta**); here each quality transforms within its own nature, which is homogeneous modification (**sarūpa-pariṇāma**). This preserves the claim that nature is never inert, so that dissolution is not annihilation. When equilibrium is disturbed in the presence of the conscious witness, the qualities enter asymmetrical relations and generate differentiated evolutes: this is heterogeneous modification (**virūpa-pariṇāma**), to which actual cosmological evolution belongs.

The disturbance is not a mechanical collision. The witness is inactive, so Sāṃkhya describes only functional activation in proximity.

The doctrine is therefore powerful as an account of qualitative variety and weakest exactly at its trigger: what converts homogeneous into heterogeneous modification is presence rather than causation, and Śaṅkara presses precisely this point.

2022 · Q5(a) · 10 marks

Printed question. Examine and evaluate the proofs given by Sāṃkhya philosophy to prove the existence of Puruṣa.

Demand decoded. Two directives. "Examine" wants the internal logic of the proofs; "evaluate" wants a reasoned judgement on their force. Listing alone answers neither.

Model answer (194 words).

Sāṃkhya offers five arguments, all sharing one premise: the entire objective complex is unconscious, instrumental and presented to experience.

Aggregates exist for another (**saṅghāta-parārthatvāt**): body, senses, mind and intellect are complexes, and a complex functions instrumentally for a user distinct from it. The witness must be other than the qualities (**triguṇādi-viparyayāt**): the knower of pleasure, pain and delusion cannot be the same changing states that are known. Organised experience requires a presiding locus (**adhiṣṭhānāt**) - an inference to a conscious witness of lived order, and expressly not a proof of God. Experience requires an enjoyer (**bhoktr-bhāvāt**), since presented states demand a subject for whom they appear. Striving for release presupposes a liberable witness (**kaivalyārtham pravṛtteḥ**).

Evaluating them, their force is cumulative rather than individual. Each alone invites a deflationary reply - a Buddhist explains coordination by causal series and ownership by convention - but together they converge on the structural point that a domain of presentation without a subject-pole is not a domain of presentation at all. Their form throughout is general-correlation inference.

Their honest limit is that they establish a subject-pole, not yet an eternal, plural and wholly inactive one.

2023 · Q5(b) · 10 marks

Printed question. "If Puruṣa and Prakṛti are two completely independent realities, then no relation between the two is possible." In the light of this statement make a brief presentation of Śaṅkara's criticism of Sāṃkhya dualism.

Demand decoded. "Brief presentation ... in the light of this statement" means the quoted relation problem must organise the answer, and the criticism must be Śaṅkara's, not a general objection.

Model answer (190 words).

The quoted statement isolates Sāṃkhya's contact problem: if the conscious witness is wholly inactive and primordial nature wholly unconscious, no intelligible real relation appears possible, yet evolution, bondage and liberation all presuppose one.

Sāṃkhya answers that the relation is mere proximity (**sānnidhya**), not gross contact: nature becomes active in the witness's mere presence. Two analogies support this - a magnet moves iron without deliberative willing, and a clear crystal appears coloured by a nearby flower without itself changing. The first explains activation by presence; the second explains apparent contamination without real change.

Śaṅkara attacks both. Even a magnet exerts force, so if the witness were genuinely like a magnet it would not be wholly inactive. The crystal may explain appearance, but it cannot explain the initiation of the world-process, since a crystal initiates nothing. He adds that an unconscious chief principle cannot be the Upaniṣadic cause, which is described as conscious and knowing, and that purposive evolution "for the sake of" the witness presupposes intelligence.

His conclusion is that the dualism is unstable: it must either collapse toward monism or admit a third mediating principle - a demand for further explanation rather than a refutation by assertion.

2024 · Q7(a) · 20 marks (10+10)

Printed question. Present an account of evolution of Prakṛti as propounded in Sāṃkhya-kārikā. In this context, also explain the difference between buddhi, mahat and ahaṃkāra.

Demand decoded. An explicitly split question. The first ten marks are the complete evolutionary sequence; the second ten are the three-term distinction, whose correct answer is that two of the three terms name one principle.

Model answer (382 words).

Part one: the evolution of primordial nature. Primordial nature (**prakṛti**) is the unmanifest chief principle (**avyakta pradhāna**), one, unconscious and uncreated, constituted by the three qualities in equilibrium. In the mere presence of the conscious witness the equilibrium is disturbed, and heterogeneous modification of the qualities (**virūpa-pariṇāma**) begins.

The first evolute is the great one, also called the determinative intellect (**mahat / buddhi**). From it arises the I-maker (**ahaṃkāra**), the principle of individuation. The I-maker then evolves along two lines. From its luminous aspect arise the coordinating mind (**manas**), the five cognitive capacities - hearing, touch, sight, taste and smell - and the five action capacities: speech, grasping, locomotion, excretion and reproduction. From its inert aspect arise the five subtle elements (**tanmātra**), the potentials of sound, touch, form, taste and smell; and from these arise the five gross elements (**mahābhūta**) - ether, air, fire, water and earth - on the standard correspondence of sound to ether, touch to air, form to fire, taste to water and smell to earth. The active quality supplies energy to both lines and produces no separate set of principles.

Twenty-four evolutes plus the conscious witness give twenty-five principles. The fourfold classification controls the list: nature alone is cause but not effect; the intellect, the I-maker and the five subtle elements are both cause and effect; the mind, the ten capacities and the five gross elements are effects only; and the witness is neither.

Part two: buddhi, mahat and ahaṃkāra. The decisive point is that the great one and the determinative intellect are **the same principle** under two names: the great one is its cosmic aspect, the determinative intellect its individual or psychological aspect. Writing them as two successive stages is an error that also corrupts the total count.

The I-maker is genuinely distinct and is derived *from* that first evolute. Functionally, the determinative intellect makes the final ascertainment (**adhyavasāya**) - judgement and discrimination - and, being predominantly luminous and transparent, receives the reflection of the witness. The I-maker appropriates functions as "I" and "mine", and false selfhood crystallises there, which is why it is central to bondage. The coordinating mind, arising later, only synthesises sense-data.

The sequence therefore unifies cosmology and psychology: the equipment of knowing is itself a product of the known.

2025 · Q7(a) · 20 marks

Printed question. Why does Śaṅkara consider Sāṃkhya Philosophy as his chief opponent (pradhāna malla)? Examine his arguments against Sāṃkhya Philosophy.

Demand decoded. Two halves again. "Why ... chief opponent" asks for the grounds of the designation; "examine his arguments" asks for the objections tested for force. Answers that supply only the objections lose the first half entirely.

Model answer (374 words).

Why chief. The title of chief wrestler (**pradhāna malla**) records systematic strength, not contempt. Three grounds support it.

First, Sāṃkhya is the most sophisticated non-Vedāntic rival at the level of ultimate explanation: it accounts for world, self, bondage, liberation and causation within one coherent metaphysical system, and is therefore near enough to require detailed refutation rather than dismissal. Second, its doctrine of real transformation (**pariṇā mavāda**) is the nearest rival to Advaita's apparent transformation (**vivartavāda**); both deny production from non-being and both derive the world from an ultimate, differing only on whether the derivation is real. Third, both appeal to a single ultimate explanatory ground - Sāṃkhya to one unconscious primal material principle, Advaita to conscious Brahman - so the contest is direct rather than oblique.

The arguments, examined. Śaṅkara's first objection is that an unconscious chief principle cannot be the Upaniṣadic cause, since the scriptural source is described as conscious and knowing; "knowing-cause" descriptions exclude an insentient nature. This is powerful within a scripturally governed enquiry, though a non-Vedic opponent may refuse the premise.

His second objection is the contact problem: an inactive witness and an unconscious nature cannot intelligibly relate, yet the whole system depends on their relation. Sāṃkhya answers with mere proximity, supported by the magnet moving iron and the crystal coloured by a nearby flower. Śaṅkara replies that a magnet exerts force - so the analogy either fails or destroys the witness's inactivity - and that the crystal explains appearance but not the initiation of the world-process. This objection is the strongest, because the two analogies do different jobs and neither does both.

His third objection is teleological: if nature evolves "for the sake of" the witness, purposiveness appears to require intelligence. Sāṃkhya replies that purposive functioning need not be conscious planning, as milk flows for the calf; the reply preserves internal sufficiency but does not remove the pressure.

Verdict. Śaṅkara treats Sāṃkhya as chief opponent because it attempts, from an unconscious first principle, exactly what Advaita attempts from a conscious one. He rejects it because the ultimate cause must be conscious, teleology cannot rest on unconscious nature, and the witness-nature relation remains unstable - a demonstration that the dualism needs further explanation rather than a proof that Advaita is thereby established.

2021 · Q5(a) · 10 marks · routed

Printed question. Does the seed contain the tree? Discuss with reference to Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika Philosophy.

Routing note. Primary ownership lies with Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, but the question is unanswerable without the Sāṃkhya position it is framed against, and the Sāṃkhya side must be stated accurately.

Model answer (188 words).

For Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika the answer is no. Before production the effect is characterised by prior non-existence (**prāgabhāva**) in its material cause; production is a genuinely new beginning (**ārambhavāda**), and the resulting whole (**avayavin**) is a new substance inhering in its parts and possessing properties the parts lack - a cloth covers, whereas separate threads do not.

The question is framed against Sāṃkhya, which answers yes on its own terms: the effect pre-exists as a latent determinate capacity, since non-existence is featureless and cannot explain why this seed yields this tree, and since a potency directed at a determinate effect presupposes that effect. Sāṃkhya does not claim that a miniature gross tree is spatially hidden in the seed.

Nyāya's reply is that Sāṃkhya equivocates: it denies only that the tree exists as the tree beforehand, not that the seed is determinate. Determinacy is secured instead by the causal capacity of the material and by the exclusion of non-causal antecedents.

The dispute therefore turns on whether determinacy can be carried by a relational potency alone, or must be grounded in a latent effect - a difference of first principles rather than of evidence.

2022 · Q5(e) · 10 marks · routed

Printed question. Do you agree with the view that 'Vivartavāda is the logical development of Pariṇā mavāda'? Give reasons in support of your answer.

Routing note. Owned by Vedānta, but the question is a direct examination of whether Sāṃkhya's real transformation entails Advaita's apparent transformation.

Model answer (181 words).

I agree only partly, and the qualification carries the argument.

The claim is defensible in one respect. Both doctrines deny production from sheer non-being, so both belong to a broad pre-existence orientation; and apparent transformation can be presented as the result of pressing real transformation's own logic - if the ultimate must not be diminished by producing, transformation is best read as appearance rather than as real change.

It is indefensible in another. Real transformation is not an incomplete version of apparent transformation but a rival with opposite commitments. Sāṃkhya's cause is unconscious primordial nature and its world is a real evolute; Advaita's cause is conscious Brahman and its world is ultimately appearance. Sāṃkhya's mechanism is the modification of the three qualities; Advaita's is superimposition. Treating one as the logical development of the other therefore assumes the very Vedāntic premise - that an ultimate cannot really change - which Sāṃkhya explicitly denies by defining nature as that whose being is modification.

The view is thus historically suggestive as a description of Vedāntic self-understanding, but logically question-begging as a claim about entailment.

2023 · Q8(b) · 15 marks · routed

Printed question. Write a note on Nyāya notion of Prāgabhāva (prior non-existence). How does this notion help Naiyāyikas in defending their position on causation against the Sāṃkhya view of causation? Critically discuss.

Routing note. Owned by Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika; the second and third clauses make Sāṃkhya's causal doctrine the subject under test, so the Sāṃkhya side must be argued and not merely named.

Model answer (296 words).

Prior non-existence (**prāgabhāva**) is one of the four absences recognised in the Vaiśeṣika category-scheme. It is the absence of an effect in its material cause before production: beginningless but with an end, since it terminates precisely when the effect is produced. Every absence has a counter-positive, and here the counter-positive is the effect itself.

The notion does exact defensive work for Nyāya's doctrine that the effect does not pre-exist (**asatkāryavāda**). It gives a positive account of the pre-production situation, so production becomes the destruction of prior non-existence rather than creation from nothing; it preserves the reality of production, since something genuinely new begins; and it blocks the charge of arbitrariness, because determinacy is located in the causal capacity of the material and in the exclusion of non-causal antecedents rather than in a latent effect.

Against Sāṃkhya it grounds a dilemma. If the effect exists beforehand, the causal operation is idle; if it does not exist as the effect, Nyāya's position has been conceded, and prior non-existence names exactly what the effect then lacks. Nyāya adds that the whole is a new substance with properties its parts lack.

Sāṃkhya replies that a merely negative antecedent cannot discriminate outcomes, since non-existence is featureless; that production is manifestation (**abhivyakti**) and effort removes obstruction; and that cause and effect differ by state (**avasthā**) rather than by substance, so the operation is not idle.

Critically, prior non-existence answers the charge of creation from nothing but relocates rather than removes the demand for determinacy, which Nyāya must then discharge through causal capacity - the very notion Sāṃkhya claims is unintelligible without a latent effect.

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE

Six original questions written in previous-year style: two at ten marks, two at fifteen and two at twenty. They are learner practice, not previous-year questions.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question. Explain why Sāṃkhya restricts the means of valid knowledge to three, and show how this restriction shapes its metaphysics.

Model answer (177 words).

Sāṃkhya admits exactly three instruments of knowledge - perception, inference and reliable testimony - and reduces comparison, postulation, non-apprehension, inclusion and traditional report to these three rather than rejecting them as worthless. Comparison operates through a prior verbal report applied inferentially; postulation is inference to the best explanatory condition; non-apprehension belongs to the failure-conditions of perception.

This restriction is not economy for its own sake; it creates an obligation. Both ultimates - primordial nature and the conscious witness - are beyond the senses (**atīndriya**), so perception cannot reach them, and testimony alone would beg the question against a non-Vedic opponent. Imperceptibility itself is disarmed by the standard list of causes of non-perception, in which root nature falls under subtlety (**saukṣmya**).

The whole evidential weight therefore falls on general-correlation inference (**sāmānyato-dṛṣṭa**), which alone can reach a term whose invariable relation was never observed directly. The five proofs of nature and the five proofs of the witness are precisely the shape this epistemology forces.

The metaphysics is thus epistemically driven - and correspondingly vulnerable if that inferential licence is denied, as Cārvāka denies it.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question. "Nothing happens to Puruṣa at liberation." Comment on this statement with reference to the Sāṃkhya account of bondage and kaivalya.

Model answer (180 words).

The statement is accurate in strict Sāṃkhya and is the best available formulation of its soteriology.

Bondage is non-discrimination (**aviveka**) between the witness and nature. The determinative intellect, being transparent, receives the reflection of consciousness, and false appropriation (**abhimāna**) follows - "I am the doer, knower, enjoyer". Since this is misattribution and not modification, the witness is not really altered by bondage.

Liberation is correspondingly cognitive. Discriminative knowledge (**viveka-jñāna**) stabilises the distinction between witness-consciousness and quality-evolutes, false identification ends, and the resulting state is isolation (**kaivalya**) - disentanglement, not merger and not annihilation. The canonical image is the dancer who retires once she has been seen; the potter's wheel explains why the body continues by prior momentum, giving liberation while living (**jīvanmukti**) before final release (**videhamukti**).

The strict formulation follows: the witness is never really bound, liberated or transmigrating, since these belong to nature and the subtle body.

The comment must end with the cost. If nothing happens to the witness, the school must explain in what sense the problem was ever *its* problem - a clarification it offers but does not demonstrate.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question. Examine the claim that Sāṃkhya's theory of the three qualities makes cosmology and psychology a single subject.

Model answer (270 words).

The claim is substantially correct and identifies Sāṃkhya's most economical achievement, though it must be stated with care.

The three qualities are luminosity, activity and inertia: not three substances but three inseparable constitutive tendencies of one nature, present together in every evolute in varying proportion. Each is defined simultaneously along three registers - character, affective tone and evolutionary function. Luminosity is buoyant, carries pleasure and performs manifestation; activity is restless, carries pain and performs movement; inertia is heavy, carries delusion and performs concealment.

Because a single triad is defined across physical, affective and functional registers at once, the same explanatory apparatus accounts for the density of a stone, the dullness of a mind and the confusion of a temperament. The evolutionary sequence completes the unification: intellect, I-maker, mind and the ten capacities are evolutes of the same nature that yields the subtle and gross elements, so the equipment of knowing is itself a product of the known.

Two qualifications are needed. First, the unification is achieved by placing all mental functioning inside unconscious nature, which is why Sāṃkhya is a consciousness-nature dualism and not a mind-body dualism; the psychology it unifies with cosmology is a psychology *without* consciousness. Second, the unification does not extend to the witness, which is beyond the qualities altogether, so exactly one thing remains outside the single subject.

Examined, then, the claim holds for everything the qualities constitute and fails precisely at the point where Sāṃkhya's dualism begins. That is not a defect in the theory of the qualities but the boundary the theory was designed to respect - and it is also where the system's relation problem starts.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question. Critically examine whether the Sāṃkhya doctrine of many Puruṣas is proved or merely postulated.

Model answer (277 words).

Sāṃkhya argues for the plurality of witnesses rather than assuming it, but the arguments establish less than the doctrine requires, so the honest verdict is "argued, not demonstrated".

The case rests on three arguments of *Sāṃkhyakārikā* 18. The fixed distribution of birth, death and sense-faculties: one witness would mean one birth is every birth. The non-simultaneity of activity: beings act at different times, whereas one self would make all streams act together. Differential constitution by the qualities: temperaments differ as luminous, active or inert. A fourth consideration, differential liberation, is a supplementary inference and not a phrase of that verse.

These arguments share a form: they infer transcendental plurality from empirical non-transferability. That form is exactly what Advaita contests. Śaṅkara replies that every cited difference belongs to limiting adjuncts (**upādhi**) - bodies, minds and quality-configurations - and that pure consciousness, being without attribute, part, action or location, admits no principle of individuation; Sāṃkhya therefore proves at most a plurality of mental streams (**citta**).

Sāṃkhya's counter is that bondage and release are non-transferable and that the reflection model requires distinct loci in distinct intellects. This is a genuine reply, since Advaita must then treat bondage itself as adventitious and the many empirical selves as apparent.

The residual difficulty is internal and should be conceded. If every witness is qualitatively identical, the school cannot say what makes them numerically many; plurality is inferred from non-transferable experience rather than grounded in a stated principle of individuation.

Critically examined, the doctrine is therefore well motivated and under-demonstrated: it is proved as far as moral and experiential individuality can prove anything, and postulated precisely where metaphysical individuation is demanded.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question. Analyse the relation between Sāṃkhya's epistemology, its theory of causation and its account of liberation, and assess whether the three form a coherent system.

Model answer (368 words).

The three parts. Sāṃkhya's epistemology admits three instruments - perception, inference and reliable testimony - and reduces all other candidates to them. Its causal doctrine holds that the effect pre-exists in its material cause (**satkāryavāda**) in the specific form of real transformation (**pariṇāmavāda**), effected by the modification of the three qualities. Its soteriology holds that bondage is non-discrimination and liberation is discriminative knowledge issuing in

isolation (**kaivalya**).

How epistemology drives causation. Because both ultimates are beyond the senses, the entire evidential burden falls on general-correlation inference. That is why the five proofs of primordial nature exist at all - and the third of them, from operation due to causal power (**śaktiṭaḥ pravṛtteś ca**), is already a causal thesis. Determinate production is the datum from which the material root is inferred, and determinate production is what the doctrine of the pre-existent effect explains. Epistemology and causation are therefore two descriptions of one inference.

How causation drives soteriology. Real transformation makes the world a genuine evolute rather than an appearance, so bondage and release are events in a real order. But real transformation also places intellect, I-maker and mind inside nature, which produces the reflection model: transparent intellect receives the witness's reflection and false appropriation follows. Liberation must then be the correction of an attribution rather than the destruction of an entity - which is exactly why isolation is disentanglement rather than merger, and why the dancer image, not the prison image, is canonical.

How soteriology returns to epistemology. The fifth proof of the witness - that striving for release presupposes a liberable witness - makes the soteriology part of the evidence. The system closes on itself.

Assessment. The coherence is genuine and unusually tight: each part supplies a premise the next requires, and the enumeration of twenty-five principles is simultaneously a cosmology, a psychology and the content of liberating knowledge.

The incoherence, where it appears, is concentrated at one joint. The disturbance of equilibrium is attributed to mere presence, which is neither perception, nor inference from causal power, nor a real transformation - the three things the system otherwise relies on.

Sāṃkhya is therefore coherent as a system of explanation and under-determined at its point of origination, which is precisely where Śaṅkara concentrates his attack.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question. "Sāṃkhya purchases the inactivity of consciousness at a high price." Discuss with reference to agency, moral responsibility and rebirth.

Model answer (372 words).

The statement is correct, and the price is best displayed by following one commitment through three consequences.

The commitment. The conscious witness is pure, self-luminous, inactive and changeless consciousness, wholly beyond the three qualities. Every productive function belongs to nature. This is not an incidental thesis: it is what the proofs of the witness establish and what makes liberation possible, since a really modified witness could never be restored.

First consequence: agency. Agency must be relocated entirely to nature's evolutes. The determinative intellect ascertains, the I-maker appropriates, the mind coordinates - and all three are insentient. What we experience as conscious agency is the two-way appearance: the insentient organ appears conscious, and the inactive witness appears to be an agent. Nyāya objects that an agentless self is otiose and makes its own self a substance with adventitious cognition, volition and effort. Sāṃkhya's reply is uncompromising: ascribing agency to the witness is precisely the false appropriation (**abhimāna**) in which bondage consists.

Second consequence: moral responsibility. If the witness never acts, it cannot straightforwardly own a moral career. Sāṃkhya secures desert through the stable association of one subtle stream with one numerically distinct witness. But this is asserted rather than derived, and it inherits the school's deepest difficulty: qualitatively identical witnesses have no stated principle of individuation, so the very individuality that moral ownership requires is the thing least well grounded.

Third consequence: rebirth. Transmigration must be relocated too. The subtle body - eighteen constituents: determinative intellect, I-maker, the eleven capacities including the mind, and the five subtle elements - carries dispositions and karmic tendencies, conditioned by the intellect's eight tendencies of merit and demerit, knowledge and ignorance, detachment and non-detachment, power and powerlessness. The gross body from parental material falls away. The witness neither acts nor literally migrates.

Assessment. The price is real but the purchase is deliberate. Inactivity buys a clean separation of phenomenal consciousness from cognitive processing, an intelligible account of liberation as correction rather than escape, and a non-theistic explanation of bondage. It costs an unowned agency, an ungrounded principle of individuation and a rebirth without a traveller.

Whether the price is too high depends on the prior question the schools actually divide on: whether consciousness may be described as doing anything at all.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Status of this block. Everything below is enrichment. No routed question in this topic requires it, and no answer in the practice sections above depends on it. The Basic Learning Session is independently answer-complete for every 10-, 15- and 20-mark demand recorded in the 2018-2025 corpus. Use at most one optional move in a fifteen- or twenty-marker, and place it in the evaluative paragraph after the standard argument chain is complete. Two optional moves is the ceiling; three is padding.

Prerequisite before this block is usable

Master, from the Basic block, the following: one primordial material nature and many conscious witnesses; the three qualities and their two modifications; the pre-existence of the effect in the form of real transformation; the evolution of the twenty-five principles; the five proofs for the witness; isolation as discriminative liberation; and Śaṃkara's critique as routed by the 2018-2025 questions. If any of these is shaky, the material below will make an answer look unfocused rather than deep.

ADVANCED MODULE 1 - What exactly does "proximity" mean?

The precise issue. If the conscious witness and primordial nature are utterly different in kind, and one of them is entirely inactive, what does their "proximity" actually amount to?

Competing readings. Summaries often slide into literal-contact language, which the system cannot afford. A subtler reading takes the relation to be epistemic or reflective conjunction rather than physical contact: what is "near" is not a body to a body but a light to a transparent medium.

Strongest extra objection. Without a real relation, the world-process never begins; a relation that changes nothing in either relatum does no work.

Counter-reply. Sāṃkhya typically relies on presence-for-the-sake-of-experience rather than mechanical interaction. The witness's efficacy is not productive causation but the mere presence that renders nature's activity experienced. Critics nevertheless continue to find the relation under-explained, and the honest advanced position is that this is a live difficulty rather than a settled reply.

Source trail. Īśvarakṛṣṇa, *Sāṃkhya-kārikā*; Vācaspati Miśra, *Tattvakaumudī*; Gerald James Larson, *Classical Sāṃkhya*.

How to use it in one line. "The relation is best read as reflective rather than physical conjunction, which preserves inactivity at the cost of leaving the initiation of evolution under-explained."

ADVANCED MODULE 2 - Can teleology survive without an intelligent principle?

The precise issue. Can unconscious nature evolve "for" the witness's experience and liberation without smuggling purpose in from elsewhere?

Competing readings. Sāṃkhya's internal teleology holds that nature serves the witness as a structural fact of the quality-arrangement. Nyāya and Vedānta press the opposite direction: purposive order points beyond unconscious matter to an intelligent orderer.

Strongest extra objection. Unconscious matter cannot pursue ends; "for the sake of" is either literal, in which case intelligence is implied, or metaphorical, in which case it explains nothing.

Counter-reply. Sāṃkhya treats teleology as structural rather than intentional - milk flows for the calf without deliberation - so "for the sake of" names a functional orientation, not an aim entertained by anyone.

Source trail. Īśvarakṛṣṇa, *Sāṃkhya-kārikā*; S. Chatterjee and D. Datta, *An Introduction to Indian Philosophy*; S. Radhakrishnan, *Indian Philosophy*, volume 2.

How to use it in one line. "Sāṃkhya's teleology is structural rather than intentional, which answers the charge of covert theism but not the charge that structural purposiveness is a description rather than an explanation."

ADVANCED MODULE 3 - Is the plurality of witnesses demonstrated or defensively postulated?

The precise issue. Are the arguments for many witnesses decisive, or partly introduced to preserve individual bondage and liberation?

Competing readings. The classical defence holds that diversity of births, deaths and moral trajectories implies plurality. Advaita presses that one consciousness can appear many through limiting adjuncts, so the inference from empirical difference to transcendental plurality is unlicensed.

Strongest extra objection. Plurality is inferentially weaker than Sāṃkhya claims, because every cited difference is available to the Advaitin as a difference of adjunct.

Counter-reply. The school can answer that moral individuality and non-simultaneous liberation become unintelligible on strict one-self models, so the postulate earns its place by what it explains, even if it cannot be independently demonstrated.

Source trail. *Sāṃkhya-kārikā*; Vācaspati Miśra; C. D. Sharma, *A Critical Survey of Indian Philosophy*.

How to use it in one line. "Plurality is best defended as an inference to the best explanation of non-transferable bondage and release rather than as a demonstration from the nature of consciousness itself."

What not to over-study

- Long textual-strata debates about every principle in the list.
- Specialist disputes on commentarial chronology, once the causation-proofs-liberation sequence is secure.
- The detailed later commentarial theism, exhaustive disposition cosmology and full Yoga practice taxonomies. These belong to other owners or to specialist study, not to a Sāṃkhya answer.

When this block would stop being optional

The advanced material would be promoted into core if a future question directly asked whether the witness-nature relation is coherent, whether Sāṃkhya's teleology presupposes an intelligent principle, or whether many witnesses are proved rather than postulated. Until then, the Basic block carries every routed demand on its own.

Three genuinely contested matters to report as contested

- Whether early Sāṃkhya was originally theistic or consistently non-theistic remains debated.
- Whether isolation is purely negative aloneness or has a positive phenomenological character is disputed.
- The relation between the Kārikā tradition and the later Sūtra tradition is historically and doctrinally contested.

Report these as disputes. Presenting any one of them as settled is a factual error, not a stylistic choice.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

What these notes are. Compressed revision material covering every subtopic taught above, in retrieval order rather than teaching order. They do not repeat the introductory prose of the sessions; they carry definitions, exact terminology, lists, comparisons, traps, answer routes and qualifications. The Basic/Optional-Advanced distinction is preserved: part N marks the enrichment boundary explicitly.

A. System identity and textual control

- Classical Sāṃkhya = the system of **Īśvarakṛṣṇa's Sāṃkhyakārikā***; commentaries: **Gauḍapāda, Vācaspati Miśra's Tattvakaumudī***.
- **Kapila -> Āsuri -> Pañcaśikha**: traditional lineage; foundational works not extant in securely recoverable form. Name them; do not quote them.
- **Sāṃkhyapravacana-sūtra + Vijñānabhikṣu** = later, often more theistic phase. Never project back into the Kārikā system.
- The name is connected both with **enumeration** and with **discriminative or right knowledge** - both senses fit liberation through knowledge of twenty-five principles.
- Orthodox (**āstika**) school, but **non-theistic (nirīśvara)**. Write "non-theistic" or "God-unproved", not "atheistic".
- Syllabus item 16, verbatim printed wording: Samkhya; Prakrit; Purusa; Causation; Liberation.
- Yoga is a **bounded comparison**, never a source: it owns the mind-field, afflictions, eight limbs, meditative absorption and God as a special witness.

B. Threefold suffering and the shape of the remedy

- **duḥkha-traya**: internal or psychophysical (**ādhyātmika**) · from other beings and material surroundings (**ādhibhautika**) · from cosmic or unseen agencies (**ādhidaivika**).
- Visible remedies are **partial**; ritual results are **produced and therefore exhaustible**. Not false - graded.
- A final cure must **correct a mistake**, not manufacture a state => knowledge, not action.
- Knowledge needs content => **enumeration of twenty-five principles**.
- Register line: *the system enumerates because it promises release by discrimination.*

C. Instruments of valid knowledge and the inferential burden

Item	Content
Admitted instruments	perception (pratyakṣa), inference (anumāna), reliable testimony (āptavacana / śabda)
Perception defined	ascertainment with respect to a presented object (pratiṣṭhāyādhyavasāya) through sense-capacities in contact
Inference, three kinds	pūrvavat (cause -> effect) · śeṣavat (effect -> cause) · sāmānyato-dṛṣṭa (general correlation, connection not itself perceived)
Standard example of the third	the sun seen in different positions => the sun moves
Testimony defined	word of a non-defective source, pre-eminently Veda/ śruti , where the object is not otherwise easily known
Reductions	comparison -> inference/testimony · postulation -> inference · non-apprehension -> perception's failure-conditions · inclusion -> inference · traditional report -> testimony when reliable

Item	Content
Causes of non-perception	excessive distance · excessive proximity · organ-defect · inattention · subtlety (saukṣmya) · obstruction · being overpowered · admixture with like things
Why the third kind is decisive	both ultimates are beyond the senses (atīndriya) ; testimony begs the question against non-Vedic opponents
Presupposition	a general correlation of kinds can license inference to an entity of a kind never observed
Objectors	Cārvāka (invariable relation cannot be secured) · Nyāya (legitimate but over-extended; atoms + God is more economical)

D. Cognition, reflection and apparent agency

- **Inner instrument (antaḥkaraṇa)** = intellect (**buddhi**) + I-maker (**ahaṃkāra**) + mind (**manas**).
- **Thirteenfold instrument (trayodaśa-karaṇa)** = 3 inner + 5 cognitive + 5 action capacities.
- Functions: intellect **determines** (final ascertainment, **adhyavasāya**) · I-maker **appropriates** ("I", "mine") · mind **coordinates**.
- External faculties = **doors (dvāra)**; inner organ = **doorkeeper (dvārin)**.
- Intellect is **sattva**-predominant => transparent => receives ****buddhi-pratibimba / puruṣa-cchāyā-āpatti****.
- Two-way appearance: the **insentient (jaḍa)** organ appears conscious; the inactive witness appears to be an agent.
- Result: **false appropriation (abhimāna)** = the psychological root of bondage.
- Register line: *knowing is processing plus borrowed light*.

E. Primordial material nature and its five proofs

- **prakṛti** = unmanifest, unconscious, uncreated, primordial material principle; ultimate material cause.
- Names: **pradhāna** (chief) · **avyakta** (unmanifest, versus **vyakta**) · **mūla-prakṛti** (root).
- Exam-safe definition: the **unmanifest chief principle constituted by the three qualities**.
- Scope: "material" means **unconscious**, not physical. Intellect, ego, mind, capacities, subtle and gross elements are all inside it.
- Needed because a changeless, inactive witness cannot become a changing world, and Sāṃkhya's realism forbids reducing the world to appearance.

#	Proof	Argues from	Delivers
1	bhedānām parimāṇāt	finitude, delimitation, measurability	a subtler ground beneath limitation
2	samanvayāt	order and common pattern across effects	a common material basis
3	śaktiṭaḥ pravṛtteś ca	operation through causal power (śakti)	a productive power adequate to all effects
4	kāraṇa-kārya-vibhāgāt	cause and effect as distinguishable stages	an unmanifest causal matrix
5	avibhāgāt vaiśvarūpyasya □	the diversified cosmos is one interconnected whole	nature must be ONE

- **Textual control:** *Sāṃkhyakārikā* 15 reads **śaktiṭaḥ pravṛtteś ca**, not *kāryataḥ pravṛtteḥ*
- power, not planning.

- **2019 bridge sentence:** plurality at the root would destroy the undividedness from which the inference proceeds.

F. The three qualities and their two modifications

Quality	Character	Affective tone	Function
sattva	lightness, illumination, buoyancy	pleasure	revelation, clarity, manifestation, knowledge
rajas	activity, restlessness, propulsion	pain	energy, stimulation, movement, mediation
tamas	heaviness, obstruction, inertia	delusion	concealment, resistance, fixation, density

- Not three substances - three **inseparable constitutive tendencies** of one nature, present together in every evolute in varying proportion.

- **Equilibrium (sāmyāvasthā)** => nature is **unmanifest**; disturbed => manifest evolution.
- **sarūpa-pariṇāma** = homogeneous, each quality within its own nature, occurs in equilibrium.
- **virūpa-pariṇāma** = heterogeneous, across qualities, generates the manifest evolutes.
- Disturbance = **functional activation in proximity**, not mechanical collision.
- 2021 demand covers **both** the triad and the two modifications.

G. The conscious witness and its five proofs

- **puruṣa** = pure consciousness, self-luminous, inactive, changeless, beyond the qualities.

Consciousness is **essence, not quality**. Witness, seer, experiencer (**bhoktr**) - not producer.

- Never bound in its own nature; never productive.

#	Proof	Core move
1	saṅghāta-parārthatvāt	aggregates are instrumental => they exist for a user distinct from them
2	triguṇādi-viparyayāt	the knower of pleasure, pain and delusion cannot be those same changing states
3	adhiṣṭhānāt	coordinated psychophysical life needs a presiding conscious locus - not a God-proof
4	bhoktr-bhāvāt	presented states require an experiencer distinct from them
5	kaivalyārthaṃ pravṛtteḥ	striving for release presupposes a liberable witness

- Shared premise: everything objective is **unconscious, instrumental and presented**.
- Shared form: **sāmānyato-dṛṣṭa anumāna**.
- Evaluation: cumulative, not isolated. Honest limit - they yield a subject-pole, not yet an eternal, plural, wholly inactive one.

H. Plurality of witnesses, purposive nature and the empirical self

- Plurality is **numerical, not qualitative**.
- **Sāṃkhyakārikā 18** supplies three arguments: fixed distribution of birth, death and faculties · non-simultaneity of activity · differential constitution by the qualities.
- **Differential liberation is supplementary**, not a fourth phrase of the verse.
- Presuppositions: empirical individuation transfers upward · the witness is genuinely an experiencer · liberation is particular · numerical plurality without qualitative difference is intelligible.

Objector	Objection	Reply	Residue
Advaita	differences are in limiting adjuncts (upādhi) => many mental streams (citta), not witnesses	bondage and release are non-transferable; reflection needs distinct loci	terminates in a clash of first principles

Objector	Objection	Reply	Residue
Nyāya	an inactive self cannot own moral desert	agency belongs to nature's evolutes; ascribing it is abhimāna	moral subject risks becoming empirical
Buddhist	a changeless actionless entity fails efficacy (arthakriyā)	efficacy is mere presence (sannidhi) , not production	non-productive efficacy may not be efficacy
Internal	what individuates qualitatively identical witnesses?	inferred from non-transferability of experience, bondage and release	the school's weakest joint

- **Purposive nature (puruṣārtha)** - four images: **milk flowing for the calf** (unconscious functioning serves an end) · **lame and blind** (sees but cannot act / acts but cannot see) · **the dancer who retires once seen** · **the modest woman who withdraws on being seen**.

- **Empirical self (jīva) is NOT a separate principle**. It is the witness as empirically conditioned through intellect, I-maker, mind, body and the karmic stream.

I. The twenty-five principles in exact order

prakṛti -> mahat/buddhi -> ahaṁkāra -> sāttvika line -> manas + 5 jñānendriya + 5 karmendriya
 +- tāmasa line -> 5 tanmātra -> 5 mahābhūta
 +- rājasa factor -> energises BOTH lines, produces NO new set
 puruṣa = 25th principle, NOT an evolute

No.	Principle
1	primordial nature (prakṛti)
2	the great one / determinative intellect (mahat / buddhi) - first evolute
3	I-maker (ahaṁkāra)
4	coordinating mind (manas)
5-9	five cognitive capacities: hearing, touch, sight, taste, smell
10-14	five action capacities: speech, grasping, locomotion, excretion, reproduction
15-19	five subtle elements: sound, touch, form, taste, smell potentials
20-24	five gross elements: ether, air, fire, water, earth
25	conscious witness (puruṣa) - non-evolute

- **Fourfold classification**: 1 cause-not-effect (nature) · 7 both (intellect, I-maker, five subtle elements) · 16 effects-only (mind, ten capacities, five gross elements) · 1 neither (witness).

- **Correspondence**: sound -> ether · touch -> air · form -> fire · taste -> water · smell -> earth.

- Do not import Advaita's fivefold grossification (**pañcīkaraṇa**).

- **mahat = buddhi**, one principle under a cosmic and an individual name. The I-maker derives from it.

J. Subtle body, transmigration and karma

- **liṅga-śarīra / sūkṣma-śarīra** = the continuing psychophysical vehicle between gross embodiments.

- Count: **18** = intellect (1) + I-maker (1) + eleven capacities including the mind (11) + five subtle elements (5).

- Conditioned by dispositions (**bhāva**) and the **eight tendencies of intellect**: merit/demerit · knowledge/ignorance · detachment/non-detachment · power/powerlessness.

- At death the **gross body from parental material** falls away; the subtle body carries dispositions

and karmic tendencies onward.

- **The witness neither acts nor literally migrates.** Transmigration belongs to the subtle body and the empirical self-complex operating for a particular witness.
- Pressure point: moral ownership rests on the **stable association** of one subtle stream with one numerically distinct witness - asserted, not grounded.

K. The pre-existent effect and the five arguments

- **satkāryavāda** = the effect pre-exists in its material cause; production is **manifestation (abhivyakti)***, not creation from non-being.

#	Argument	Standing example	Counter	Reply
1	asadakaraṇāt	no hare's horn; no oil from sand	Nyāya: equivocation between absolutely and not-yet non-existent	the not-yet effect must still be something determinate
2	upādāna-grahaṇāt	milk for curd; threads for cloth; mango seed not sand	restriction is explained by capacity	determinate capacity is latent presence
3	sarvasambhavābhāvāt	curd from milk, not from water	restriction comes from the constitution of causes	a constitution capable of only X is X latently
4	śaktasya śakya-karaṇāt	milk has potency for curd, not cloth	Nyāya: potency is relational	relational potency cannot explain determinacy
5	kāraṇa-bhāvāt	cloth is threads arranged; ornament and gold	Nyāya: the whole (avayavin) is a new substance	new properties are new arrangements (saṁsthāna)

- **Mango-seed formula:** latent effect + material continuity + real transformation. **Never** a miniature gross tree inside the seed.

L. Real transformation against the rival causal theories

Position	School	Core claim	Cause	World
pariṇāmaavāda	Sāṃkhya	transformation is real	primordial nature	real evolute
vivartavāda	Advaita	transformation is apparent	Brahman	ultimately appearance
asatkāryavāda / ārambhavāda	Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika	effect absent beforehand (prāgabhāva); production is a new beginning	material + efficient causes	a fresh product
pratītyasamutpāda	Buddhism	dependent arising without an enduring material root	conditions	a conditioned series

- **Shared premise with Advaita:** no being from non-being => both fall under a broad pre-existence orientation. **Decisive difference:** **pariṇāma** versus **vivarta**.

- Three standing objections and replies: effort pointless -> **manifestation**; cause/effect collapse -> difference of **state (avasthā)**; world always as now -> only the **capacity** is latent.

- Advaita reaction (2018): unconscious cause cannot be the scriptural cause · a really changing ultimate is mutable and dependent · superimposition explains dependence better.

- Sāṃkhya defence (2018): production is **selective** and only material continuity explains it · mutability disqualifies only a *changeless* ultimate · appearance-theory buys immutability at the cost of the reality of bondage and release.

M. Bondage, discriminative knowledge, isolation and non-theism

- **Bondage = aviveka**, non-discrimination; generated by reflection and stabilised as

abhimāna. Not a real alteration in the witness.

- **Liberation = viveka-jñāna**, the steady discrimination "I am not nature".
- **State = kaivalya**, isolation or aloneness. **Disentanglement, not merger, not annihilation.**
- **jīvanmukti** = liberation while the body continues by prior momentum - **potter's wheel**.

videhamukti = final cessation of embodiment.

- Strict formulation: the witness is **never really bound, liberated or transmigrating**; knowledge ends false attribution.

- **Goal names must not be interchanged**: isolation (Sāṃkhya) ≠ identity with Brahman (Advaita) ≠ cessation of suffering (Nyāya).

- **Five non-theistic arguments**: (1) a God acting from desire is neither perfect nor free; (2) an eternally fulfilled God has no motive to create a painful world; (3) distributing results under karma limits divine independence, arbitrary distribution destroys justice; (4) an immutable conscious God cannot be the material source of a changing unconscious world under Sāṃkhya's cause-effect continuity; (5) eternal witnesses plus primordial nature already explain consciousness and material evolution.

- Boundary caution: later theistic readings (Vijñānabhikṣu) must not be projected backwards; Yoga adds God as a special witness and owns the practical discipline.

N. The contact problem, Śaṅkara's critique, the answer route and the verdict

- **Problem**: an inactive witness and an unconscious nature can stand in no obvious real relation, yet evolution, bondage and liberation all presuppose one.

- **Sāṃkhya answer: mere proximity (sānnidhya)**, not gross contact; nature becomes active in the witness's mere presence.

- **Two analogies, two jobs: magnet and iron** = activation by presence; **crystal and flower** = apparent contamination without real change.

- **Śaṅkara's attack on the analogies**: a magnet **exerts force**, so the witness would not be wholly inactive; the crystal explains appearance but **not initiation**.

- **Why chief wrestler (pradhāna malla)**: (1) most sophisticated non-Vedāntic rival at the level of ultimate explanation; (2) real transformation is the nearest rival to apparent transformation; (3) both appeal to a single ultimate explanatory ground.

- **Four objections**: unconscious nature cannot be the Upaniṣadic cause · the contact problem is unresolved · teleology cannot rest on unconscious matter · knowing-cause texts exclude an insentient nature.

- **Pressed verdict**: the dualism is unstable - it collapses toward monism or needs a third mediating principle.

Four standing criticisms with replies.

Criticism	Reply	Residual force
teleology without intelligence	purposive functioning need not be conscious planning	vulnerable to Vedāntic pressure
relation between two absolutes	proximity, reflection, false attribution - not fusion	partly analogical; the weakest point
plurality of witnesses is unnecessary	non-simultaneous liberation and individual experience	the limiting-adjunct reply is unanswered

Criticism	Reply	Residual force
the pre-existent effect removes novelty	manifestation from latent to patent	Nyāya presses the new-whole objection

Debate axes for cross-school answers.

Axis	Sāṃkhya	Contrast
Self	many inactive witnesses	Advaita: one self · Nyāya: many active selves · Buddhism: no permanent self
Causation	pre-existent effect + real transformation	Nyāya: prior non-existence · Advaita: apparent transformation
World-process	rooted in enduring nature	Buddhism: dependent origination
God	non-theistic	Yoga, Nyāya, Vedānta: explicit God or Brahman
Liberation	isolation	Advaita: identity · Nyāya: cessation of suffering

PYQ answer route, 2018-2025.

Year · Q	Marks	Route
2018 Q5(e)	10	Kārikā 18 three arguments -> supplementary liberation argument -> Advaita adjunct objection -> non-transferability reply -> concede individuation
2018 Q7(b)	15	real transformation stated -> three-part Advaita reaction -> three-part Sāṃkhya defence -> shared premise -> clash of first principles
2019 Q5(d)	10	witness defined -> empirical self is not a principle -> reflection mechanism -> bondage as misattribution -> critical limit
2019 Q8(c)	15	name avibhāgāt vaiśvarūpyasya -> show the other four permit plurality -> bridge sentence -> Nyāya's refusal
2020 Q7(a)	20	latent-effect formula -> five arguments -> reject Nyāya, Advaita and Buddhism by name -> manifestation reply
2021 Q6(b)	15	triad with character, tone, function -> equilibrium -> homogeneous and heterogeneous modification -> trigger problem
2022 Q5(a)	10	five proofs -> shared premise and form -> cumulative evaluation -> honest limit
2023 Q5(b)	10	quoted relation problem -> proximity reply -> two analogies -> Śaṅkara on both -> instability verdict
2024 Q7(a)	20	full evolution tree and fourfold classification -> mahat = buddhi -> three functional roles
2025 Q7(a)	20	three grounds for the title -> four objections examined -> verdict on what the critique establishes
2021 Q5(a) routed	10	Nyāya "no" via prior non-existence -> Sāṃkhya "yes" via latent capacity -> equivocation charge -> first-principles verdict
2022 Q5(e) routed	10	partial agreement -> shared denial of production from non-being -> opposite commitments -> question-begging verdict
2023 Q8(b) routed	15	prior non-existence defined -> its defensive work -> the dilemma against Sāṃkhya -> Sāṃkhya's three replies -> relocation verdict

Trap ledger - twenty-four checkable errors.

1. Calling the threefold suffering a printed syllabus term.
2. Saying ritual means are false rather than exhaustible.
3. Citing Vijñānabhikṣu as evidence about the classical system.
4. Writing "atheistic" without the non-theistic qualification.

5. Giving Sāṃkhya four or six instruments of knowledge.
6. Saying Sāṃkhya *rejects* comparison or postulation instead of reducing them.
7. Treating imperceptibility as a refutation instead of invoking subtlety.
8. Calling general-correlation inference "vague inference".
9. Saying the mind determines or the intellect coordinates.
10. Describing reflection as a real modification of the witness.
11. Equating nature with matter as opposed to mind.
12. Naming proof 1 or 2 as the one-nature proof.
13. Reading *Sāṃkhyakārikā* 15 as *kāryataḥ pravṛtteḥ*, turning power into purpose.
14. Calling the three qualities three substances.
15. Stopping at the triad in a question that asks for modifications too.
16. Presenting the third proof of the witness as a God-proof.
17. Making consciousness a property of the witness.
18. Citing differential liberation as a fourth phrase of *Sāṃkhyakārikā* 18.
19. Treating the empirical self as a twenty-sixth principle.
20. Splitting the great one and the determinative intellect into two stages.
21. Giving the active quality its own product-set.
22. Counting the subtle body as seventeen by dropping the mind.
23. Defending the mango seed as containing a miniature gross tree.
24. Interchanging isolation, identity with Brahman and cessation of suffering.

Graded verdicts, ready to adapt.

- **Strong:** rigorously argued non-theistic realism; economical theory of qualitative variety; a causal thesis that explains determinate production and material continuity; an early separation of phenomenal consciousness from cognitive processing.
- **Weak:** the witness-nature relation is under-explained; unconscious teleology is difficult; individuation of attributeless witnesses is the weakest joint; the beginning of bondage is obscure.
- **Contested:** whether early Sāṃkhya was theistic; whether isolation is purely negative; how the Kārikā and Sūtra traditions relate.
- **10 marks:** one nature explains the world, many witnesses explain experience, discrimination explains liberation.
- **15 marks:** the power lies in the mutual fit of instruments, causation, qualities and isolation, though the contact problem invites Vedāntic criticism.
- **20 marks:** a philosophically serious non-theistic system whose causal realism and psychology of reflection are impressive, but whose unconscious teleology and plurality of attributeless witnesses remain unresolved.

Optional-Advanced boundary. Nothing in parts A-N above depends on the Optional Advanced block. That block adds only three enrichment moves - the precise meaning of proximity, whether teleology survives without an intelligent principle, and whether plurality is demonstrated or postulated - each usable as a single sentence in an evaluative paragraph.

COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

This is the terminal-friendly, data-complete master flow. It is authored separately from the graphical package and is validated against the same Basic, Advanced and previous-year ledger. The same fourteen panels are installed as a standalone text artifact and rendered as a standalone PDF.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 1/14: The controlling question and the shape of the remedy

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 1/14: The controlling question and the shape of the remedy

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SYLLABUS ITEM 16, PRINTED VERBATIM: "Samkhya; Prakrit; Purusa; Causation; Liberation."
normalised: Sāṃkhya · prakṛti · puruṣa · causation · liberation
|
CONTROLLING QUESTION ..... how can suffering be ended FINALLY and NON-RETURNINGLY?
|
+---- THREEFOLD SUFFERING (duḥkha-traya) – the exhaustive diagnosis -----+
| ādhyātmika    internal / psychophysical .... bodily disease, mental affliction |
| ādhibhautika  from other beings + surroundings ... humans, animals, environment |
| ādhidaivika   from cosmic / elemental / unseen agencies (traditional class)   |
+-----+
|
WHY ORDINARY EXITS FAIL
|
visible remedies (medicine, wealth, protection) -> relief is PARTIAL and decays
ritual / scriptural means -> the result is PRODUCED -> perishable -> repeatable
=> GRADED AS EXHAUSTIBLE, NOT DENOUNCED AS FALSE [trap 2]
|
THEREFORE the required remedy must be NON-PRODUCTIVE
it cannot manufacture a state; it must CORRECT A MISTAKE
correcting a mistake = KNOWLEDGE, not action
|
THEREFORE the knowledge must have CONTENT
"Sāṃkhya" is connected BOTH with ENUMERATION and with DISCRIMINATIVE/RIGHT KNOWLEDGE
=> the content is the TWENTY-FIVE PRINCIPLES (tattva)
|
+-----+
| ANSWER-GRABBING SPINE |
| Sāṃkhya is a soteriology forced to become a cosmology: a system promising release |
| by knowledge must first specify, exhaustively, what there is to be known. |
+-----+

! TRAP 1: do not present duḥkha-traya as a printed syllabus noun. It is the doctrinal
starting point that explains why the printed clause ends with "Liberation".
```

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 2/14: System identity and the textual ladder

Page 87

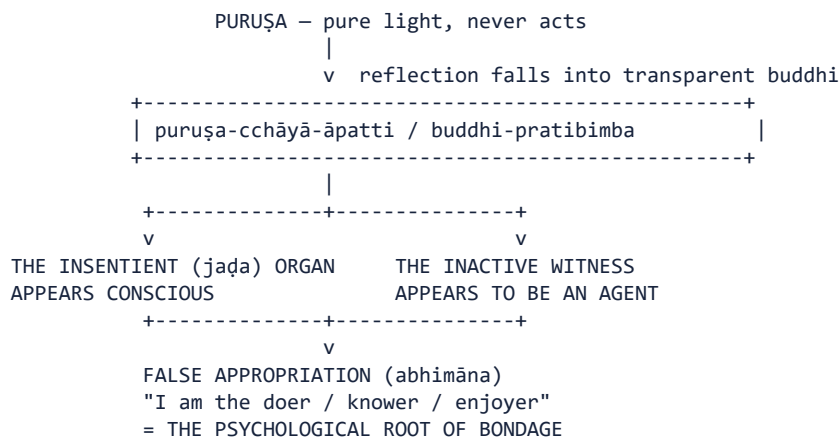
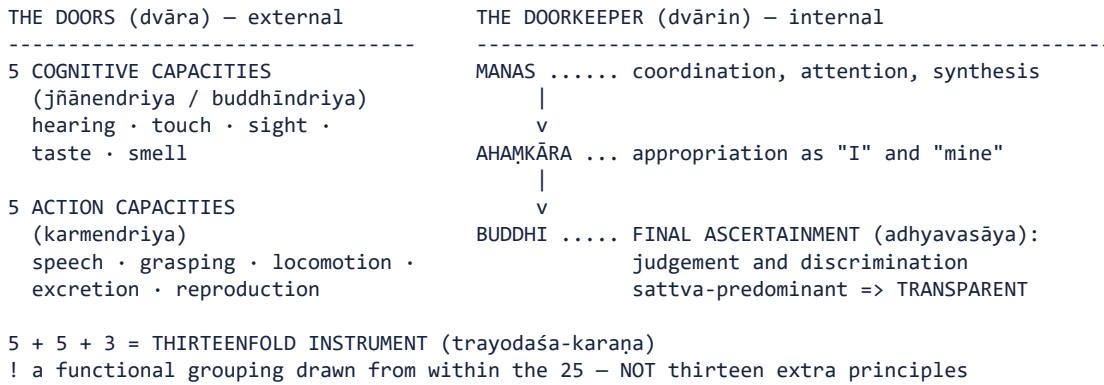
ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 3/14: Instruments of valid knowledge and the inferential burden

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 3/14: Instruments of valid knowledge and the inferential burden

ADMITTED – EXACTLY THREE	REDUCED – absorbed, NOT rejected [trap 6]
-----	-----
1 PERCEPTION (pratyakṣa) pratīviśayādhyavasāya: ascertainment with respect to a presented object through sense-capacities in contact	upamāna -> inference / testimony arthāpatti -> inference anupalabdhi -> perception's FAILURE-CONDITIONS sambhava -> inference aitihya -> testimony when reliable
2 INFERENCE (anumāna) – THREE KINDS pūrvavat antecedent/cause -> effect clouds -> rain śeṣavat effect/residue -> cause one drop -> the sea is salty sāmānyato-dṛṣṭa .. general correlation; the connection between the terms is NOT ITSELF PERCEIVED sun in different positions -> it moves	
3 RELIABLE TESTIMONY (āptavacana / śabda) word of a non-defective source, pre-eminently Veda/śruti, where the object is not otherwise easily known	
EIGHT CAUSES OF NON-PERCEPTION excessive distance · excessive proximity · organ-defect · inattention of mind · SUBTLETY (saukṣmya) · obstruction by an intervening object · being overpowered · admixture with like things => mūla-prakṛti's imperceptibility is assigned to SUBTLETY; puruṣa is likewise atīndriya rather than non-existent. IMPERCEPTIBILITY IS NOT ABSENCE [trap 7]	
+----- THE SELF-IMPOSED DEBT -----+	
both ultimates are BEYOND THE SENSES (atīndriya) -> perception cannot reach them	
testimony alone BEGS THE QUESTION against non-Vedic opponents	
=> THE WHOLE EVIDENTIAL WEIGHT FALLS ON SĀMĀNYATO-DṚṢṬA INFERENCE	
=> the five proofs of prakṛti and the five proofs of puruṣa ARE that payment	
+-----	
PRESUPPOSITION: a general correlation of KINDS can license inference to an entity of a kind never itself observed as a sense-object.	
OBJ Cārvāka: vyāpti cannot be secured for a term never perceived. REPLY: strict perceptualism cannot explain ordinary causal reasoning either.	
OBJ Nyāya: legitimate but over-extended – atoms + Īśvara is more economical. REPLY: adding God does not explain the MATERIAL CONTINUITY between cause and effect.	

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 4/14: Cognition, reflection and the two-way mistake

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 4/14: Cognition, reflection and the two-way mistake



ORDERING TO KEEP EXACT: reflection is a STRUCTURAL FACT -> appropriation is the ERROR
-> bondage is the CONSEQUENCE.
! TRAP 10: reflection must NOT be described as a real modification of puruṣa; a really
modified changeless principle could never be released.
ANSWER LINE: the intellect processes without awareness, the witness is aware without
processing, and a conscious thought is the borrowed light of the second on the first.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 5/14: Primordial material nature - names, scope, necessity

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 5/14: Primordial material nature – names, scope, necessity

PRAKṚTI = unmanifest, unconscious, uncreated, active primordial MATERIAL principle;
the ultimate MATERIAL CAUSE within Sāṃkhya's dualist ontology

NAME	EMPHASIS	ANSWER USE
-----	-----	-----
prakṛti	the productive nature of the principle	the general term
pradhāna	it is the CHIEF material principle	Śaṃkara's target in pradhāna malla
avyakta	UNMANIFEST before differentiation	contrasts with vyakta (manifest)
mūla-prakṛti	ROOT: cause of all, effect of none	fixes its place in the 1/7/16/1 grid

EXAM-SAFE DEFINITION: prakṛti is the AVYAKTA PRADHĀNA – the unmanifest chief principle constituted by the three guṇas.

WHAT THE RESERVOIR CONTAINS ! "material" here means UNCONSCIOUS, not physical [trap 11]

+-----+	+-----+	+-----+	+-----+
buddhi	ahaṃkāra	manas + 10	5 tanmātra -> 5 mahābhūta
intellect	ego-maker	capacities	subtle -> gross elements
+-----+	+-----+	+-----+	+-----+

=> THE FAULT-LINE IS NOT MIND vs BODY. It is EVERYTHING UNCONSCIOUS vs PURE CONSCIOUSNESS.

WHY A SECOND PRINCIPLE IS FORCED

- 1 the world shows plurality, transformation, dependence, purposiveness, structure
- 2 a school accepting REAL effects, REAL bondage and REAL liberation needs a REAL material source; it may not dissolve the world into appearance
- 3 puruṣa is CHANGELESS and INACTIVE => it cannot itself become the world
- 4 => an ACTIVE but UNCONSCIOUS second principle is required

ANSWER LINE: Sāṃkhya's dualism is misdescribed as mind against matter; intellect, ego and mind sit firmly inside unconscious nature, so the fault-line runs between everything that changes and the one thing that merely watches.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 6/14: The five proofs of nature and the one-nature verdict

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 6/14: The five proofs of nature and the one-nature verdict

#	PROOF	ARGUES FROM	DELIVERS
1	bhedānām parimāṇāt "from the finitude of things"	finitude, delimitation, measurability of effects	a SUBTLER GROUND beneath limitation
2	samanvayāt "from uniformity in effects"	order and common pattern across diverse products	a COMMON MATERIAL BASIS
3	śaktiṭaḥ pravṛtṭeś ca "from operation due to power"	operation through a cause possessing the relevant śakti	a PRODUCTIVE POWER adequate to the full range of manifest effects
4	kāraṇa-kārya-vibhāgāt "from the cause-effect distinction"	cause and effect as distinguishable STAGES (distinguishable ≠ unrelated)	an UNMANIFEST CAUSAL MATRIX distinct from the manifest order
5	avibhāgāt vaiśvarūpyasya * "from the undivided source of the diversified universe"	the diversified world is ONE INTERCONNECTED COSMOS	=> THE ROOT MUST BE **ONE** => THE 2019 Q8(c) ANSWER

WHY PROOFS 1-4 CANNOT DELIVER UNITY

several reservoirs could EACH be subtler than their products, EACH show pattern, EACH possess power and EACH differ in stage from their effects.
None of the four takes UNITY as a premise, so none yields unity as a conclusion.

THE BRIDGE SENTENCE THE EXAMINER WANTS [trap 12 if omitted]

the premise of proof 5 is the world's UNDIVIDED interconnectedness, so plurality at the root would FALSIFY THE PREMISE, not merely complicate the conclusion.

TEXTUAL CONTROL [trap 13]

Sāṃkhyakārikā 15 reads ŚAKTITAḤ PRAVṚTṬEŚ CA – from causal POWER and operation.
It does NOT read kāryataḥ pravṛtṭeḥ. Misreading it converts a non-theistic argument into a DESIGN argument, which would be fatal to a nirīśvara system.

HONEST LIMIT: the verdict holds within Sāṃkhya's own inferential licence; a Nyāya atomist traces interconnectedness to COORDINATION among many causes, not to one origin.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 7/14: The three qualities, their states and their modifications

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 7/14: The three qualities, their states and their modifications

GUṆA	CORE CHARACTER	AFFECTIVE TONE	FUNCTION IN EVOLUTION
SATTVA	lightness, illumination, buoyancy	PLEASURE	revelation, clarity, manifestation, knowledge
RAJAS	activity, restlessness, propulsion	PAIN	energy, stimulation, movement, mediation
TAMAS	heaviness, obstruction, inertia	DELUSION	concealment, resistance, fixation, material density

! TRAP 14: NOT three separable substances. Three INSEPARABLE CONSTITUTIVE TENDENCIES of one prakṛti, present together in EVERY evolvee in varying proportion.

TWO STATES OF THE SAME TRIAD

EQUILIBRIUM (sāmyāvasthā) the three in exact balance prakṛti = AVYAKTA (unmanifest) v	DISTURBANCE asymmetrical relations begin prakṛti = manifest evolution v
SARŪPA-PARIṆĀMA homogeneous: each guṇa transforms WITHIN ITS OWN NATURE => nature is dynamic even when unmanifest => dissolution is NOT annihilation	VIRŪPA-PARIṆĀMA heterogeneous: the guṇas transform ACROSS one another => ACTUAL COSMOLOGICAL EVOLUTION lives here => this is the mechanism of ALL causation

WHAT DISTURBS THE BALANCE

the MERE PRESENCE (sannidhi) of puruṣa – FUNCTIONAL ACTIVATION IN PROXIMITY,
NOT a mechanical collision and NOT an act of the witness.
=> this is the system's most exposed joint; see PANEL 14.

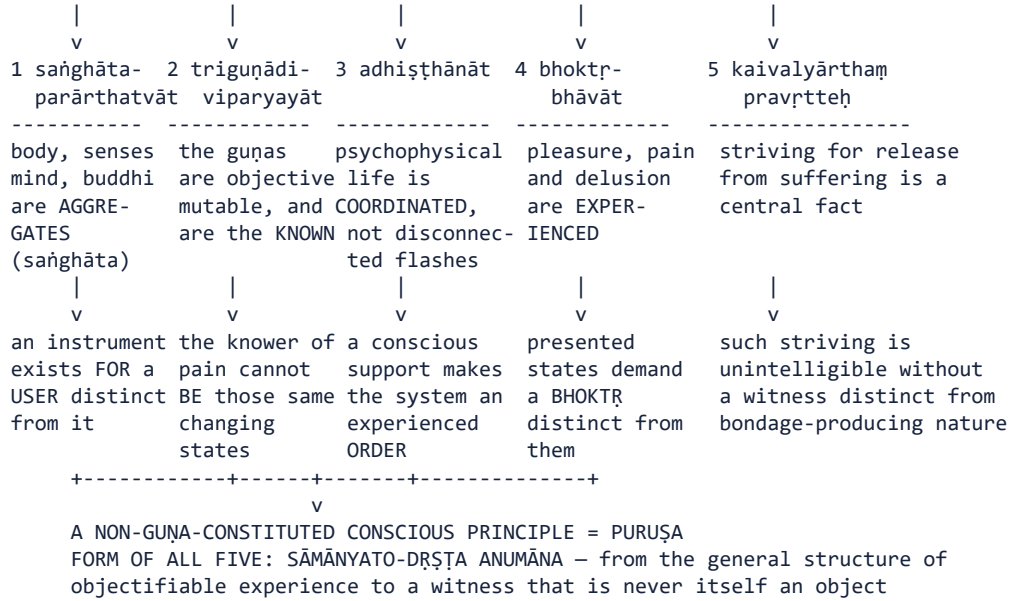
! TRAP 15: the 2021 demand is "three guṇas AND THEIR MODIFICATIONS" – stopping at the table forfeits roughly half the marks.

ANSWER LINE: one triad is made to explain physical constitution, affective tone and moral temperament together, so cosmology and psychology are not two subjects here.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 8/14: The conscious witness - nature and the five proofs

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 8/14: The conscious witness – nature and the five proofs

SHARED PREMISE OF ALL FIVE: the entire objective complex is UNCONSCIOUS (jaḍa), INSTRUMENTAL, and PRESENTED to experience.



! TRAP 16: proof 3 is NOT a God-proof. It infers a PRESIDING WITNESS OF LIVED ORDER.

NATURE OF PURUṢA consciousness = ESSENCE, not quality [trap 17]
 activity inactive, non-productive
 change changeless, immutable
 guṇas entirely beyond them
 status witness, seer, experiencer (bhoktr)
 => never bound in its own nature | never produces the world

EVALUATION (the 2022 directive): the proofs are CUMULATIVE, not isolated. Honest limit – they yield a SUBJECT-POLE, not yet an eternal, plural and wholly inactive witness.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 9/14: Plurality, purposive nature and the empirical self

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 9/14: Plurality, purposive nature and the empirical self

PLURALITY IS NUMERICAL, NOT QUALITATIVE – every puruṣa is equally pure consciousness

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+-- FROM SĀṂKHYAKĀRIKĀ 18 – write these THREE first -----+
| 1 FIXED DISTRIBUTION of birth, death and sense-faculties: one witness would make |
| one birth every birth, and all would be blind when one is blind |
| 2 NON-SIMULTANEITY OF ACTIVITY: beings act at different times and in different |
| ways; one self would make all embodied streams act together |
| 3 DIFFERENTIAL CONSTITUTION BY THE GUṆAS: beings differ as sattvic, rajasic or |
| tamasic in temperament => distinct centres of experience |
+-----+
+-- SUPPLEMENTARY – reinforcement only, NOT a fourth phrase of the verse [trap 18] -+
| 4 DIFFERENTIAL LIBERATION: release of one would be release of all |
+-----+

```

OBJECTOR	OBJECTION	REPLY	RESIDUE
Advaita	differences lie in LIMITING ADJUNCTS (upādhi) => at most many CITTAS, not many puruṣas	bondage and release are NON-TRANSFERABLE; reflection needs distinct loci	clash of first principles
Nyāya	an inactive self cannot own moral desert	agency belongs to prakṛti's evolutes; ascribing it is abhimāna	moral subject becomes empirical
Buddhist	a changeless actionless entity fails arthakriyā => unreal	efficacy = SANNIDHI (mere presence)	is non-productive efficacy efficacy?
Internal	what individuates qualitatively identical witnesses?	inferred from non- transferability	THE WEAKEST JOINT – concede it

TELEOLOGY (puruṣārtha): prakṛti acts FOR the witness – four canonical images
 MILK FOR THE CALF unconscious functioning can serve a purposive end
 LAME AND BLIND sees but cannot act / acts but cannot see
 THE DANCER retires once she has been seen
 THE MODEST WOMAN concealment ends on being seen

OBJ: unconscious teleology is incoherent. REPLY: purposive functioning need not be
 conscious PLANNING; the guṇa-structure unfolds in the witness's presence.

JĪVA IS NOT A SEPARATE TATTVA [trap 19] – it is puruṣa as empirically conditioned
 through buddhi, ahaṁkāra, manas, body and the karmic stream.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 10/14: The twenty-five principles in exact evolutionary order

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 10/14: The twenty-five principles in exact evolutionary order

PURUṢA (25th, NOT an evolute) --- mere presence (sannidhi) ---+

v
PRAKṚTI (cause of all, effect of none)

|

v

MAHAT / BUDDHI – FIRST EVOLUTE

cosmic name = mahat · individual name = buddhi

! ONE principle under TWO names – never two stages [trap 20]

|

v

AHAṂKĀRA – the principle of individuation

|

+-----+-----+-----+

v

SĀTTVIKA LINE

manas (mind)

5 JÑĀNENDRIYA

hearing · touch · sight ·

taste · smell

5 KARMENDRIYA

speech · grasping ·

locomotion · excretion ·

reproduction

v

RĀJASA FACTOR

supplies ENERGY and operative

force to BOTH lines

! produces NO separate set of
principles [trap 21]

v

TĀMASA LINE

5 TANMĀTRA

sound · touch · form

· taste · smell

|

v

5 MAHĀBHŪTA

ether · air · fire

· water · earth

CORRESPONDENCE: sound -> ether | touch -> air | form -> fire | taste -> water |
smell -> earth ! do NOT import Advaita's pañcīkaraṇa

COUNT: 1 prakṛti + 1 buddhi + 1 ahaṁkāra + 1 manas + 5 + 5 + 5 + 5 = 24 evolutes
+ 1 puruṣa = 25 PRINCIPLES

FOURFOLD CAUSE-EFFECT CLASSIFICATION – the fastest control on the whole list

cause but NOT effect prakṛti alone 1

BOTH cause and effect buddhi, ahaṁkāra, five tanmātras 7

effect ONLY manas, ten capacities, five mahābhūtas 16

NEITHER puruṣa 1

THREE FUNCTIONS TO KEEP APART (the 2024 second half)

BUDDHI determines / ascertains (adhyavasāya); transparent, receives reflection

AHAṂKĀRA ... appropriates as "I" and "mine"; false selfhood crystallises here

MANAS coordinates, attends, synthesises sense-data

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 11/14: Subtle body, transmigration and karma

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 11/14: Subtle body, transmigration and karma

```
+-----+
| DOES NOT MIGRATE                                     |
| PURUṢA – never acts, never moves, is never really bound, liberated or transmigrating |
| => transmigration in Sāṃkhya is NOT the journey of a soul [trap 24 guard] |
+-----+

+-----+
| MIGRATES: THE SUBTLE BODY (līṅga-śarīra / sūkṣma-śarīra) |
| the continuing psychophysical vehicle between gross embodiments |
| buddhi ..... 1 |
| ahaṃkāra ..... 1 |
| eleven capacities INCLUDING MANAS ..... 11 ! omitting manas gives 17 |
| five tanmātras ..... 5 [trap 22] |
| TOTAL = 18 |
|
| CONDITIONED BY dispositions (bhāva) and the EIGHT TENDENCIES OF BUDDHI: |
| merit <-> demerit knowledge <-> ignorance |
| detachment <-> non-detachment power <-> powerlessness |
| described as primordially arisen within the evolutionary cycle |
+-----+

+-----+
| IS DISCARDED: THE GROSS BODY – produced from parental material; falls away at death |
+-----+
```

THE PRESSURE POINT (state it; do not hide it)

moral ownership must be secured by the STABLE ASSOCIATION of one subtle stream with ONE numerically distinct witness. Sāṃkhya ASSERTS that association; it does not ground it. This is PANEL 9's weakest joint seen from the ethical side.

ANSWER LINE: Sāṃkhya buys the inactivity of consciousness by relocating rebirth – what travels is not a self but a disposition-bearing subtle body, so the school must then explain how a passive witness owns a moral career it never conducted.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 12/14: Causation - the pre-existent effect and the rival map

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 12/14: Causation – the pre-existent effect and the rival map

SATKĀRYAVĀDA: the effect PRE-EXISTS in its material cause; production = ABHIVYAKTI (manifestation), not creation from non-being. Sāṃkhya's specific form = PARIṆĀMAVĀDA.

#	ARGUMENT	EXAMPLE	COUNTER	REPLY
1	asadakaraṇāt a non-entity cannot be produced	no hare's horn; no oil from sand	Nyāya: equivocation between absolutely and not-yet non-existent	the not-yet effect must be SOMETHING determinate in the cause
2	upādāna-grahaṇāt a determinate material cause is taken up	milk for curd; threads for cloth; mango seed not sand	it is CAPACITY, not pre-existence	determinate capacity IS latent presence
3	sarvasambhavābhāvāt everything cannot arise from everything	curd from milk, never from water	restriction comes from the constitution of causes	a constitution capable of only X IS X latently
4	śaktasya śakya-karaṇāt the potent produces only the producible	milk has potency for curd, not for cloth	Nyāya: potency is a RELATIONAL property	relational potency cannot explain determinacy
5	kāraṇa-bhāvāt the effect has the being of the cause	cloth is threads arranged; ornament and gold	Nyāya: the whole (avayavin) is a NEW substance	new properties are new ARRANGEMENTS (saṃsthāna)

THREE STANDING OBJECTIONS: effort pointless -> production is MANIFESTATION | cause and effect collapse -> they differ by STATE (avasthā) | world always as now -> only the CAPACITY is latent, never the gross effect

DOES THE EFFECT PRE-EXIST IN ITS MATERIAL CAUSE?

YES (satkārya orientation)

SĀMĀNYA pariṇāma-vāda | ADVAITA vivarta-vāda
real transformation | apparent transformation
cause = prakṛti | cause = Brahman
world = real evolute | world = appearance
mechanism = guṇa-pariṇāma | mechanism = super-imposition

NO

NYĀYA asatkārya/ārambha | BUDDHISM
prāgabdhāva; new beginning | dependent
effect = a fresh product | arising,
continuity BROKEN | no root

=> SHARED PREMISE with Advaita; DECISIVE DIFFERENCE = PARIṆĀMA vs VIVARTA [trap 23]

! MANGO-SEED FORMULA: latent effect + material continuity + real transformation.

NEVER a miniature gross tree hidden inside the seed.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 13/14: Bondage, discriminative knowledge, isolation, non-theism

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 13/14: Bondage, discriminative knowledge, isolation, non-theism



ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 14/14: Contact problem, Śaṃkara, PYQ route and verdict

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 14/14: Contact problem, Śaṃkara, PYQ route and verdict

THE PROBLEM: puruṣa is INACTIVE and prakṛti is UNCONSCIOUS – what relation is possible?
Yet evolution, bondage and liberation ALL presuppose one.

SĀṂKHYA ANSWER: SĀNNIDHYA – mere PROXIMITY or PRESENCE, not gross physical contact.

MAGNET AND IRON explains ACTIVATION BY PRESENCE

CRYSTAL AND FLOWER ... explains APPARENT CONTAMINATION WITHOUT REAL CHANGE

ŚAṂKARA ON BOTH: even a magnet EXERTS FORCE => puruṣa would not be wholly inactive;
the crystal explains APPEARANCE but not the INITIATION of the world-process.

WHY SĀṂKHYA IS PRADHĀNA MALLA (chief wrestler) – systematic strength, NOT contempt

A most sophisticated non-Vedāntic rival at the level of ULTIMATE EXPLANATION

B pariṇāmavāda is the NEAREST RIVAL to vivartavāda

C both appeal to a SINGLE ULTIMATE EXPLANATORY GROUND – unconscious prakṛti vs
conscious Brahman => the contest is DIRECT, so refutation must be detailed

FOUR OBJECTIONS: unconscious prakṛti cannot be the Upaniṣadic cause | the contact
problem is unresolved | teleology cannot rest on unconscious matter | tajjña-type
"knowing-cause" texts exclude an insentient nature

=> PRESSED VERDICT: the dualism is UNSTABLE – it collapses toward monism or needs a
third mediating principle. A DEMAND FOR EXPLANATION, not a proof of Advaita.

PYQ ANSWER ROUTE, 2018-2025 (10 primary-owned + 3 routed)

2018 Q5(e) 10 .. Kārikā 18 x3 -> supplementary -> upādhi objection -> concede joint

2018 Q7(b) 15 .. real transformation -> Advaita x3 -> defence x3 -> first principles

2019 Q5(d) 10 .. puruṣa -> jīva is no tattva -> reflection -> critical limit

2019 Q8(c) 15 .. avibhāgāt vaiśvarūpyasya -> why 1-4 fail -> bridge -> Nyāya refusal

2020 Q7(a) 20 .. latent-effect formula -> five arguments -> reject 3 rivals by name

2021 Q6(b) 15 .. triad -> equilibrium -> sarūpa/virūpa -> trigger problem

2022 Q5(a) 10 .. five proofs -> shared premise and form -> cumulative -> honest limit

2023 Q5(b) 10 .. relation problem -> sānnidhya -> two analogies -> instability

2024 Q7(a) 20 .. evolution tree + 1/7/16/1 -> mahat = buddhi -> three functions

2025 Q7(a) 20 .. three grounds for the title -> four objections examined -> verdict

2021 Q5(a) 10 routed .. prāgabhāva "no" vs latent-capacity "yes" -> equivocation

2022 Q5(e) 10 routed .. shared premise -> opposite commitments -> question-begging

2023 Q8(b) 15 routed .. prāgabhāva -> its defensive work -> dilemma -> three replies

GRADED VERDICT

STRONG argued non-theistic realism · economical guṇa theory · a causal thesis
explaining determinate production · consciousness separated from cognition

WEAK the puruṣa-prakṛti relation · unconscious teleology · individuation of
attributeless witnesses · the obscure beginning of bondage

CONTESTED .. early theism? · is kaivalya purely negative? · Kārikā vs Sūtra traditions